Vow of Teeth

The Odiyan Contracts, Book 1

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Adult (18+). All characters are adults.

Chapter 1

The Kasavu Bride

Four exits. The stair behind her, the wall-walk running east, the wall-walk running west, and the drop to the pepper terraces, which only counted if she didn't mind breaking something.

Neela counted them again while the sun went down red behind the Kettamala rampart. Then she held out her left hand, because a man in a grey mundu was waiting to put a bangle on it.

"Your wrist," Devan said.

He didn't take it. He waited for her to turn it over. That was the first thing she noted about him: he asked before he touched.

The ridged scar lay pale on the inside of her wrist, the shape of a drawn-out thumbprint. Resin had made it, and a hundred nights like the one coming. His eyes stopped there for exactly as long as it took to decide not to ask. Then he slid the plain gold bangle over her hand and closed the hinge. The metal was warm from his palm. It covered the scar to the last ridge.

"It sits wrong," he said. "I had it made from a measure the council sent."

"It sits fine."

"You haven't tried to move your hand."

She flexed her fingers. The bangle slid a thumb's width and stopped. "Fine," she said again.

Something in his mouth might have been the start of a smile. It went nowhere. Behind them the whole fort stood in the last light, a few hundred faces in the courtyard below, and an old woman with a lamp stood closest of all, breathing hard through her nose.

*

Twelve.

That was the number she held under every other number. The twelfth contract, and she was Seventeen in a ledger a day's ride off, a girl in the book of the Resin House with a page that could be read aloud. Twelve contracts earned release. Release meant the page burned and a birth name handed back to her. She had never known that name. Not one syllable of it.

The Monkey Pass closed in about forty days. The rains came and sealed the cart road, and nothing she did after that would matter to anyone who'd paid for it.

So: forty days. A man in a high west room. A fort with one great gate and sixty-odd soldiers. A wedding that cost somebody a great deal of money.

"Thirty-two," the old woman muttered, close enough to be heard, far enough to pretend she hadn't been. This was Janu, steward of the fort, who had been dabbing at her eyes with the end of her shawl since the first vow. "Thirty-two, and thin as a pepper vine in drought. I told him. I said, you'll eat at your own wedding, and look."

"Janu," Devan said, not turning.

"And her." Janu's whisper climbed. "Twenty-seven and not one word. Not a word through the whole rite. A girl that quiet is either holy or sulking."

"Neither," Neela said.

Janu's mouth shut with a click. Devan looked at the sky, and the corner of his mouth moved again.

"Then you can speak," he said.

"When there's something worth saying."

"I'll note it," said the warden of Kettamala, "for the council."

*

The feast ran long, as feasts did.

Neela sat on the dais in her ivory kasavu, its gold border heavy across her shoulder, and collected names. It was an old habit and a stupid one, and she had never been able to put it down. The guild had given her a number. The least she could do was refuse to give the same to anyone else.

Kannan was the goat-boy, nine or ten, plastered against a pillar with a garland he'd been told to carry and had clearly decided to keep. Chinna ran the kitchen door, a broad woman who slapped the leaf plates down like a judge handing out sentences. Raiu held the corridor torch outside the warden's chamber, a young guard with a bad haircut and an excellent memory for who had gone past him and when.

Four exits from the rampart. Seven from the hall, if you counted the roof. She counted the roof.

Devan ate little. She watched him do it. He moved rice from one side of his leaf to the other and spoke to nobody who wasn't brought to him. When a captain with a laugh like a dropped pot clapped him on the shoulder, he allowed it the way a man allows weather.

"Captain Muthu," he said, when she asked. "My second."

"Does he sleep in the fort?"

"Yes. Do you want his hours?"

She hadn't expected that. "Do you offer them to everyone?"

"Only to people who ask." He took a mouthful of rice, chewed, swallowed. "Mostly he's in the lower barracks. He wakes me for the dawn watch, twice a week. He will not tonight."

"No," Neela said. "I suppose he won't."

Later, when the lamps burned low and the singing had turned to the kind that needed no words, he walked her down the corridor to the warden's chamber. Raiu stood at the turning with his torch.

"Thank you, Raiu," she said. "Mind the draught by the stair. It'll gutter your flame."

The young guard flushed to the ears and said something that wasn't quite a word.

Devan had stopped. He didn't stop for much, but he'd stopped for this. He looked at Raiu, then at her, and the careful flatness of his face gave way to something she could only call attention.

"Nobody presented him to you," he said. "You never went near him at the feast."

"No."

"He's been on this corridor since dusk. How did you learn his name so fast?"

She could have said that Janu said it. She could have said she'd overheard. She said, "How long did it take you to learn it?"

He was silent a moment. Raiu looked at the ceiling.

"Four months," Devan said at last. "I had to ask twice."

"Then ask me again tomorrow," Neela said, and went into the chamber ahead of him.

*

She'd meant to be quicker about it. But the guild's rule was to learn a room before you needed it, and she stood just inside the door and did that while he latched it behind them.

A high room, whitewashed over laterite. One broad bed. A low lamp, sesame-scented, on a stand. A brass kindi beside the pillow, its spout bright. A sword on a rack and nothing else on the wall. And across from her, taking up the whole west side, two tall teak shutter leaves, closed against the dark.

Behind the shutters, she knew, was a ledge broad enough for a crouching body. The guild's drawings had said so. They hadn't said the wood was old and the ledge worn smooth by weather.

Chathu's voice came to her then, the way it did when she was careful and alone. It was soft as always, the patient voice of a man reading her a

column of figures she had no choice but to accept. *Like a leopard kill, child. Throat and floor, and tell the rest as the beast would. And not before the marriage writ comes back sealed from Kodiyur, mark that. Not after the rains. The buyer is particular.*

The tooth was sewn into her waistband. It was a real one, yellow and worn, and she was to leave it in the wound. It pressed against her hip bone, a small hard question.

"You can ask," Devan said.

She turned. He'd taken off the wedding cloth and stood in his plain mundu, shoulders square, looking at her across the width of the room as if it were a distance he intended to respect.

"Ask what?"

"Whatever you've been counting since you came in." A pause. "You do count. Your lips move."

Damn. "How many guards on the stair at night?"

"Two on the west stair. Four at the padippura. Six on the wall, in pairs, changing at the cistern chain."

"The chain?"

"It clanks on the hour. They change on the third clank after the middle watch."

She stared. "You're telling me."

"You asked."

"You're the warden. Wouldn't you rather I didn't know?"

"I would rather you asked me than found it out." He said it flatly, without warmth, which made it somehow harder to dismiss. "Is there anything else?"

She made herself ask the real question, wrapped in a harmless one. "Why did you agree to this? A bride from a Kodiyur pepper house you've never met."

"The council pressed the match. I couldn't refuse without saying why." He stopped. "I won't answer the rest of that."

"Which rest?"

"The why."

It wasn't comfort. It wasn't even courtesy, exactly. It was a closed door with a plain label on it, and she found, to her annoyance, that she would rather have that than a smooth lie.

"The shutters," she said. "Do they stick?"

"The third slat creaks." He glanced toward the window. "I've never fixed it."

"Why not?"

"I like to know when the wind comes in."

It was an answer, and it told her nothing. She filed that away, too.

The bed was wide. There was no way to ask which side he took without the question meaning something, so she looked at the floor. He said, "The left is mine," and went around to it without looking at her. She sat on the right, where the lamp's reach ended. Her hands lay in her lap, the left one heavy with gold.

Then he did something she hadn't planned for.

He took the sword down from its rack. He drew it half an inch, checked the edge with his thumb, and slid it home. He knelt and laid it on the floor on her side of the bed, along the edge of the sleeping-mat, with the hilt toward her hand.

"What is that for?" she said.

"I sleep badly."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's what I'm going to say." He rose and went round to his own side. "If you wake and find me restless, don't touch me. That's all."

She looked at the hilt. Plain wire grip, worn at the thumb. It lay within reach of her right hand, and he had put it there with his own, in front of her, with the lamp still lit.

Either he was a fool, or he wanted her to think so, or he wanted to see what she did with it. Chathu had taught her which of those to bet on.

"Good night, Devan," she said.

"Good night, Neela."

He pinched the lamp himself. Dark rushed in, with the smell of hot oil and a draught from the third slat.

*

She lay on her back and counted his breaths.

One to ten, steady. Eleven to forty, slowing. By a hundred he had gone still in the particular way of a man who has given up fighting the dark and let it put him down. Twice his breath snagged and smoothed. At two hundred and twelve there was a catch, a hitch like a bucket knocking a well-wall, and she held every muscle until it passed.

Two hundred and sixty. Two hundred and ninety. Three hundred.

Not yet. She gave him thirty more, because thirty was cheap.

There was no choosing tonight. The guild kept a watcher in the pass village, and every dawn he walked the hill edge and read which of an odiyan's marks had gone fresh. A first night with none read as refusal. Refusal went to Chathu, and Chathu answered refusal with a balance sheet. So the other one had to be on the hill before light, and Neela had to get her there past a sleeper.

She rose slowly, one hand flat on the mattress to take the weight, and stepped over the hilt of his sword. It stayed where he'd left it. He did not stir.

The floor was cold. She crossed it in her bare feet and stopped at the west window with the dark all round her and her pulse in her ears. The shutters were old teak, oiled and dark, held only by an iron latch. The long teak bar hung unused on its hooks beside them. A man who expected nobody at his window, then. She lifted the latch, eased the first shutter, then the second.

The third slat she did on purpose. She laid two fingers on it and leaned, and it creaked, a small dry crack like a knuckle. Better to learn now, with her clothes on, whether the sound woke him. She stood with her hand on the frame and counted twenty. Behind her the breathing went on, long and even, unbroken.

Asleep, she told herself. *He's asleep.* And she believed it, because she needed to, which was the kind of belief she'd been trained not to trust. A

man who has trained himself to sleep awake does not change his breathing either.

Beyond the shutters lay the ledge and the night. The sky was black and full of stars, and the wind came up from the pass smelling of wet red laterite and pepper leaf. Somewhere below, the cistern chain clanked the hour. A dog barked once and was hushed.

She slid the bangle off her left wrist and set it on the sill. It was still warm. For a moment she looked at it, a small round weight of gold that a stranger had closed around her like a promise. Then she took the corked flask from the fold of her cloth and drew the stopper.

The smell struck first. Scorched tamarind and pine sap, bitter as a mouthful of ash. It was the smell of the Resin House and of every night she had ever been good at her work. It was the smell of being useful.

She shrugged off the wedding cloth and folded it on the sill. The wind raised gooseflesh along her arms.

One rule Chathu had drilled harder than the knife. Anyone whose eyes were on her for the next minute became a witness. A witness needed one word, said in her hearing while she wore the other shape and the night still held, and she would wear it for life. She already carried two witnesses, Chathu and Ammu, the way she carried her own name for the dead. A third would hold a cage in his mouth every night she slept under his roof. If the man behind her was awake, that was what she was handing him.

She tipped the flask against her fingers and the resin ran black and slow. She drew it across the ridged scar on her right wrist, then the left, then up the line of her throat where the oldest marks lay.

For a breath, nothing.

Then the burn took her.

It came in like a hot wire drawn through each scar, from wrist to elbow, from throat to sternum, and she bit down on her own lip until she tasted blood. She had done this a hundred times and never once grown used to it. Heat crawled up her arms. Her knees went, and she caught the sill. The stars smeared. Her vision narrowed to a long dark tunnel with

the wind at the end of it, rich with a thousand smells she had no name for.

Behind her, in the room she'd mapped, a man lay breathing or pretending to.

Her spine began to bend.

Chapter 2

What the Warden Saw

Devan had been ready for a knife.

He lay on his left side with one hand open on the sheet, because a fist wakes the whole body, and he counted her breaths past three hundred. He had built the night to give her every chance. The sword on her side of the floor, hilt toward her hand. The lamp pinched out by his own fingers. A man asleep, a wife awake, and the council's gift laid out like a plate.

She stepped over the sword.

Her eyes never went to it. She stepped over it the way a woman steps over a sleeping dog, and crossed the floor without a sound, and he understood that whatever she had been sent to do, it would not be done with steel.

Through his lashes he watched her lift the latch on the west shutters. The third slat creaked. He kept his breath long and slow. She stood very still for a count of twenty, and he gave her nothing to hear.

Then she set the wedding bangle on the sill and uncorked a flask.

The smell reached him across the room. Scorched tamarind, pine sap, something bitter underneath. He had smelled it once before, from a sealed jar passed hand to hand in a cold classroom when he was twenty and being taught what to do about people like her. He had not expected to know it at once.

She folded the kasavu on the sill. She drew black resin over her wrists and up her throat, where the old scars lay in pale rows, and for a breath she did nothing at all.

Then she bit her lip, and it began.

He had been told it took about a minute. He had not been told what a minute was. She braced both hands on the stone and her back bowed, and the bones of it moved under the skin like something turning over in sleep. Her fingers spread and shortened. Her shoulders rolled forward. A sound came out of her that was not a cry, only breath forced through a closing throat. Gold came up through her skin in patches, then in spots, dark rosettes on a pelt that rose over her ribs like water filling a footprint.

It was the most private thing he had ever seen. He did not look away. That was the job, and it was also the crime.

At the end of the minute a leopard crouched on his window ledge.

It was long and heavy, too big for the stone and perfectly at home on it. The tail hung once, then drew up. Its head came round slowly toward the bed. Two eyes caught what starlight there was and held it, green and flat, and the nostrils worked.

Devan lay like a man carved on a tomb.

The cat looked at him for three heartbeats. He counted them because counting was all he had. Then it gathered itself, flowed over the edge of the ledge, and vanished into the dark.

The bangle sat on the sill beside the folded cloth, small and bright, with nobody to wear it.

*

He did not say it.

Not aloud, not under his breath, not shaped on his lips. He lay with his tongue pressed flat behind his teeth like a man holding a coal, and made himself go through the lesson in order, because the lesson was all that stood between him and the thing he wanted to do.

Anyone who watches an odiyan turn, at dusk or at dawn, with his own eyes, is her witness. Not the one who sees only the beast. The one who sees the change.

A witness who speaks her night-shape aloud, while she is in shape and before dawn and in her hearing, cages her. She stays that animal for life. Her mind goes out over about a year, like a lamp left without oil.

Intent does not matter. The instructor had said it three times, tapping the table. Anger cages her. A joke cages her. A fever or a word spoken in sleep cages her all the same, and nothing on earth undoes it.

Devan was a witness now. He had a live weapon in his mouth, and he was going to carry it to bed beside the woman it was made for.

When the cistern chain clanked the next hour, he rose. He went to the window barefoot and stood in the dark beside the open leaf of the shutter, where he would be hidden until she reached the ledge. The air smelled of wet laterite and pepper. Below, the terraces lay silver and empty. There was no sound at all, which he supposed was the point of her.

Then he sat down on the cold floor with his back to the wall, and waited, and let himself think about the west stair.

*

Asha, his sister, his second on this wall, had left notes on his table, under his cup, inside his boots. *Eat something.* She had been twenty-two and fast and funny, and afraid of exactly one thing, which was the dark.

They found her at the foot of the west stair. The wounds were a bear's. Shoulder to hip, deep, the work of claws as long as his fingers.

There were no bears inside the walls of Kettamala. No bear could have come up the cliff, or through the padippura, or past two men on the stair. He had stood in her blood that morning and counted the gates one by one, and when he reached the end of them, he had known what kind of thing had done it. Someone had paid. Something had worn a bear for a night, then put on a face and walked away.

Six years. And now one of them slept, or didn't sleep, in his bed.

His hands had closed on his knees. He opened them.

It would be so easy. She would come back along the ledge in the grey, a beast with a woman's mind caught inside it, and he would be standing there. One word. He could watch her understand it. He could watch her stop being anyone.

The rage was not hot. It was cold and level and quiet, and it felt like clear thinking, which was why he distrusted it.

*

He got up, crossed the dark room to where the sword lay by the bed, and carried it back to the wall. He sat with it across his knees and made himself think properly.

A caged odiyan tells nothing. If he caged her, he would own a handsome animal and no answers, and he had married her for answers. Someone on the council had pressed this match, and tokens with genuine council wax were going out through the Monkey Pass to Thurai. A woman who could speak could be made to say. A cat on a chain could only be looked at.

Muthu would want her dead, cheerfully, on the day, by every rule of the border. Devan's thumb found the worn place in the sword's wire grip and rubbed it, slowly, as he weighed that answer. By the rules Muthu would be right.

And the buyer was watching. If Devan caged her, the buyer would learn she had failed and send someone he would not recognise. If he kept silent, the buyer must come asking why the warden still lived, and he wanted to see who came.

He did not follow her onto the hill. A leopard in her own dark would hear him inside fifty paces, and a man who trailed her was a man who had already decided to hunt. He would let her go, and see what she did with the night.

Under all of it, where he did not usually look, lay the real reason, older than the council or the wax.

His hands could end a man in a breath. He kept them closed. Eight years he had kept them closed, and there was a reason, and the reason had a face, and he did not think about it in the dark. He did not spar. He did not strike first. He gave orders to men who did, and he drilled alone at dawn, so the one thing he was good at would never be pointed at a living person. Power was safe in his keeping because he did not use it.

The word was the same. One sentence, and he would be a man who had used it.

Not safe, then. Merely not spent.

*

The chain clanked the last hour of the night. Grey crept up behind the pass, thin as milk in water.

Stiff in the knees, he stood a moment at the window with his hand on the sill, near the bangle.

The wind swung the open leaf of the shutter, and the third slat began to complain.

He caught it. He laid his palm flat against the wood, as he would on a horse's neck, and held it until the wind dropped and the sound died in his hand. He left the shutters exactly as she had left them. She would come back to the room she had mapped, with nothing moved.

Across the floor, the bed waited. He set the sword down where it had lain, hilt toward her hand, and lay on his left side with his palm open on the sheet, and lowered his lids to a crack.

She came back with the light.

A shape on the ledge first, low and tired, one paw set after another along the stone as if the stone were hot. The leopard folded down onto its belly and lay there, flanks heaving. Then the pelt began to go.

It went the way it had come, and slower. Spots thinned and ran together and faded to skin. The long spine drew in. A shudder went through the whole animal, and then there was a woman on the ledge on her hands and knees, her hair stuck dark to her neck.

The shaking was not slight. Her arms would not hold her, and she let herself down onto her side on the stone and lay with her knees drawn up, breathing through her teeth. The scars at her throat stood out wet and pale. He had a good view of them. He wished he didn't.

Small. That was the thing he had not planned for. All night he had thought of her as an edge, and the thing on the ledge was a person who had not eaten since the feast and had just been turned inside out. She crawled to the sill. She dragged the folded kasavu around herself with fingers that kept missing the cloth, and her wrist, when she reached for the bangle, tilted toward the light.

She put the gold on. It slid over the scar to the last ridge, the way he had made it do. She held that hand against her chest with the other one, hard, for a count of ten.

Then her head came round toward the room.

Devan shut his eyes.

He heard the cloth whisper. He heard bare feet on the cold floor and the shutter drawn home, and the third slat gave its dry crack as it closed. He kept his breath even and slow and let it drag a little at the end, the way a sleeper's does. She stopped, and he felt her stop. It was a long way to the bed.

Then the mattress dipped on the far side, and a body lowered itself into the dark as carefully as if the bed were made of glass. She lay with her back to him. She was still shaking. He could feel it through the frame.

She did not touch the sword.

*

The chain clanked dawn.

He rose without waking her, which was not hard, because she was past waking. She lay on her side with the sheet to her chin and one hand fisted under her cheek, the bangle bright against the pillow. He stood a moment looking at her, taking in what he saw, the way a man takes inventory of a debt.

Witness, he thought, and did not say.

The corridor was grey and cold. Raiu had gone off watch, and Janu was on the other side of the door with a brass pot of water and her mouth already set for scolding. She stopped. She looked at his face.

"You didn't sleep," she said. "I knew it. A man doesn't sleep in his own wedding bed. He lies there like a log, thinking of the pass."

"Janu."

"Don't *Janu* me. I raised you." She pushed the pot at him. "She is thin. Thinner than you. She sat at that feast and ate two bites of rice and left the rest, and I watched, I watched the whole time."

"I know," he said. "Leave rice in the chamber."

Janu's mouth stayed open for a moment, which had not happened in his life.

"Rice," she said.

"And plantains. A good many of them. Set it on the low table, where it can be seen from the bed." He took the water pot. His voice was perfectly level. "I'm hungry."

"You," said Janu. "Hungry."

"Is that so strange?"

"It is the first time since Asha." She put a hand flat on her chest as if to hold something in. Her eyes were suddenly wet. "The wedding. I said it would do him good. Didn't I say? Rice and plantains, and a little jaggery, and I'll find the good ghee."

"Thank you."

"Hunger," she said, almost to herself, and went down the corridor with her shawl flapping, already shouting for Chinna.

Devan stood with the water in his hands and the door shut at his back.

He had never lied to Janu. He had not known he could do it so well.

The door opened without a sound. She had not moved. He set the pot down and crossed to the shutters, where the long teak bar hung on its hooks, as it had hung unused all his life. He lifted it free. It was heavier than he remembered.

It would go across the shutters at dusk, before any servant could stand where he had stood.

He leaned it against the wall beside the window, within reach, and looked once at the low table where the rice would go.

Chapter 3

Closed Shutters

Her hands would not hold still.

Neela woke on her side with the sheet at her chin and a hollow where her stomach should be, as if someone had scooped her out with a spoon. Weak tea light leaked through the shutters. The left side of the bed was empty. She held her fingers up in front of her face and watched them tremble.

The morning after. Eleven years of it, and her body still treated each one like news.

She sat up too fast. The room tilted, righted itself, and showed her the low table by the wall. A banana leaf lay on it, heaped with rice, a stack of plantains, a dark knob of jaggery, and a spoon of ghee going gold at the edges. A brass pot of water stood beside it, beaded with cold.

Janu, she thought. The old woman had stared at her plate all through the feast.

Neela meant to cross the room like a person with all day. She got there in four steps and went down on her knees. The rice was hot. She ate with her right hand, fast, ghee running to her wrist, and did not taste a grain of it. At the Resin House the orphans had eaten in rows, and the child who slowed was the child who got less. Nobody had told her that eating was a weak thing to be caught at. Nobody had needed to.

The door opened.

Janu stood there with a basket on her hip. Neela's hand stopped halfway to her mouth, and her face went flat and polite. It was a useful trick. It did nothing for the rice on her chin.

"Thank you for this," she said, when she could. "It was kind."

Janu looked at her for a long moment. Her mouth opened, then shut. "Well," she said. "Somebody had to feed you." She set down a second leaf, and a third plantain, and did not say another word about it. "Wash. Then I'll show you the fort. A warden's wife who can't find the privy is no use to anyone."

Neela washed. Her hands steadied somewhere around the second mouthful of plantain. She counted it as a small debt owed, and filed it where she kept the others.

*

The tour began at the pepper terraces, which Janu introduced as if they were relatives.

They climbed in steps up the inner slope, each terrace a ledge of red earth walled in laterite, and every ledge was green. Vines wound up their stakes with the berries hanging in tight strings, unripe and hard. The smell of crushed leaf was sharp enough to sting. A small boy sat on the third wall with a stick across his knees and six goats arranged around him like a council.

"Kannan," Neela said.

He nearly fell off the wall. "You know my name?"

"You carried the garland." She held out her hand. "Is the white one yours?"

"She's Pepper. She bites."

"Then I'll stand back."

Janu made a noise like a kettle. "Don't encourage him. He's learned two new words since the wedding and both of them are about you."

Neela looked at the boy and the goats and the walls, and kept walking. She kept count as she went. Gaps in the laterite where a person could drop from one terrace to the next. A drain big enough for a child.

Two guards on the upper wall who passed each other at the far end every hundred and ten steps, and turned on the same foot.

The cistern stood at the heart of the fort, a great iron-banded tank under a tiled roof, with a wheel and a chain thick as her forearm. A bent man in a faded mundu heaved a lever as they came up. The chain went over the drum and the sound hit the courtyard like a dropped anvil, and every pigeon in the fort went up at once.

"That's the hour," Janu shouted over it. "Gopan keeps it. Nineteen years, and he hasn't missed one."

"Not once?" Neela said.

"Once," said Gopan, with dignity. "In the fever year."

She learned the day watch changed on the sixth clank after dawn. She learned Gopan's knees hurt in the damp. She learned the sergeant on the gate was called Bhaskaran, and the thin guard at his side was Unni, and that Unni's mother sold salt fish in the lower village and had opinions about wardens.

The kalari lay below the east wall, a sunken pit with its lip worn smooth by sitting. Sesame oil lamps stood in niches around the rim, unlit now, their wicks black. The red earth inside had been swept in long arcs. In the middle was one set of bare footprints, sharp as a seal in wax.

Only one.

"Every day before light," Janu said. She was looking at the pit, not at Neela. "Eight years. He used to have a partner. Now he has the earth." She sniffed. "I stopped asking him."

Neela stood at the lip and looked at that single trail of steps. It went round and round. It never crossed itself. A man who drilled like that, alone, with no one at his back, had decided something about his hands.

That was worth knowing. It was only worth knowing.

The padippura came last, the roofed gatehouse with its great double door and its four guards in a row. Neela said all four names. Captain Muthu came ambling out from the guard room with a laugh already in his mouth.

"The lady knows my men better than I do," he boomed. "I'll have to ask her their mothers' names."

"Unni's sells fish," Neela said.

Muthu's laugh broke in the middle. Then it came back, bigger than before. "Janu, she's going to run this fort."

"Pity the fort," said Janu, and meant it kindly.

*

She found him in the afternoon on the highest terrace, with his back to her and a handful of green berries in his palm.

Janu had been summoned by a scream from the kitchen. Neela had said she'd find her own way down, which was a lie of the plainest sort. She'd come up here because from the top terrace you could see the whole road to the pass.

"You walk quietly," Devan said, without turning.

"You listen for it."

"I do." He turned the berries over. "These are early. The vines think the rain is close."

"Is it?"

"Forty days, give or take."

She came up beside him. The wind off the pass pushed at her kasavu and she let it. Below them the road fell away in loops, red between the green, and far down a cart the size of a seed was creeping toward the gate.

"May I ask you things?" she said.

"You may ask me anything."

"That's not what I said."

"No." He glanced at her sidelong. "It's what I meant."

All right, she thought. Let's see.

"Did you sleep well?"

"No. Not much."

"Why not?"

"I sleep badly. I told you."

"Did I wake you?"

"You didn't wake me."

It was flat and plain, and she turned it over and found no seam. Her pulse settled. "What do you eat for breakfast?"

"Rice. Whatever Janu sends." A pause. "More, lately."

"Do you like me?"

That got her a longer look. "I don't know you yet."

"Do you trust me?"

"No."

She laughed. It came out of her before she could check it. "You could have said yes."

"It wouldn't have been true."

"People say untrue things to wives all the time."

"Do they?"

"It's most of what a wife hears."

"I wouldn't know." He shook the berries off his palm into the earth. "I don't say them. It saves effort."

She decided to push. "Say the sky is green."

"The sky is blue."

"It's a game. Say it."

"No."

"Say you're glad of me."

He considered the question as if it were a stone he'd been handed. His fingers worked at the empty air, square hands with old white nicks across the knuckles, slow and careful, as if even a question deserved to be held properly. Neela caught herself watching them. She took a step back, and the wind filled the space where she had been.

"I'm not sorry," he said. "I can say that."

"Say it was the council's idea and you hated it."

"It was the council's idea."

"And the rest?"

"I won't answer that."

"Then I'll ask the one that matters." She kept her voice light. "Why did your council choose me?"

The wind moved the vines. He stood very still, and for the first time since she'd met him his face showed effort.

"I won't answer that," he said.

"You could lie."

"I could."

"Nobody would know."

"I would." He said it without weight, the way another man might say he'd had breakfast. "Ask me something else."

She looked at the cart on the road. It had not moved at all, as far as she could tell.

She had known men with power over her. Chathu, soft and patient, who lied the way he breathed and gave every lie a column of figures to hide in. The masters before him. The buyers she'd never met. Every one of them told her what was convenient, and she had learned to read them by the hole it left. This man left no hole. He told her the sky was blue and that he didn't trust her, and when he couldn't tell her, he put up a plain wall and stood in front of it.

That should have comforted her. A man with no cunning had nothing to hide behind. Instead it made her careful. A man who would not lie was a man who would notice hers.

"Tell Janu thank you," she said, "for the rice."

"I will," said Devan.

He nodded once, like a man settling a small account, and turned back to the vines. Indifference, she decided. Almost a relief.

*

He was closing the shutters when she came back at dusk.

The chamber had gone amber. The sun sat low and swollen over the pass, the sky round it bright as a washed bowl. Devan stood at the west window with one leaf drawn in, and as she stopped in the doorway he pulled the second to. The third slat creaked. He lifted the long teak bar from where it leaned against the wall and dropped it into the iron brackets, and the whole window shut like a mouth.

"Rain," he said.

Neela looked past him, at the thin gold line still showing between the slats. "The sky's clear."

"Yes."

"You said rain."

"Rain comes off the pass fast." He rested his hand on the bar a moment, as if checking it was seated. "I like it shut."

Last night there had been no bar across them at all. Tonight there was, and a man who barred a window looked at its bar.

That was all. He did not turn the lamp up. He did not explain. He crossed to the table where the supper leaf lay waiting and sat, and began on his rice with the same slow thoroughness he brought to everything.

A fussy habit, she told herself. Some men kept their boots in pairs. Some counted their coins every night. She would put it with the sword on the floor and the creaking slat: the small private rules of a man who lived alone and slept badly.

But she stayed in the doorway, because the bar was a good one. A hand's width of seasoned teak, seated in iron, and the only way to lift it was from the inside. A leopard could not do that. Outside the door a guard stood all night. If the warden were found dead behind a barred window, the fort would not say *beast*. It would say *who was in the room with him*, and there was only one answer.

The way in she had planned all week had just been shut. The hand that opened it again would be hers.

*

She counted his breath again.

One to ten, steady. Forty, slowing. A hundred. At two hundred and twelve he caught, that same hitch like a bucket knocking a well wall, and she let it pass. A man with a habit. She was starting to collect those.

At three hundred she gave him thirty more. Then she slid out from the sheet and stepped over the sword.

The bar was heavier than it looked. She took it in both hands and eased it up out of the brackets an inch at a time, and set it down against the wall on the side where it would not fall. The shutters swung under her fingers. The third slat cracked.

She froze with her hand on the wood and counted twenty. His breathing went on, long and even.

Out on the ledge she knelt in the cold dark and thought it through, the way she thought through any job. Last night nothing had barred the window, and nothing was missing from it when he woke. Tonight he had barred it himself, and he would look at it in the morning, as a man looks at anything he has set with his own hands.

If she left it lifted, he would see. And if he saw, he would ask. A man like this would ask, and he would listen to what she said, and he would know exactly what the answer weighed.

So it had to go back before he woke. Not from the ledge. From inside, with her hands, as a woman, in the grey, with the shaking still in her arms.

She drew out the flask, and put the bangle on the sill, and did what she did.

The burn took her. The wind rushed in, loaded with a thousand smells. She did not think in words after that. The other one ran along the ledge, dropped to the terrace wall, and went along the stone as if it were a road. She learned the pairs on the wall and how they walked. She learned the third clank after the middle watch, and what a dog smelled like through a kennel door, and that the yard below the padippura lay open and pale. Somewhere in the hours she learned that the chamber door had a guard in front of it and the window had a bar behind it, and that between the two no kill by beast had room to stand.

She did not know which of them was the problem, the man or the bar. She would work that out in daylight.

*

The chain clanked the last hour, and the sky went grey behind the pass.

She came back along the ledge with her legs like wet rope, and the turning went out of her in a long ragged shudder that left her on her knees on the stone. The hollow was back. It was worse than yesterday, because tonight a task waited at the end of it.

She put the bangle on. She wrapped the kasavu round herself with fingers that kept missing. Then she stood, which took two tries, and drew the shutters in behind her one at a time.

The room was dim and smelled of sesame oil and sleep. Devan lay on his left side with his back to her and one hand open on the sheet, breathing slow. Rice sat on the low table, a fresh leaf, covered by a cloth. Neela did not look at it. She would be sick if she looked at it.

She lifted the bar. It weighed what it had weighed before, and her arms had less in them. She set the end in the left bracket first, then walked it round to the right, slowly, a finger's breadth at a time, because the iron was cold and the wood would knock if it went wrong.

The bar slid home.

The third slat answered it. A dry crack, sharp as a knuckle, loud in the quiet.

Neela stayed where she was, her palm flat on the teak and her breath held behind her teeth. She did not turn. She counted.

At nineteen she gave up, and looked.

He lay exactly as he had lain. The sheet rose and fell, rose and fell. His hand was open on the cloth. Nothing in his back had changed.

But she had not been watching his back when the slat cracked, and she could not tell whether the breathing she heard now was the breathing from before.

Chapter 4

Kennelled

"They've shut the hounds up again," Kannan said.

He said it to the goat. Pepper went on chewing and watched Neela with one yellow eye, like a small judge.

Neela had climbed to the second terrace with a bowl of Janu's rice. The hollow in her belly would not let her sit still. Besides, a goat-boy on a wall saw everything that moved in a fort. She sat on the laterite beside him and held out the bowl. He took a fistful without looking, like a boy who had been fed by a steward all his life.

"Which hounds?" she said.

"All of them. Fourteen." He wiped his hand on his knee. "They sleep in the long kennel behind the stables. Can you hear them? Every night since your wedding. They howl till the middle watch, and my loft is right over that wall."

"They didn't howl before?"

"They weren't *in* before. They ran the yard from dusk to dawn. Since forever. Nobody crossed it in the dark unless the hounds knew his smell." He scowled. "Then the warden says, kennel them. Chinna asked why. He said, 'I like it quiet.' Quiet! In a fort!"

"Maybe he sleeps badly."

"Janu says he's slept badly eight years, and the hounds ran anyway."

Neela ate the rest of the rice slowly. Her face stayed polite. Behind it she was already counting.

She had checked the bar first thing that morning, before Janu's rice, before anything. It sat in its brackets, seated as she had left it. Devan had come in from the pit and said one thing about the night. "The third slat creaks," he'd said, to the shutters. "I've never fixed it."

That was all. It was a fact about wood. It might also have been a question, or a door held open for her to walk through. She had said, "It's an old house," and he had said, "Yes," and gone to wash. She still could not read it.

That was the first piece. The second was the yard.

She had crossed it last night. Sixty paces of open ground between the padippura and the stables, pale as a threshing floor, and nothing in it. She had noted it the way she noted everything, and had been glad. She had not asked why. Now a nine-year-old with a goat had told her it had never been empty before.

So. A gift, or a trap.

A gift, because a man who barred his window against clear sky was a man of small, odd rules. Perhaps he truly wanted quiet. Perhaps he was a husband with a new wife and a poor night's sleep, and the hounds were one more noise. Careless men did leave doors open. She had walked through a hundred of them.

But this man wasn't careless. She had watched him pick up berries one at a time. A warden with a bride the council had chosen, and tokens leaking through his pass, might very well empty a yard on purpose. Then he would put men on the wall to see who walked into it. And a slat that he had named aloud, the morning after...

She could argue it either way until the chain clanked noon. She tried. It came out even.

Both readings ended in the same place, which was in the yard, with her eyes open.

"Are you going to eat that?" Kannan asked, looking at the bowl.

"No," she said, and gave it to the goat.

*

The hooves came an hour later.

Gopan hauled his lever, the chain went over the drum, and a patrol clattered through the padippura in a spray of red mud. Seven riders. Neela was at the hall door before she'd decided to be, with Janu hissing behind her about wives who ought to be sitting down.

The hall was long and cool, with pillars of black teak and a floor of polished red earth. The riders came in with their boots still dripping. The sergeant at the front was Bhaskaran, who held the gate and had ridden out at dawn when a herdsman swore he'd seen men at the second ford. He had a satchel in his fist, stiff with dried blood, and he slammed it onto the long table hard enough to jump the lamps.

"Raider, sir. At the ford. One of his friends put an arrow in him, and we found what he was carrying."

Devan had come in from the east door. He didn't hurry. He took the satchel by its strap, turned it out, and picked through what fell: a knife, a twist of dried fish, a coil of cord. Then a flat tally the size of a palm, strung on a leather loop and capped with a thumb of dull red wax.

Captain Muthu had come up beside him, big and easy, with his arms folded. "Another one?"

"Another one."

Devan held it up. The hall went quiet in a way she knew from the Resin House, the quiet of people waiting to be told how bad it was. He set his thumbnail under the wax and pressed. It split cleanly into two halves. He turned each to the window.

"The wax is genuine," he said. "Council wax. Council seal, pressed from the true ring."

Somewhere behind her a lamp wick spat.

"It isn't copied," he said, in the same flat voice. "I'd know. This was made in the council house, by someone with the right to make it."

Then the hall broke open.

"A clerk," said Muthu, loudly. "Some wax-house clerk with a bad debt and a wife."

"A Thurai spy in the council," said a young guard near the door. "They've got them everywhere."

"A lord," said Bhaskaran. "It's always a lord. A man who never has to stand at the gate and look into a carter's face." His voice cracked on *face*.

Neela, behind her pillar, made her own wager. She didn't believe in clerks. A clerk made a mark; a clerk could be caught making it. This had a hand behind it that nobody searched. She watched who said nothing, and it was the warden.

Bhaskaran saw it too. "The tally number," he said, and his voice dropped, and that was worse. "Sir. I know this number. It's a cart I passed. New moon, a salt-and-cloth cart from the coast. I looked at the wax. I *looked* at it, and I waved them through. I'll ride to Kodiyur myself and open the whole council with my sword."

"Bhaskaran," Devan said.

"Sir, I will."

"Sit."

Bhaskaran didn't. Two of his men had already taken a half step toward him. He was a big man, red in the face, and his hand had found his hilt. Neela slid her weight onto the balls of her feet without meaning to.

Devan didn't raise his voice. He came around the table and stopped an arm's length from the sergeant. He put one palm flat on the tabletop, where Bhaskaran could see it, empty.

"You looked at the wax," he said. "It was true wax. You were meant to pass it. That's what the wax is for."

"Sir..."

"If you'd turned that cart away, I'd have asked you why. You'd have said it looked wrong. It didn't look wrong. It was perfect." He waited. "That's the whole trouble. Do you see it?"

The sergeant's chest went in and out. "Yes, sir."

"I need every tally that has passed your gate since the last rains. Numbers, carts, faces, whatever you remember. You're the only man who can give me that. Will you?"

The hand came off the hilt. "Yes."

"Then sit and eat first. You smell of the ford."

A thin laugh went round. Bhaskaran dropped onto the bench like a sack set down at the end of a long road, and Janu was already there with a cup. The whole thing had taken less time than it takes to boil water.

Neela's pulse had gone quiet, the way it did when a fight ended before it began. She had watched men handle men at the Resin House, but they used the rod, or the ledger, or the threat of both. This one had used the truth and a free hand.

Her own hand lay against the black teak of the pillar, palm flat, fingers open and empty.

She looked at it. It was his hand, the one he'd laid on the table for Bhaskaran, and she had made it without being told. She took it off the wood and tucked it into the fold of her kasavu.

"Neela."

She started. He was looking straight at her across the length of the hall, and so was everyone else.

"Your house trades pepper under these tallies. Come and tell me if this wax is what it looks like."

It was a test, or it was courtesy, and his face didn't say which. She crossed the red floor with the polite smile on and took the two halves from his palm. They were warm from his hand.

Dull brick red. A pressed mark of a pepper sprig, crisp at every leaf. She raised one half to her nose, because a Chirayil ward would, and sweet clove rose off it, faint and green.

"It's new," she said. "A month old, not more. The wax-house pours with clove oil so it doesn't crack in the damp. It's still in the wax." She turned the half over. "And it's good work. Better than good."

"That's what I thought," Devan said.

He took the halves back. For a moment his fingers were against her palm, dry and rough at the pads. Then they weren't. She went back to her pillar with her hand held very still.

*

She caught him on the outer stair, where the hall's shadow ended and the court began, and fell into step beside him as if she had been going the same way.

"Your sergeant thinks it was his fault."

"He thinks wrongly."

"You told him so."

"I told him the truth. It's easier than arguing." He didn't slow. "Your nose is good."

"My guardian taught me to judge a pepper by smell before I could read." That was a line she had learned in the Resin House, with the rest of Chirayil. It came out smooth.

"Useful."

They walked a few steps. Below them the court was full of men leading in tired horses. She let a pause go by and then asked it plainly, as a wife might.

"Who sells them?"

He glanced at her. It wasn't suspicion. He looked like a man who has been asked the weather and is surprised anyone cares.

"Someone on the queen's council."

"Which one?"

"If I knew," Devan said, "he'd be in a cell."

She waited for the rest. For the turn: *and that's why you're here*, or *and I've reason to think you can help*. It didn't come. He was looking down at the horses.

"The tokens go to Thurai raiders," he said. "So far they burn grain stores and a mill or two. Soon it will be the villages on the coast side. Your house's carts will want the pass open in harvest. I mean to see it stays that way."

"That's all?"

"It's a great deal." There was dry humour in it, very low. "I would sleep better."

She had come out of the hall braced for her own name. A husband holding a hostile bride might circle the subject of her for weeks; she had

planned for that. Instead he had told her his hunt in six sentences, and her name wasn't in any of them. He wasn't hunting her. He was hunting somebody else, and he wanted him badly, and it had never crossed his mind to use her as a lever.

That made him easier to listen to, which was a bad sign.

"I hope you find him," she said, and was startled to find she meant something by it.

"So do I," said Devan, and went down into the court.

*

He barred the shutters at dusk. "Rain," he said again, and again the sky was washed clean.

She said nothing. She watched his back and set the two things side by side.

Everything else he told her fit the world. The wax was true, the sky was blue, the cell was waiting for a man he couldn't name. When he couldn't answer, he said so and kept his hands where she could see them. Only here did he give her a word that answered nothing. Rain, every night, at this window, under a sky with no cloud in it.

Hounds shut up for a bride. Shutters shut for weather. Both were about the dark, and the dark was hers.

She did not know what it meant. A man who held back one thing so plainly had a reason, and she did not like that she wanted to know it. She ate her rice, counted his breath to three hundred, and stepped over the sword.

The bar came up in her hands. The third slat cracked. She counted twenty and he gave her nothing to hear.

The burn. The bright rush of smells. The other one went down the wall on silent claws.

The yard lay open below.

It did not hurry. It took the terrace face in three drops and came to the corner of the stables, where the kennel smell rolled out thick: dog, straw, wet fur, fourteen angry noses turned toward it through the planks.

They knew it was there. They could do nothing about it. One began to whine and the others took it up, a low grumble, and a guard at the far wall turned his head, and turned it back again. Dogs in a kennel at night were only dogs.

The yard stretched out silver and flat. The leopard crossed it low and slow.

It learned the padippura from the shadow of the water trough. Four men, and one with his chin on his chest. It went past the open end of the guard room close enough to touch the doorpost. It learned the kitchen door, where Chinna snored on her mat, and the granary, whose lock was a farm lock, and the well. It learned that the pairs on the wall met at the same stone and turned the same foot. Two men stood the west stair, as Devan had said. There was a gap, a count of thirty, under the far wall when the lower pair swung inward.

The cistern chain went. The third clank after the middle watch, and the pairs changed, and the yard took no notice of it at all.

This was the easiest fort it had ever walked. That was what lifted the fur along its spine. Nothing had stopped it. In all its life nothing had left it alone without wanting a price.

It circled back, past the cold stones of the kalari rim, toward the west wall. At the corner the wall pair parted. One man went on along the far walk with his lantern. The other turned back and paced the short stretch of rampart above the warden's window, alone, up and down, up and down. It went flat in the shadow and let him pass.

Then it lifted its head and looked up.

The window was a dark square in the laterite, one shutter leaf drawn back where it had left it. Nothing showed through the gap, but the smell of him came down the stone: sesame oil, old iron, sleep. And on the still air, the hitch in his breath.

It gathered itself. The wall was thirty feet, an easy climb. The ledge was wide. The sleeper was close enough that it could count that breath.

And above the ledge the sentry stopped. He leaned on the parapet and looked out at nothing, and his boots were two spans over its head.

When he moved, the lantern light swung over the ledge like a hand. A shape that went in at that window would be seen going. It would be shouted at before the teeth closed, and the whole wall would run. A beast out of the dark was a thing the fort could blame on the hills. A beast that walked into the warden's room under a sentry's eye was a hunt, and a sealed gate, and a skin on a pole.

The sentry coughed and went on. The moment stayed, wide open, and so did the window.

There was a cheaper way. She could wait a night, until the post above was bare, and take the throat in the quiet. The pass left thirty-seven nights, and she would be spending one of them on nothing.

But the other one did not weigh nights. It weighed an open palm laid flat on a table where a furious man could see it, and a voice that never rose. *Who is he hunting?* It had no words for the question. There was only the shape of the wanting, and the long cold climb that did not begin.

For the first time since the wedding she did not know the answer she had come to give: whether this man died by her hand.

It turned from the window and went down into the shadow of the wall. It lay under the water trough until the sentry's boots found their old beat, and watched the dark square, and waited out the night.

The sky began to grey behind the pass. The chain clanked the last hour.

Above her, the shutter moved.

Not a crack. Both leaves swung back against the laterite, wide, and stayed there. No lamp. No face. Only an open window thirty feet up, where she had left one leaf ajar, and the black square waiting like a held door.

The first burn of the dawn turning ran up her legs. Someone had opened it for her. Or for whatever came to the sill next.

Chapter 5

The Man Who Doesn't Spar

She had come back shaking again.

Devan had lain with his eyes shut and listened to it. At the grey of dawn he had thrown both shutter leaves wide and stood a moment at the empty sill. Down in the yard the shadow under the water trough lay thicker than a shadow should. When he looked again it was gone. She had not come to the sill. She had turned back in the yard.

Some time after first light he heard the stair door, then bare feet, then rough wool dropping to the floor. A saddle-blanket from the stable, by the smell of horse. Then came the long breath of a woman who had run all night and was trying not to show it. A hand missed the bed-post twice before it found it. The bed creaked.

He had opened the shutters because a woman who spent the night somewhere in his yard ought to see one way back that was not guarded and not a trap.

He counted her breaths until she slept. Then he went out to the kalari, because that was what he did, and a man who did something else on the fourth morning of a marriage would be noticed.

Three nights. She had gone out each one, and each one she had come back. Each time she had come to the bed shaking and lain with her back to him, as far off as the mattress allowed.

He did not know what that meant. He lit the sesame lamps around the rim one at a time and let the question sit in his chest.

The first form was slow. Feet in the red earth, weight low, the long staff turning over his shoulder. The second was faster. By the fifth the earth was spitting under his heels and the staff made a sound like cloth tearing. He drilled the way he had for eight years, against nobody. Every sequence ended in a strike, and every strike stopped a hand's width from the post. He had never once let it land. His arm knew exactly where to stop.

"Warden!"

Muthu came down the pit wall in two jumps with a practice staff in each fist, grinning. Red dust puffed under his boots.

"One round," he said. "One. I'll let you win. I'll let you win so loudly Gopan will ring the chain."

"No."

"I'll fight left-handed."

"No."

"I'll fight asleep." Muthu spun a staff and caught it. "Eight years, sir. I've counted. Every week I ask, and every week you say no, and it's the steadiest thing in Kettamala. The walls leak. The pass closes. But my warden says no at dawn on the seventh day, like the cistern chain on the hour."

"Eight years and a week."

"Is that all? I thought it was longer." Muthu laughed, the big laugh that made the pigeons go up. "At this rate I'll ask from my pyre. Burn me, Devan, I'll say, one round first. And you'll say no, and the whole fort will weep."

It was a good joke. It was the same joke, dressed a little differently each week. Devan watched Muthu's hand on the staff. The knuckles had gone pale, and Muthu held the grip long after the laugh ended.

Muthu had been his partner in this pit once. He had taken every bruise Devan gave him and asked for more. Then one day there had been a captain on his knees with his hands open, and a strike, and a silence. Devan had put down his staff and not lifted it against a living man since.

He couldn't give Muthu the reason he had stopped. Muthu had been there. He knew what had happened. He had never been told what it had done to Devan.

"Put the staffs on the rack," he said.

"Sir."

"And thank you for asking."

Muthu's face did something quick and unguarded. Then the grin came back over it like a lid. "Next week," he said, and went up the wall, whistling a little off key.

Devan stood in the empty pit with the second lamp guttering and finished the form. The strike stopped a hand's width from the post.

*

After the day watch changed, he took her out to the terraces, because a warden walking his wife through his pepper was the most natural thing in the world. It also kept her where he could see her hands.

She wore a day kasavu from her trousseau and the gold bangle. She took the steps up the slope without looking at them. A woman who counted her feet, he thought, and pushed the thought away, because he had decided to look at her as the Chirayil ward the council had sent.

"Tell me what you see," he said, at the second terrace.

She didn't hesitate. She picked a string of berries and rolled one between finger and thumb. "Early. The vines are confused. They've set fruit for a rain that's still a month off." She pressed the berry with a nail. "Hard. Good. These will dry heavy. Drop a handful in water and the sinkers are the ones worth the weight." She looked along the row. "You've let the east side go too dense. They'll mould if the monsoon comes early."

"Janu said the same."

"Then Janu's right. Is she often?"

"Always. It's tiresome." He walked on. "Your guardian. What was his name?"

"Kunjan Chirayil." She said it smoothly. "He kept the north warehouse in Kodiyur. Do you know it?"

"No."

"You'd smell it from the water. Wet sacks, and cloves from the Thurai side. He'd stand in the door and tell you the grade of a cargo with his eyes shut." A small shrug. "It's what he was good at."

Devan had read the council's papers on the Chirayil house three times, and nothing in them was false. Kunjan Chirayil was real. The warehouse was real. She spoke of both the way a person speaks of a place they have been taught.

"Were you fond of him?"

"Were you fond of yours?"

"My father?" He considered it honestly. "I respected him. Fondness came later, after he was dead and couldn't object."

"Did that make it easier?"

"No. Did it make it easier for you? With Kunjan?"

"Do you miss the hills?" she said. "Janu says you were away once."

"Two years, at the border school. Where did you learn your letters?"

"Where did you learn to be so patient?"

A cart creaked somewhere below. He nodded as though she had given him a fair answer, and filed it with the others. Ask her what a pepper weighs and she would tell him to the grain. Ask her where she slept as a child, and a question came back at him, light and quick and always shaped like a door closing.

It was neat work. It was also the first time all morning she had sounded like herself.

She reached up to pull a runner free of its stake, and the gold bangle slid back along her wrist.

Under it, the skin was pale and ridged, in rows, like a field the plough had gone over too many times. He knew the pattern. He had smelled a sealed jar of the stuff at twenty, in a classroom, while a lean teacher described exactly what it did to the skin of those who used it. He had seen

these scars by starlight on the wedding night, and in the grey of the dawn after. He had not seen them in full sun.

In sun they told him something new. The ridges lay thick, layer over layer, one scar healed into the next. That was not a season's work. That was more than a decade of it, and nobody burned herself that many times who had begun as a grown woman. She had started young. Whoever had put her to this had done it while she was still a child.

Her eyes caught his, and the bangle slid down in one smooth motion.

"A childhood burn," she said, lightly. "I was clumsy."

It was no child's burn, and they both knew it. He said, "The stakes want mending on this row," and went to look at them.

Behind him the bangle clicked against a stake. He didn't turn around.

*

The yelp came from above them, and then a boy's furious wail.

Kannan sat on the third wall with his right hand clamped in his left, and the white goat stood beside him, looking mildly satisfied. Blood ran between the boy's fingers and dripped off his wrist onto the laterite.

"She bit me!"

"She does that," Devan said. "It's in the name."

Neela was already there. She hadn't run, exactly, but she had crossed the terrace in the time it took him to start. She knelt, took the boy's wrist, and turned the hand to the light.

"It's clean," she said. "A good bite is cleaner than a bad scratch. Hold still." She looked up. "Warden, there's a water pot on the wall."

He brought it. She rinsed the wound under the pot, steady, murmuring to the boy about nothing. When it ran clear she pulled the gold-bordered edge of her kasavu through her fingers and tore a strip off it in one motion. The cloth was trousseau cloth, gold thread and all, worth a month of the boy's keep.

She bound the hand with quick, firm turns and tied it off.

"Tell Bindu to wash it again tonight with boiled water," she said. "And to sing while she does it. She has a good voice and you'll forget the sting."

Kannan stared at her. "How do you know my mother sings?"

"The women at the well were talking about it this morning." She tapped his nose. "Keep Pepper off the vines. She's eating the best of them."

"She isn't," said the boy, who was nine, and incapable of lying about a goat. "Well. Only the low ones."

Devan stood with the water pot in his hand and did not move.

His sister Asha had done this. She had taken her post as an officer of the fort at nineteen, and in her first month she had gone through the recruits with a slate and a bit of chalk, writing down names and villages and mothers. Everybody's. He had teased her. *You'll be the only second in the border guard who can address a conscript's grandmother.* She had looked at him, grinning, chalk on her chin. *They'll fight better if someone knows who to write to.*

He set the water pot on the wall. He said, "I need a moment," and walked down the terrace steps without looking back.

It was true, and it was all he would say. The wall by the cistern was near enough that he could stand there, palm flat on the cold laterite, until the chain went and covered the sound of his own breathing.

An instrument did not tear a wedding-gift cloth for a goat-boy.

He had been so sure what she was. The thing that had been sent. The thing like the one that had come down his west stair on a night six years gone, and taken his sister apart with a bear's claws, and left her there for Janu to find in the morning.

He did not know what to do with a person.

*

Supper was rice and a dark fish curry, and Janu served it herself and sat down at the end of the table to scold them while they ate. Muthu had

come in from the gate and taken the bench opposite, heaping his plate. The hall smelled of tamarind and lamp oil.

"The old woman at the lower ford says there's a cat on the hill," Janu said.

"A cat?" said Muthu, with his mouth full.

"A big one. She heard it cough in the pala grove." Janu pulled her shawl straight, enjoying herself. "It reminded me. When I was a girl, a leopard came down to the village below my mother's house. Every night it took something. First a hen, then a kid. Then the headman's calf, and it left the bell, mind you, neatly, on the doorstep, as if to say it had no use for the noise. The men sat up with spears for a week and never saw it once. They said it knew which house it wanted. It was patient. It waited till the lamps were out, and—"

Devan was not looking at Janu.

Across the table, Neela held her cup with both hands. She had been drinking water, steadily, in small sips. Now her hands were round it as if she were warming them, and the knuckles had gone white as the rim.

Her face hadn't changed. It was the pleasant, attentive face of a bride listening to an old woman's story. But the cup trembled by the width of a hair, and she pressed it to the table to stop it.

He knew that stillness. He had seen it a hundred times on the faces of recruits who were told the thing they feared was coming.

Janu, enough. The words were in his mouth. She would have stopped at once, and sniffed, and looked at him with the hurt he had never been able to bear.

He did not say them.

Neela did not know he had seen her turn. It was the one thing he held that she did not. A warden who cut off a leopard story for his bride's sake would be telling her, as plainly as speech, that he had joined the two in his head. She would know it by morning. Every night after, she would run with that knowledge at her back.

So he sat, and let the old woman tell it, and watched the white knuckles, and ate rice he could not taste. He wanted to stop it for her. He didn't.

"Is it true?" Neela said, when Janu ended. Her voice was light. "Did you see it?"

"Heavens, no. I was a girl in bed with the shutters closed." Janu patted her hand. "Don't mind me. It's a story."

"I like stories," said Neela, and set down the cup.

She excused herself soon after. Devan watched her cross the hall, back straight, steps even, and counted the times she looked at the doors. Two. The west door and the east.

*

He let Muthu finish his meal. Then he walked him out under the arch of the hall, where the torchlight did not reach the corner and the pigeons had gone to roost.

"Captain."

"Sir."

"Take the night man off the west wall. The one who walks the rampart above my window."

Muthu's chewing stopped. "Off it? That's the closest stretch to your chamber, sir."

"I know."

"The raiders have been at the ford. Sir, with respect, if any wall wants a man on it—"

"I know," Devan said again. "Pull him."

Muthu looked at him in the dark. The cheerfulness was gone for a moment, as if something had been set down. "Any reason I should give the sergeant?"

"I won't answer that."

A pause. Then the big shoulders came down, and Muthu clapped him once on the arm, like a man shaking off a thought. "Then I'll tell

him you've got a bad stomach and want the quiet," he said. "That'll keep the barracks busy till harvest."

"Tell him whatever you like."

"Sir." Muthu hesitated. "You'd say, wouldn't you. If it was bad."

"If I could."

It was the nearest thing to a lie he allowed himself, and it was not one. He watched Muthu go down the steps toward the barracks, and then he climbed to the chamber.

Neela was not in it yet. The bed was made. The sword lay on the floor on her side, hilt toward the pillow, plain wire grip worn at the thumb. He barred the shutters, as he did at dusk, and stood looking at the teak.

His first reason was a plain one. Whoever had sent her would want a report, and a leopard that ran the hills left marks. Each dawn he could read the wet laterite by the trough, see where the paws came from and where they went, and learn who she ran to.

The truer reason was the rule. A man on the rampart two spans above that ledge, with a lantern in his fist, could watch her turn. He would be her witness from that moment, with the word in his mouth for the rest of his life. Devan had decided never to use what he knew. He could not decide that for a sentry.

Then he lay down with his back to the door and shut his eyes.

She came in late, in her day cloth, and said nothing. She lay down at the far edge. He counted her breaths, slow and careful, a woman pretending, until at last she rose. The bar lifted from its brackets. The third slat cracked.

He did not move. He kept his breath even, with its small hitch.

Then the cold thought came, too late to take back. With the rampart bare there was no one up there to shout. There would also be no one to swear, if the worst came, what had or had not passed in this room. If she turned from the hill toward the bed, nobody on the wall would hear a thing.

Soft as a dropped cloth, her weight landed on the ledge.

Chapter 6

Green Wax

Janu held the sandalwood box out at arm's length, the way she held a fish she didn't trust.

"The queen's own wax," she said. "I've never seen it so close."

It sat in the middle of the storeroom floor between a rice sack and a chest of Chirayil linens. Neela had known what it was from the doorway. Everything else the wedding had brought was brown paper and string. This had a thumb of green wax over a knot of red cord, pressed with a small bird, wings spread.

"A rider brought it before noon," Janu said. "Sat in my hall and ate for three. Sudhi, he said his name was. I wanted to hit him with a ladle."

"Sudhi," said Neela, and put it away with the rest. Maniyamma and Thankappan, who had carried the chests. The two Chirayil cousins who had sent the bolt of yellow cloth and not come. She had learned them all while Janu talked. It was a bad habit for a woman who was meant to pass through a house like water. She had never been able to stop.

"Open the lamp first," Janu said. "It's the only one from your own people, and you've been polite to everything else."

The lamp came out of its straw heavy and cold, a standing lamp of brass with a bird worked into the stem and five cups for oil. Someone had paid for it and chosen it, and wrapped it so it would not scratch. It was part of her family. She had no family. A stranger in the Chirayil

house had sat down and thought, what would a ward carry to her husband's fort? And had decided on a bird.

She rubbed a thumbprint off the rim with her sleeve.

"Handsome," said Janu, grudging. "Put it by the window. It'll catch the evening."

The warden's step sounded in the passage. He didn't knock. He stopped in the doorway and looked at the box before he looked at either of them.

"You sent for me," he said.

"I sent Kannan to tell you there was a box," said Janu. "From the palace. I thought you'd want to cut it yourself."

"I do." He crossed the floor, crouched, and drew his belt knife. The red cord parted. He slid the blade under the green wax and lifted, and the whole seal came away in one piece, the bird still crisp on its face.

Inside, on a bed of dry cloth, lay a betel set in silver. A tray, a lidded box for lime paste, an areca cutter with a sunbird for a handle. Janu made a sound of pure greed.

Devan barely glanced at it. He turned the seal over on his palm and tilted it to the slit of window. He ran his thumbnail along the underside, then the edge. He held it close to his face and breathed in, once, the way Neela had done with the council's wax in the hall. She had caught the smell herself when Janu set the box down: crushed leaf. Not clove.

He was at it longer than he'd given the silver or the cord, and the cord was cut through.

"Well?" Janu said. "Her Grace's own hand chose it."

"Her Grace's staff chose it."

"It's *lovely*."

"It is." He closed his fingers over the wax. "I'm not going to eat from it."

Neela's mouth moved before she'd checked it. "You don't like the gift."

"I don't trust gifts from the palace."

He said it plainly, to the floor, in the same voice he'd used for the weight of a berry. Janu made a noise like a kettle. "Devan! In this house! Under my roof!"

"I'll say it under hers, if she asks."

Neela knelt very still among the straw. She thought of the Resin House, and of sweets. Before every contract, Chathu sent a tin of them to her room. Jaggery and sesame, soft, still warm from the kitchen. *For luck, child.* She had eaten all eleven tins. Around the fifth, she had learned that being given something was the start of a bill.

"Then we agree," she said.

He looked at her at last. It was a short look, and a surprised one. "Do we?"

"I was raised by a pepper house. Anything given free costs double." She kept her voice light. "Ask any trader."

Something eased at the corner of his mouth. It didn't become a smile. It only seemed to be thinking about one. "I will," he said.

He turned the seal over once more. Then, to her surprise, he held it out across the box, green wax flat on his palm. "What would a trader say it cost?"

She looked at the bird, wings spread, and not at him. "The price of what they'll ask for next."

He nodded once, the way a man nods when a weight matches his own scale. He closed his hand and tucked the wax into his sleeve. "Janu, lock the set in the granary with the hill seed. Nothing from that box goes into our chamber or our mouths."

"A queen's silver in the *granary*—"

"Yes."

Nobody in this fort had asked what she thought of anything that wasn't pepper. She had been asked now, and some small, stupid part of her had wanted to be. She put the feeling with the other things she would have to ignore.

"One more thing," said Janu, who could not let a quiet go by. "Warden. The cat."

"What cat?"

"The one in the pepper store! Two sacks torn open this week, and droppings I could use for a doorstop. I've told the boys to sweep and it comes back. Turn the hounds loose again, a night or two. They'd have it out by morning."

"The hounds stay in."

"Then what am I to do?"

"Leave the cat," said Devan. "It keeps the rats down."

His eyes were on the box lid as he said it. Neela's hand had been resting there, one finger tracing the grain. It stopped.

The cat.

Her heart gave one hard knock and went on. She kept her face where it was.

It was Janu's word. Janu had said it three times this week, of the pepper store, and the old woman at the ford had said it, and Janu's story at supper had used it for a creature half a hill away. Everyone in this fort said cat. A man who answered a steward's complaint used the steward's word. Of course he did. And a cat in a pepper store was a cat in a pepper store.

She lifted the finger. The lid closed on its own weight.

"I'll carry the lamp up," she said, "before it's lost under all this."

She avoided his sleeve, where the green wax was. She avoided his face. She took the lamp by its bird and went out into the passage, and counted her steps up the stair to forty, to be sure they were even.

*

At dusk the lamp stood at the window with a thin line of evening running down its stem. The shutters were barred. The sword lay on the floor, hilt toward her. The man who owned both was already in the bed with his back to the door, breathing slowly and evenly, which she had learned meant nothing.

She counted him to three hundred. Then she went to the window.

Thirty-five nights. Thirty-five, and tonight she was not going to spend one watching a wall she'd already measured.

The bar. The third slat, a crack like a knuckle. The resin on throat and wrists, black and bitter, with its old burn lighting under the skin, and the rush of smells that came over her in a flood. The other one took the ledge in a single flowing step. It looked up, and the rampart over the window was empty. The rampart had been empty two nights now. Neela had stopped calling it luck. She noted it and pushed it behind her.

The leopard didn't go to the yard this time. The yard was learned. It went along the foot of the west wall and dropped to the first pepper terrace, then the next, and over the lip of the last into the dark of the hill.

The hill was loud with small lives. A hare screamed somewhere and went quiet. The animal's hunger came with the night, and it was not hers, and it ate at her anyway. The leopard passed a hollow where a hare breathed in the grass, a fast and tiny pulse. It let the hare breathe. It was there to work.

Find the weak hour. The contract needed it, and she couldn't get it by looking down from a ledge. She went back over what she had. The chain at the cistern, and Gopan, who kept it. The pairs changing on the third clank after the middle watch. Raiu holding the torch in the passage outside the chamber, a boy who nodded off over his own elbow by the end of the night. Chinna snoring at the kitchen door. The cooks who woke when the sky went grey. The men on the wall in the last long hour before first light, when the night pairs had stood longest, with their lanterns burned low and their heads gone heavy.

The last dark hour. Just before first light the whole fort was at its poorest.

The hour had one flaw, and she found it as she ran. The man she was paid to kill woke in that hour. He rose before the light and went to the pit alone, and for as long as he drilled he was awake and armed and in the open air.

She checked herself mid-stride and made herself be honest. She knew it only from Janu's grumbling and from the pit lamps lit below the east

wall. She had never once been in the chamber to watch him rise. At that hour she was always out on the hill. It was a thing she had been told, not a thing she had seen.

She would not take him in the pit. She would take him in the bed, before he woke, or not at all. Which left the hour before the hour. A narrow door, but a door. She would look at it again at dawn, with her own eyes.

She was a good way up the second spur, in the pala grove, when the wind changed.

The scent came down the slope on it, and the leopard stopped dead with one forepaw lifted. Under the green smell of wet leaves, under dung and old rain, there was a sharp thread of musk. Warm. Fresh. Neela knew it the way she knew the dormitory blankets at the Resin House, thin and grey and smelling of one particular child.

Jackal.

The leopard went up the slope low and fast. At the top of the spur stood a split slab of laterite, knee high, with a lightning scar through the middle and a pale cup cut in its top. Every meeting stone in the guild was cut with a cup. A mark was left in it, or a thing was left under it, and no one who passed would see anything but a rock. She had been told to look for this one before she left the Resin House. Now she had found it.

Wet at the base, where the pink earth had been splashed. Fresh. The jackal had stood here at dusk, or an hour after, and said her piece in the oldest way a jackal could.

Ammu was close.

She put her face to the mark and breathed it in. Anyone else would call it a jackal's mark on a stone. It warmed her like tea taken hot.

The leopard could not speak. It could not leave a word. It could only press its cheek against the laterite and drag it, once, slowly, from one end of the slab to the other. A leopard's answer, with its own scent laid down over hers.

I'm here. Come.

She stayed until the wind moved, then turned for the fort. The grey was a long way off still. She ran the paths home with her head up, and the hunger forgotten.

*

She took the terraces at a lope and the wall in three bounds and was crouched on the ledge before the chain rang the last hour of the dark. She hadn't thought of it as the last. Now it was. The sky behind the eastern wall was the colour of a dove's back, and the shutter stood open the width of her shoulders.

The bed was behind her. She could hear him from here. Slow. Level. His breath did the small hitch that it always did, a little stumble a third of the way through each long count. She took it for the sign of a man in the deepest part of sleep.

Still abed, then. At first light, again. She set it beside what Janu said about the pit lamps, and the two did not fit. She would count it again tomorrow, and the night after.

The grey came up. The other one went out of her all at once.

It always hurt, and it always hurt the same. The bones took it first. Then the skin of her wrists and her throat peeled hot and ran cold, and she was a woman crouched naked on a stone sill with her teeth chattering, one hand flat against the wall for balance. The hunger came after, hollow and shaking, scooping her out from the inside.

She breathed. She looked up for the sentry's lantern, and there was none, and in its place sat a cat.

It was on the parapet above her, in the very spot where the boots had stood. A scruffy ginger tom, one ear gone to a notch, his coat in ropes. A dead rat hung from his jaws. He looked down at her with the flat hostile calm of a creature who had held this wall long before she had, and he was covered in pepper. It lay on his paws and whiskers and on the top of his head like flour. He looked at her for a long moment.

Then he sneezed.

It was a tiny sneeze, outraged and very wet, and the rat jumped in his mouth.

The laugh came out of her before she knew it. It came out loud, ringing off the laterite, and it was a real one, not the careful bell of a Chirayil ward. She clapped her hand to her mouth, and the laugh went on behind it, shaking her shoulders, hunger and cold and all.

Leave the cat. It keeps the rats down.

That was the cat. That was the whole of it, a pepper-dusted tom with a notched ear. She had stood in a storeroom and let a word go through her like a nail, and it was a ginger ruffian with an opinion about Janu's sacks. She leaned her forehead on the stone and shook with laughing, silently now, tears in her eyes.

Behind her, in the dark of the chamber, the breathing hitched.

She froze, one hand still pressed to her lips, and counted. One, two, three. The breath settled and ran level. A man turning in his sleep.

But the hitch had come on the very beat of her laugh. Not a third of the way through, like every other night. She filed it. A loud sound wakes anyone halfway, she told herself. Sleepers stumble. It was chance. She kept her eyes off the bed.

The tom looked down at her with great contempt. He picked up his rat and walked away along the parapet, his tail kinked at the tip.

"Thank you," she whispered, and climbed in.

She dressed in the dark, quickly, with her teeth shut on the chatter. The cold bangle went on last, over the ridged skin. She lowered the bar into its brackets with both hands. By the time she turned, she had half decided she'd have two helpings of Janu's rice, and was thinking very hard about rice.

Then, from the tree line past the lowest terrace, a jackal cried.

Three short yips. A pause long enough to count. Then a single long note that slid up and cracked at the top, very thin on the cold air.

She stood with her back against the shutter and her skin gone tight. She knew the call. They had practised it in the yard behind the sheds, eleven years old and nine, bent double with laughing, until Master

Chathu came out to tell them the Resin House had no use for dogs. Three and one meant *tomorrow*. It meant *I will find you*.

The call came again. Three. A pause. One.

She did not answer. She could not, and it did not matter. She stood in the half-dark of a stranger's chamber, with the sword on the floor and the sleeper in the bed, and heard her sister tell her, over the length of the hill, to hold on one more day. And behind the call, quieter, the question she had filed and could not unfile: had he meant the cat?

Chapter 7

There's a Way, Chechi

The tune reached Neela before the girl did.

It came from the far end of the lower market, under the tamarind, thin and cheerful and a little flat: four rising notes, a drop, the same four again. A fishing song. *Pull and pull, the tide is coming in.* Ammu had hummed it through every bad night of their childhood, and Neela would have known it through a wall.

She did not turn her head. She finished with the lamp-oil man, who had shorted his measure by a thumb, and paid him the fair price with a smile that cost him the other thumb. Then she said to the boy at her elbow, "Unni. Isn't your mother's stall by the fish racks?"

Unni went the colour of a plum. He was thin as a ladle and not much past twenty. "Janu said I wasn't to leave you, lady."

"Janu said you weren't to lose me. The whole market can see me, and I can see the whole market. Go and let your mother feed you. I'll call it guarding."

He went almost at a run.

Thirty-four nights. She had counted them on waking, with the hollow shake of the morning still in her hands. She walked toward the tamarind slowly, a warden's wife with a market basket, and let the song get louder.

The stall was three sacks and a scale on a plank. Behind it sat a girl in a patched cotton wrap, her hair oiled flat, her face burned brown by a

coast sun that had not been hers a month ago. A tally string hung at her belt. She looked up, and her whole face broke open and was put back together as a trader's.

"Chechi!" said Ammu. "Lady, I mean, lady. Come, come. For the warden's wife the good sack."

In the market, a poor girl might call a richer woman elder sister and nobody would blink. Neela took the stool Ammu kicked toward her. "What's your name, girl?"

"Valli, lady. Coast-side, up with the last cart before the passes shut." Her eyes went over Neela's face, her throat, the high collar, and came back satisfied. "Black pepper. Heavier than hill pepper. Lady has a nose for it, I hear."

"Who says?"

"The whole market. They say the warden's wife can grade a berry blind." Ammu began scooping into the scale, and her voice dropped under the clatter without losing its sing-song. "They say the warden is tall. They say he never smiles and never raises his voice, and the women at the well are split on whether that's a husband or a wall. Which is it, chechi?"

"He tells me the guard rota."

Ammu's scoop stopped. "He what?"

"Over supper. Unasked."

"The old man will faint with joy." Ammu choked the laugh down into the scale. "A handsome man who tells you where all the knives are. Chechi, you've married a gift."

"I've married a ledger." Neela turned a berry in her fingers. It was the coast kind, well dried. "Say what you came to say."

Ammu weighed the pepper twice, which no honest trader does. When she spoke, the sing-song was gone, and the voice underneath was soft and patient and a little sad. It was an excellent copy.

"*Tell Seventeen the writ is on the road.* That's him, word for word. *After it lands, every day counts double. If the account stands open when the pass closes, I'll put the resin on her myself, and at dusk I'll read her page aloud where she can hear it. I would grieve, child. I always do.*"

Neela did not move. She had been braced for it since the jackal's call in the dark, and it still went through her like cold water.

Forced resin was not a thing you forgot hearing described. The scars tore open. You bled for days. You turned because the sun went down, with a man standing in the room, and then he read the page.

She counted the sacks. Three. She counted the coins in her sleeve. Seven.

"The marriage writ?" she said.

"He didn't say. He said it like it was a harvest." Ammu tied off the pepper. "Give me something for the cart, chechi."

There was a great deal she could have given her. That the sentry above the window had vanished two nights ago. That the hounds were kennelled at dusk. That there was a goat-boy's hand in her torn cloth, and a man at supper who had not stopped an old woman's leopard story. That a cat on a parapet had made her laugh until she cried, and a breath behind her had stumbled on the beat.

Every one of them was a thing she could not explain. Ammu would call the sentry luck and the hounds a quirk, and then she would carry them to Chathu, and Chathu would tell Neela what they meant.

"The weak hour is the last dark one," Neela said. "Before first light. I haven't proved it. I need ten days."

"Ten! He said—"

"He says what he says from a chair in the Wood. I'm the one in the room."

Ammu looked at her a moment longer than a trader should. Then she shrugged and reached for the cloth to wrap the packet. "Ten, then. I'll make it sound like nine."

She was humming again, tunelessly, the four notes over and over. Neela watched her fingers on the cloth. They were quick and square and had a nick across one knuckle that was new.

"Kirri's letters," Neela said. "Has she answered?"

The humming stopped.

"I wrote her again," Ammu said brightly. "That's three. Nothing yet. She's out on the water at dawn, hauling nets. She'll never have the hands for a pen again, she'll have rope-hands. And she couldn't spell *tide* when she was the big girl teaching us our letters." She tucked the packet into the basket with a flourish. "Busy, chechi. That's all. A woman with a boat has no time for sisters."

It was the right sort of joke, and it was a half beat too fast. The laugh after it was too round.

Neela said, "Three is a lot of letters for a woman with a boat."

"I'm a sister who pesters."

"You are."

They looked at each other over the pepper. The word *released* sat between them, and neither of them picked it up. It was the thing the twelfth contract bought. It was the door at the end of the road, the burned page and the birth name and the boat on the water. Neela had never in her life asked what stood on the other side of it, because there had never been anything to ask.

Her own voice came out low and flat. "If anyone ever saw me, Ammu, I'd be finished. Release or no release. You know that."

Neela hadn't known she was going to say it. A breath had hitched, on the beat of a laugh. She wanted someone to tell her it was nothing.

Ammu's hands went quite still on the cloth. "Not always," she said.

"What?"

"Not always. There's a way, chechi." Her voice had gone very small and very fast. "It costs, it costs a great deal, but there's a way if the one who sees you is—"

She stopped.

She was not looking at Neela. She was looking past her shoulder, and her face had gone blank and pale.

Neela did not turn. She had spent twenty years not turning her head. She let her eyes go idle across the lane and came to the next stall along, three paces off, where a woman was selling turmeric in yellow heaps. A

big man in a captain's plain coat was leaning on her plank with a hand full of her best root, laughing at something she had said.

Muthu.

"—costs two panam the measure," Ammu said loudly, "and that's cheap, lady, that's near robbery on my own mother!"

Neela leaned in over the scale, as if to haggle, and mouthed it. *What way?*

"Buy the pepper."

"Ammu."

"Buy the *pepper*, chechi." The brightness in her eyes was something close to fear. Neela had seen it twice in twenty years. The last time was the night of a first turning, when a fourteen-year-old girl had held her friend's hand in a locked room and watched what she became. "It's a market story. It's nothing. I talk."

It was not nothing. There were few things the Resin House punished harder than failure, and one of them was telling a member what the masters had not. Whatever Ammu had been about to say, she had learned it somewhere she was not meant to, and she had nearly said it three paces from a captain of the warden's own guard.

"Lady Neela!" Muthu had seen her. He swung round, still grinning, turmeric yellow on his palm. "Down among the honest thieves. Where's your shadow?"

"Eating fish," said Neela. Her voice came out as pleasant as a bell. "I let him off."

"Poor Unni. He'll talk about it for a year." He looked at the stall and at Ammu, and Ammu bowed her head and became the least interesting girl in the market. "Who's this?"

"Valli. Coast pepper. She's honest, which is rare."

"Is she? Then I'll take four measures for the mess." He dropped coins on the plank without counting them. "The warden hates market day, did you know? He says it's all noise. I say that's the point of it." He winked. "He'll be along. Bet you a copper. He's heard I'm down here with the garrison's purse and he can't bear it."

"Why would he come down for you?"

"Oh, not for me." Muthu laughed his big laugh and the pigeons went up from the tamarind. "Valli, four measures, and don't skimp."

Ammu measured. Neela watched her, and the girl did not look up once, and under her breath she hummed. It was the fishing song. Pull, and pull, and the tide was coming in.

*

He came at the foot of the lane, as Muthu had said, in his plain brown coat with no sword and no escort. He stopped at the edge of the market and looked at nothing, the way a man looks when he has been told where to find something.

Neela was a long way from the stall by then, with a basket of lamp oil, turmeric and pepper on her arm, and she had told herself she would not look back. She looked back. Ammu had a customer, an old man with a goat, and her head was bent.

"Warden," she said.

"Neela." He fell into step beside her. "Unni says you let him off."

"You've been speaking to him."

"He was coming up the road with a pomfret. He looked as if he'd been given a kingdom." A pause. "I had business with the salt factor."

"Down here."

"He keeps his tallies down here."

It was a good answer, and it was true as far as she could tell. It also did not explain why a man who hated market day had left the fort with no escort on the one afternoon she was out of it. By any count she made, there were three ways he could have known where to find her, and only one was an accident.

Followed, she thought. And then: *or he came for his captain.* And then, coldly, because it was how she had been taught: *or he came to watch whom I talked to.*

Her fingers tightened on the basket. He glanced at them, then at her face, and held out his hand for it.

"I can carry it," she said.

"I know." His hand stayed where it was.

She let go a beat too late. He took the weight without comment, but she saw him note the beat, and she saw that he had decided not to mention it. She noticed herself noticing, and walked on.

They went up the road through the lower village, where the houses were laterite and thatch and the cattle moved aside for no one, and a child stood in a doorway with a stick in her fist, guarding a hen.

The woman was at the third house. Neela knew her at once, without having been introduced, because she had stood next to her at the well for a quarter of an hour two mornings ago. Parukutty. Mid-thirties, a bad shoulder from the water pots, a daughter of six and a son of nine. Her husband had been a spearman on the wall, and he had been dead since spring.

A man stood in front of her door with a slate under his arm. He had the soft voice and the sad, level face of a collector. "I'm not unfeeling," he was saying. "The factor isn't unfeeling. But it's the fourth month, Parukutty. It's six measures and a half, and he can only carry a thing so long."

"After harvest," she said. "The queen's gift comes after harvest."

"The factor doesn't wait for harvest."

The warden's step slowed. He said, "Wait here," as if he had remembered a small errand, and put the basket back into her hands, and walked up the lane.

He did not hurry. He did not raise his voice. He spoke to the collector for no longer than it takes to say a name, and the man's face changed, and he took a cord of coins from Devan's hand without looking at the amount. The slate came out from under his arm. A thumb wiped it. Parukutty stood in her doorway holding her shoulder and watched the slate go clean, and did not understand it. The collector said something low and quick, and bowed, and went down the lane the other way.

The warden was already walking back.

He passed the doorway without a glance. The woman called after the collector once, bewildered, and then went in, and a moment later a child's voice rose, high and delighted, about the hen.

"Raman," Neela said, when he reached her. "That was her husband's name."

"Yes."

"Six measures and a half of salt."

"And a tally fee." He took the basket again, and this time she let it go on time. "The factor adds a charge when a debt passes a month."

"The queen's death-gift would have paid it."

"At harvest." He walked. "It's three months till harvest."

The road was steep here, and red dust rose around their feet. She was thinking of tins of jaggery sweets, warm from the kitchen, sent before a death. *For luck, child.* She was thinking of how every gift she had ever been given had arrived with its price written in a hand she couldn't read.

"Do you know every widow's debt?" she said. She meant it as a test, and made it light so it would not sound like one.

"Four widows on the wall rolls owe the factor," said Devan. "That was the largest. The other three I will see to by the new moon."

"By the new moon." She kept her eyes on the road. "You've done your sums."

"Yes."

"And you'll tell no one, and this one won't know whom to thank."

"That is the arrangement."

"A tidy arrangement," she said dryly. "It leaves nobody anything to hold against you."

His step checked, once, and went on. He did not look at her. But the corner of his mouth moved, as it had over the green wax, and she understood that she had named the thing he'd left unsaid, and that he knew she had. It was not a comfortable thing to have been understood by.

"Why?" she said.

He didn't pretend not to follow. "He died on my patrol."

"That's a date, not a reason."

"It's the reason I have."

He said it as he said everything: exact, unpadded, with nothing in it to hold on to. If she had thanked him he would have gone out of the room. She had known him six days, and she already knew it. He had not looked behind him once to see whether the woman saw.

It was the fourth thing he had done like that. The pulled sentry. The hounds. The shutters barred at dusk. And now this. Each time she had put it down to a hunter's craft, a man laying out a long patience for a long purpose. A hunter did lay out patience. She had never known a hunter to wipe a stranger's slate and tell no one.

He is keeping a book, she thought. But Chathu kept a book too, and his was the kind that came to collect. This one, she was beginning to think, was the sort a man keeps against himself.

It was inconvenient, and she did not want to think it. She had thirty-four nights and a man to kill, and a pair of hands that were still not quite steady from the dawn.

"You're quiet," said the warden.

"I'm counting."

"What?"

"Steps." It was half true. She'd lost the count at the well.

He nodded as though that were a reasonable thing for a bride to do. Up the road ahead, the laterite wall of Kettamala rose red against the sky, with the padippura dark at its foot. The cistern chain clanked the hour across the fields.

At the gate he stopped, and held out the basket. She took it. Her fingers closed on the handle and on the pepper packet wedged beside the oil jar, and found Ammu's knot through the cloth. Not a trader's single tie. A fisherman's double hitch, the one two girls had once learned from a net-mender behind the sheds, and had tied on everything for a summer.

There's a way, chechi, but it costs.

The chain clanked again. The warden went in under the arch, and Neela stood a moment in its shadow with her thumb on the knot. She did not undo it.

Tonight she would take the second spur, and she would leave a written question under the meeting stone, whatever it cost Ammu to answer.

Chapter 8

The Unlit Lamp

"Leave it dark," Devan said.

Raiu stopped with the taper half raised. The corridor lamp hung in its iron bracket across from the chamber door, a clay lamp with a fresh wick and a full belly of oil, filled every dusk since the wedding. The boy looked at it, then at the warden, then at it again.

"Dark, Warden?"

"It saves oil."

"Janu fills it herself. She'll say—"

"She'll say I never counted oil in my life. She'll be right, and it will still be dark."

Raiu's mouth worked on that. He was nineteen, with a cowlick no water had ever beaten, and Devan had needed four months and two askings to learn his name. He had not lost it since. "Where do I stand, then?"

"Head of the stair. If I want you, you'll hear me."

"And the lady, if she wakes and wants a light?"

"The lady has a five-cup lamp at her window and a husband with a flint." Devan took the taper from his hand, pinched the flame out between finger and thumb, and gave it back. "Go on."

The boy went, wondering. Devan stood in the blue passage and listened to the fort settle. The chain clanked the hour at the cistern. A pot rang in the kitchen.

It did not save oil. A lit lamp laid a gold bar under the door and across the floor, and at first light that bar would reach the window corner, where a woman came over the ledge shaking, with nothing on her, to find her clothes. At the watch change a guard with a lit lamp would also try the latch, as guards did. Devan wanted no lamp near that door at that hour. Not Raiu's, nor Raiu's shadow stirring in it.

He had lain through every dawn since the wedding with his eyes shut and his breath counted. He had learned the sound of her coming in, which was almost none.

Inside, Neela stood at the window with a taper of her own, trimming the bird lamp's five wicks. She did not turn.

"Raiu's gone from the passage."

"I sent him to the stair."

"Why?"

"So the passage stays dark."

She looked at him over her shoulder, head a little on one side, and he watched her take the answer and set it down with the others. There was a row of them by now. He knew she was keeping them. He did not know what she thought the row added up to.

"Then mine can keep it company," she said, and pinched out the wick.

*

Muthu came to the hall with the morning meal still on his chin.

They had the end of the long table to themselves. On a slate Devan had laid two squares of beeswax, each warmed the night before and pressed over a seal. One came from the tally in the dead raider's satchel. One came from a true tally out of Bhaskaran's gate chest. Beside them lay a stack of old council tallies, a year of brick-red wax that smelled of cloves.

"Pepper sprig," said Muthu, squinting. "I've seen a sprig."

"Look at the stem."

Muthu looked. Devan watched him go from cheerful to attentive. It was a quick road, and one reason he had made him captain.

"The council keeps seven tally seals," Devan said. "Each is cut with a private mark at the stem, so a clerk can tell whose box a tally left. Four have a bar. Three have a dot with a split under it." He set a fingertip on the forged impression. "This is a dot with a split."

"So it's one of three boxes."

"Or a copy of one."

"A copy's hard. The dies were cut by the palace engraver, and he's older than the queen." Muthu sat back. A laugh started low in his chest and came out big. "Chief. Come. You know what the treasury clerks are. They'd press a tally for a cousin and take a measure of arrack for the trouble. Some boy lent his master's seal to oblige a friend, and the friend sold it on. It's carelessness. The whole council runs on it. I once saw a minister sign a writ on the back of a fish."

"The wax is a month old and poured with clove oil."

"Then a careful careless clerk."

"Careless doesn't deliver to Thurai."

The laugh ran down. Muthu turned a square of beeswax over with one thick finger. "Three boxes," he said. "That's a lot of councillors to insult on a guess."

"It isn't a guess."

"No." He slid the slate back, gently. "Who else knows?"

"You."

"Then I'm the lucky one." He grinned, a shade late. "I'll keep it behind my teeth. Who would I tell?"

It was the only odd note in the whole talk, and too small to hold. Muthu liked to talk, and no man likes to hear that his masters might be thieves. Devan put it by.

"Four days to the seventh day," Muthu said, rising. "One round in the pit. I'll let you win."

"No."

"Eight years of no. One day I'll catch you on a yes."

"Eat something," Devan said, which was how he said *thank you for asking*. Muthu wiped his chin and went out whistling.

Devan stayed with the wax. Three seals. Three councillors, or three people with keys. Not one name yet, but the circle was thinner than the fort wall had been that morning. He began to put the squares away in a cloth and found he was thinking about a bride.

*

At noon the sun stood straight over Kettamala and the red stone gave the heat back. Devan sat in the shade of the parapet's turn with his sword across his knees and watched the pass. A cart crawled up it. On the far cliff the langurs argued, loud and unconcerned. When strangers came, they would go quiet. They were not quiet.

"Janu says you haven't eaten."

Neela came along the walk with a covered brass dish held out in front of her like a thing that might go off. She wore the day kasavu from her trousseau, the gold border mended with small neat stitches where she had torn it for Kannan's hand.

"She said it to me, to Chinna, to the goat," she went on. "I came to see if you were alive."

"I am."

"I'll tell her. She'll be disappointed." She set the dish on the stone between them and sat on the parapet, a yard off, with her feet drawn up. Rice, fish, a green mash he didn't know. He ate. She watched him do it as she watched everything, the way a woman watches a lock.

"Can I ask something?"

"You will."

"Why do you never laugh first?" She tipped her head toward the yard below. "Muthu laughs at everything. Janu laughs at her own scolding. At supper someone says something funny and everyone looks at you, and you wait."

"I wait to learn whether the joke is at someone's expense."

"And then?"

"Then I know whether to laugh."

"That isn't a reason. That's a ledger."

"It's both."

She studied him a moment. Something moved behind her face, quick and wary, and then it put on a different look, almost sly. "Then here is one at mine," she said. "Safe to laugh at. I have a signed letter from the Chirayil house that says I can haggle a lamp-oil man down to his last thumb. Yesterday I won a thumb. Today Kannan's goat looked me in the eye, took a bite out of my sleeve, and I paid her in full. Nine generations of pepper traders, undone by an animal named after the stock."

For a breath he only looked at her.

Then it came up out of him, short and rough from disuse, and he heard it ring off the laterite. He put the back of his hand to his mouth. It went on a little behind it.

She was staring. Not guarded, not counting. She looked as if she had found a coin in a coat she had thought was empty.

"That," she said, "is the first time."

"It's the second."

"When was the first?"

"A long time before you." He lowered his hand. "I'll tell you the goat bit hard, though. I've seen her take a man's boot."

"You're laughing again."

"I won't answer that."

"Your ears are."

Asha had laughed first at everything. She had laughed at the quartermaster, at a bad bridge, at Devan himself, and then looked round to see who was in on it. Since the west stair he had waited, and waited, and been very sure whose expense it was at. He had not noticed how long it had been since he laughed at a thing because it was funny.

And he had been given hers once already, by theft. He thought of the ledge in the grey, and a sneezing ginger tom, and a woman shaking with silent laughter while he lay with his teeth in his lip and his breath gone

wrong. He had hidden then. Now he could sit in the sun and be answered.

She ate a piece of fish from the dish with her fingers, and he saw the question come up in her, and saw her weigh it. The lower market. A man in a plain brown coat at the foot of a lane, with no escort and no sword. He had stood in the shade of the tamarind wall for the better part of a quarter hour before Muthu's laugh drew every eye and gave him cover to walk in. He had watched a girl with a pepper scale weigh the same measure twice. He had watched his wife listen with her back like a drawn string.

The business with the salt factor had been real. It had also been the second reason.

If she asked, he would say, *I won't answer that.* It was the truth, and she would hear it as a door.

She wiped her fingers on her sleeve. Her mouth opened, and she closed it again.

"Is that all the green stuff?" she said.

"It's all of it."

"Janu will ask."

"Tell her I ate it."

"Did you?"

"I will now." He took the dish, and neither of them said anything about anything else. It was the kindest silence anyone had given him in years, and the most dangerous.

*

Unni came up the steps two at a time, red in the face, with a leather case held against his chest in both arms.

"Warden! Rider from Kodiyur. Registry blue. He wouldn't climb, said his orders were the gate, so I said I'd carry it, and he said sealed and into your hand and no one else's, and I said I'm *a* hand—" He ran out of breath.

"Well done," said Devan, and took the case.

The seal on the cord was council wax, dull brick red, the pepper sprig pressed clean. He broke it with his thumb. Inside was a single folded sheet of registry paper, thick and creamy, covered in a clerk's even black hand. The marriage writ, back from the palace record with the registrar's stamp at the foot.

Neela had come to stand at his shoulder, as a wife would. He tilted the page so she could see. He had never hidden a page from her, and he would not begin with one that carried her name.

It was a long writ and a dull one. Her ward-name, Chirayil, and the house's witnesses. His own title. The date of the sunset rite. The settlement of cloth, brass and four hundred panam, and the usual sentence about the wife's duty to the household. He read down it without hurry, as one reads something already seen done.

Near the foot, in the same flat clerk's ink, ran a clause that stopped him.

...and the said wife, being lawfully wed, shall hold the pass-seal of Kettamala in trust from the hour of the warden's death, until the council shall name another in his place.

He read it a second time.

The custom, as he had always known it, sent the seal to the captain of the fort when a warden died. There was an old line in the charter that sent it to a wife instead, if the warden had one. No warden had married in office in living memory. He had never given the line a thought, as a man gives no thought to a door in a house where he lives alone. Now it stood in black ink with the registrar's stamp under it. He was married, and a stranger would keep the seal.

A stranger. Chosen by the council. A ward from a house nobody at Kettamala had met, who had come up the hill with a bangle and a lamp and a quiet manner. The council whose wax sold passes to Thurai had pressed this match. They had pressed it in a hurry, and were pleased with themselves. The chain ran in his head: the council, the match, the widow, and the coast girl who had weighed twice.

If he died, the seal did not go to Muthu. It did not go to Bhaskaran. It went to whoever slept beside him.

The cold of it ran down his arms. He had thought of the marriage as a door the council had left open for a knife. He had not thought the marriage might itself be the thing they wanted done. A wife who was an odiyan, sent into his bed. A dead warden with leopard marks and a widow in black, calm, with the pass-seal in her lap. A widow could be steered. A widow could be set aside, afterwards, with no one the wiser.

And the woman at his shoulder either knew it, or she did not. If she did not, she was a blade never told whose hand she was in. If she did, then he had laughed beside her on a hot wall an hour ago, and she had let him.

He could not make himself believe the second. He marked that, as he would have marked a weak place in the wall. Either way, she had to stay alive and near. Dead, she told no one anything. Alive, she knew the name of the hand that held her.

Unni shifted his feet, waiting. A langur barked and was answered. Devan raised his eyes from the page to say something light, so that she would not see him read it a third time.

Neela was looking at the writ. Her face had gone still, as water goes still just before it takes a shape. For the first time since the wedding, she was not watching him at all, only the page, and he could not tell whether she was reading it or remembering it.

Chapter 9

The Goat Path

Janu had got as far as the yellow eyes when the warden put down his cup.

"—and my grandmother swore it came down the pass every dry-season dusk," Janu said, ladling rice onto Neela's plate without being asked, "big as a cart-pony, with a coat like spilled lamp oil, and it took a man off the road above the second ford. Just took him. Left his sandals standing side by side, neat as a prayer. And the next night it came for—"

"Not tonight, Janu."

He said it quietly, with his eyes on the rice. The old woman's ladle stopped in the air. For a moment Neela thought she would argue. Janu argued with the cistern chain.

"No," Janu said. "No, well." She set the ladle down. "It's a bad tale for supper anyway. Eat, child. You're all wrists."

Neela ate. She watched the warden over the rim of her cup.

He did not look up. He tore his bread and ate it. Two seats down, Muthu opened his mouth for a joke and thought better of it, which was strange in itself. She turned it over and found the simplest reading. Some men could not abide a story. Her own guardian's accountant had been the same, and had walked out of rooms if anyone began a song.

He dislikes stories, she decided. She set it on the shelf with his other dislikes: market day, bells, gratitude. There was no harm in a man who

hated stories. It was a good thing to know about the man she was going to kill.

She did not think about the pass-seal. She had read that clause twice at his shoulder, kept her face as still as water, and put it away where she kept things she could not use yet. Nor did she think about how it had felt when he went quiet beside her.

"The council has written," Devan said, to the table in general. "They expect the warden's wife to be shown to the pass villages. They want her seen." A pause so small she would not have heard it a week ago. "I'll take her down to the lower waystation tomorrow. I need to inspect it anyway."

"Both birds," said Muthu. "One stone."

"Eat something, Muthu."

Neela said, "Will I be inspected as well?"

"Only by the goats," said Devan.

Janu laughed so hard she had to sit.

*

Thirty-two nights.

She woke to the count, to the hollow shake in her hands, and to the thought that today she would watch him work. Watching was her work. For eight days she had mapped his chamber, his rota and his hours, and he had handed her half of it unasked. She had not once seen him do his real work, on a road, away from walls.

By the first mile she knew three things about him, and the first was that he was slow.

He did not take the cart road at a trot. He sent Unni ahead, then called him back, then sent him ahead again when the ridge showed bare. At every bend he stopped his pony and sat listening. He checked his own girth, and then hers, without comment. He had her walk the last stretch before the first village, so that people would see a woman on foot with her husband, and not a bride carried in on a beast.

"We'll be there by noon at this rate," Neela said, "if the monsoon holds off."

"It will."

"I've seen a snail with more ambition."

"The snail isn't carrying anyone." His gaze stayed on the road. "Nobody is asked to be fast on this road. They're asked to arrive."

She thought it was caution of the dullest kind. A man with that many men and that many walls had no business creeping like a thief. She made a note of the pauses anyway. He stopped at every bend, always for the same count of ten. At the third ford he went across upstream of the usual crossing. He never used the same place twice. A man who wished to be waited for would be easy to wait for. Without meaning to, he had given her a lesson in how not to be.

She did not like how much she wanted to ask him why.

The villages came and went. Women at the wells looked her over and decided, and she knew most of the names by the second house. Saroja, who sang at the well. A grandfather called Kesu with one eye. A girl who held up a hen as a gift, and was told by her mother in a furious whisper to put it down. Devan stood by with his hands behind him, silent, while Neela said everything that was needed. She sensed him watching her do it. Twice he nearly spoke.

The langurs started in the early afternoon, on the cliff above the narrow gorge below the last village. They had been barking all morning, a hoarse and tireless racket that bounced off the rock until you stopped hearing it.

They stopped.

All of them, together. The silence came down the pass like a cloth dropped over a cage.

Devan's hand went up. Unni's pony stopped dead. Neela, who had her hand on the bridle already, felt the back of her neck prickle in a way that had nothing to do with him.

"Strangers," she said softly.

"On the road, or above it." He did not turn his head. "Both of you stay."

He went forward alone. She watched him go. He did not draw his sword. He walked his pony to the bend and stopped for ten counts, and then he made a small flat gesture to Unni that said, quite plainly, *back*. It occurred to her that the slowness had been a tool for a day exactly like this one, and that she had been laughing at the wrong end of it.

The rockfall lay beyond the bend.

It had come off the cliff and filled the cart road wall to wall. Red-brown boulders the size of oxen, slabs of sheared laterite, a drift of loose stone to the knee. Fresh dust still clung to the biggest, and the air tasted of it.

"Dry week," Devan said, when she came up. "Dry cliff. Nothing rains stone on a dry week."

"Rock falls."

"It does. Not at the one place on the road where a cart has to stop." He glanced at the rim, where the langurs sat motionless in the thorn. "Somebody wants us standing here, looking at it."

Her body had gone cold and easy, the way it did before work. She counted the ways out. The way they had come was open. A line of boulders at the foot of the slope made a good place for a bow. The cliff offered a ledge she would have chosen herself.

"Unni," said Devan. "Back to the fort. Tell Bhaskaran the road is shut at the gorge, and I want twenty men with bars. Go by the high ford."

"Warden, I'm to guard the—"

"You're to ride. Go."

Unni went. His pony's hooves faded up the track, and the silence closed behind them.

Devan turned to her. He was working out how to ask her to wait somewhere safe, she could see, and also working out that there was nowhere safe. For the first time she saw him honestly at a loss. It did not look like weakness. It looked like a man laying two bad choices on a scale.

"There's a path," Neela heard herself say.

"I know of none."

"Left of the split rock. Up the scree and over the shoulder, then down through the thorn to the old well. Goats take it." She was already moving. "Give me the pony."

She did not know why she said it. Her feet knew. They had turned toward a gap in the thorn that she could not see yet, and she followed them, and there it was, a threadbare line of dung and beaten earth no wider than a hand, rising behind a boulder cloven by lightning. She had not looked for the rock. It had been where she expected it.

Left of the split rock.

Nobody had told her that. She had read the scouting notes on the pass until her eyes burned. There was no goat path in them.

She went up the scree with the pony's bridle in her fist. Behind her she heard the warden's boots, steady, a half pace slower than hers on purpose. He did not ask until they were over the shoulder and the thorns closed in.

"How do you know this?"

"How do you know where a ford is shallow?"

"I walk it."

"Then you know what I'd say." She kept her back to him. "Mind the root. It's on the left."

There was a root on the left. She heard him step round it.

"That isn't an answer," he said.

"No. It's a question, and you've asked it the wrong way round." She glanced back, and his face was calm, but his eyes were on her feet. "Would it help you to know, Warden? Or would it just be something else you kept?"

He considered that, with the same patient weight he gave every question. "I won't ask again today."

"That's generous."

"It's not generous. It's tactics." The path bent, and he followed. "I would like you to keep on knowing it."

The old well was where she had known it would be. They came down through the thorn into a quiet fold of the hills, and below them, a long bowshot off, stood the lower waystation. They had come around the rockfall in the time it took the langurs to start up again, all at once, loud and bored and scolding. The strangers, whoever they were, had gone on.

Neela stood still a moment with the bridle in her hand. She had a strong wish to sit down.

*

The waystation was a low laterite house with a well, a long carters' shed, and a yard trodden to powder. No one lived there between the seasons. A spiked board by the door said that the warden's tally was needed for the pass. The gate stood open.

Devan went into the yard like a man entering a sickroom.

He crouched. He did not touch anything. He studied the ground for the better part of a hundred counts, and she stood at the gate and watched his eyes travel, left to right and back, the way a clerk's do down a column.

"Six men," he said. "Two nights back, not three. They came in from the north on foot and left to the north on foot, before dawn. One of them dragged his right foot a little. Here, and here. Two lit a fire in the shed, with the door shut so the glow wouldn't show. They slept in shifts." He bent over a smear of ash. "They ate a hot meal, so someone fed them. Rice. This was a rest, not a raid."

"How do you know it was rice?"

"Because one of them dropped the husk." He held up a pinch of it. "Raiders from the coast live on dried fish. These men weren't hungry. They were waiting for something."

"For what?"

"A cart." He stood. "I don't know yet. Tell me what you see."

She had not meant to go in. She went in and crouched at the edge of the churned dust, where the clay was damp at the well's lip, and the prints were sharp as stamped wax. It was not tracking. She could not

have followed those men over a hill. This was the other thing, the thing the guild had drilled into her until it stopped being a skill and became a habit of the eye. It was the study of feet.

A hundred patrols had walked past her window, and she had learned them by their boots.

"They aren't raiders, or not the way you mean," she said. "Look at the heel. This one is ground flat, straight down, in a ring. He's stood a lot of watches in one spot. Soldier. And this pair." She tapped a print. "The outer edge is worn thin, left more than right. That's a man who rides. Somebody trained them, and fed them, and these soles aren't a month old. A town cobbler did the stitching. See the double row?"

"I see a line."

"It's two lines, close together, in thread that was waxed. Coast work. Nothing from up here. They've been mended for a long road by someone who could pay for it." She looked up. "These men didn't walk from the sea. They were brought most of the way, and set down."

He was quiet. Then he said, slowly, "I'd have said six men on foot."

"I'd have said six men."

"I'd have missed the boots entirely."

"I'd never have found the husk." She heard herself add, drily, "Or the foot."

"The foot was easy."

"For you."

The corner of his mouth moved. She watched it, helplessly, as she would have watched a knot come loose.

They stood in a dead yard with a well and a fire-black shed, and between them they had made the thing whole. One of them would have had half of it. Neither could have had the rest. He had read where they went and how, and she had read who they were. In twenty years she had never met someone whose skill ended where hers began.

She did not like it. She was careful to be clear to herself about that.

"Whoever sent them," Devan said, "wants me to find this, or wants me to find nothing. I can't tell which." He nodded at the shed. "Neither can you."

"No."

"Good." He seemed to mean it. "I'd distrust you if you could."

*

They rode home at dusk by the cart road. The twenty men with bars had reached the fall by late afternoon and cut a lane through it, wide enough for ponies led single file, and the langurs had greeted the sight of them with a roar of professional outrage.

Neela rode alone beside the warden. The men and their bars had gone back an hour ago.

The light was going. Over the western ridge a long bank of cloud had been building all afternoon, the first heavy cloud she had seen that year, bruise-purple underneath and gold along its edges. The wind had changed. It carried a smell she had not met since the spring, of dust waiting for water.

She had no resin.

She had not carried it. No woman carries a flask to inspect a waystation. It lay in its fold of cloth, in a chest, in a room with a lamp she had pinched out last night. The sun was going down on a road two miles from a gate, and for the first time since the wedding night she was nothing but what she looked like: a woman on a pony, with a tired back, beside a man.

No ache would count tonight. One night did not matter. She would take the resin when she reached her room, and be gone before the moon.

Not yet.

One mile, she thought. She let it be a small bargain, with no one to witness it. She would have this for one mile.

He rode half a length ahead, as he always did, so that his shoulder covered hers. He had said nothing for a long time. He did not fill silence.

She had once thought that was a trap, a man leaving a gap for her to fall into. Now it seemed more like a courtesy. He was leaving her room.

"You were right about the boots," he said at last.

"I was."

"You'd make a good tracker."

"I'd make a bad one. I'd find the shoes and forget the road." She watched the cloud. "You'd make a good thief."

"Why?"

"You know where people put their feet. That's all stealing is."

He laughed, once, short and low, like the one on the wall. She felt it in her chest.

She was not afraid. Out on the hill tonight she would have been a quarter mile from the fort, belly low, ears forward, every hair a nerve, a creature that did not trust the wind. Here she could hear the pony's hooves and a man's breath and her own voice with nothing behind it. She could smell clay and thorn and the coming rain. The man she was paid to kill rode a length ahead with his back to her.

She did not look at the back of his neck. Not for any good purpose.

The first mile ended at a milestone, a squat worn thing with a pepper sprig cut in its face. She saw it come and she did not look away. The second began.

The wind pushed a long cold breath down the pass. High up, the first drop struck her hand, big and warm.

"Rain," said the warden, and then, after a moment, "A real one."

She almost laughed. She didn't know why.

Ahead, the lamps of Kettamala came on, one at a time, up the red wall. She counted them without meaning to. Eleven. Then she started the road again from the beginning, as if she had something to learn by it, and could not think what.

She still had no idea how she had known the path.

Chapter 10

The Broken Beak

Forty-four steps.

Neela counted them up the west stair in the wet red morning, and at the landing she kept going. Forty-five. Forty-six. She stood with one hand on the cold rail while the number ticked over in her head like the cistern chain, and she could not make it stop.

It had begun at the bottom.

She had come to map an approach. The stair climbed the west face of the keep from the lower court to the passage outside the warden's door. Two guards on it by night, Devan had told her himself, and Raiu at the head since the lamp went dark. She wanted to know where the stone rang, where the shadow lay, how many steps a body could cover before a man on the landing heard. It was ordinary work. She had done it in a dozen houses and slept well after.

The newel post at the foot was a carved parrot, a forearm long, its wings cut flat against its sides. Someone had loved the thing once. The beak had snapped off at the root long ago, and years of passing palms had worn the stump to a river stone. She had laid her hand on it as anyone would, to start the climb, and her fingers had closed round the stump as if it had been shaped for them.

Her stomach dropped, like a foot that finds no stair where the stair should be.

She stood ten counts with her hand locked on a wooden bird. Nothing happened. A pot rang in the kitchen. The court steamed in the sun. Then she let go and wiped her palm down her kasavu and told herself it was hunger. The morning after the other one was always a hole in her, and holes made the mind jump.

So she had climbed, and counted, and now she was on the landing counting air.

She made herself look. A pala-wood rail. Steps dished in the middle by a hundred years of feet. At the eleventh step, a stone that rang hollow under her heel, over a drain slot. That was useful. A man at the head would hear that stone. She put *eleventh* away like a coin and went down, and at the foot her mind went on without her. Forty-five. Forty-six.

Names, then. It was what she always did. Kannan. Pepper, who bites. Chinna at the kitchen door. Gopan at the chain. Bhaskaran, Unni, Raiu with the cowlick. By Gopan the number had thinned to a mutter. By Raiu it was gone.

Janu stood at the cistern well, a good ten paces from the foot of the stair, with a cup in each hand. She held one out and did not come nearer. Neela crossed the court to take it.

"Buttermilk," Janu said. "You were up and down that stair like a squirrel. I watched from the kitchen. What are you hunting?"

"The best view of the pass."

"The best view is from the wall, where a woman has something to lean on." Janu drank and studied her over the rim. "You're grey. Did he keep you up?"

"The rain did."

"Mm." The old woman was not fooled, though she was fooled in the wrong direction. She lowered her voice, which for Janu meant that only the cistern, the kitchen and two sergeants could hear. "Since I have you alone. He's barred the shutters again."

Neela's cup stopped halfway. "Has he?"

"Don't play simple, child, they're your shutters. Every dusk since the wedding. Thirty years I've run this house, and that room stood open

every night it didn't storm. His father's rule. A room should breathe. Not once barred, not the winter his mother died. Now the bar goes across when I light the evening lamps, and the whole fort knows it. The girls talk of nothing else. Chinna has a wager."

"On what?"

"On why." Janu counted on her fingers like a clerk. "Bhaskaran's lads say a man with a new wife wants his privacy. Gopan says it's my grandmother's tale. A grown man, warden of the border, afraid of a story. I told Gopan the boy was never afraid of anything but quiet. Chinna says nothing and takes coin on all of it."

"And what do you say?"

"I say it's the damp. It gets into a man's head up here."

"He doesn't strike me as damp."

"He doesn't strike you as anything, he's a locked chest. That's why I'm telling you." Janu reached out a dry hand and pinched Neela's wrist, hard, as women do who feed people. "Ask him."

"I'd sooner ask the goat."

"The goat would answer." Janu took back the empty cup and looked her over again. "All wrists," she said, with deep dissatisfaction. She went back to the kitchen, giving the stair a wide berth that she did not seem to know she was giving.

Neela stood in the steaming court. The whole fort knew.

That was the part that turned in her like a key.

*

She did her sums in the warden's chamber, with the door shut and the shutters open to the afternoon.

The bar lay along the wall on its two hooks, seasoned teak, thick as her forearm. She could lift it one-handed. She leaned out over the ledge, set her palm to the slats and pushed. They held. A bar does not care what has claws.

She laid it out on her fingers.

The hounds, kennelled since the wedding, who had run the yard loose for years. The sentry pulled off the rampart above this window. The corridor lamp left dark. Raiu sent to the head of the stair. Four things, and every one of them let a hunter in.

Then the fifth. The bar, every dusk, known to every maid and goat-boy in Kettamala. It shut a beast out. It left exactly one living creature in the fort who could lift it from inside.

She sat on the ledge and said it plainly to the afternoon. A beast's work, found in a room no beast could enter, and beside the body a woman with a registry paper in her hand. The pass-seal in trust until the council named another. Two days ago she had read that clause at his shoulder and put it away to use. It had a second face. A widow in black with the seal in her lap. The council's men would not need an hour.

The crown would hang her for it, and that was the lesser ruin. Chathu would lose his best tool, and he balanced every loss in some other coin. Ammu was the nearest coin he had.

So. On purpose, or by chance?

By chance, he was a man who slept badly and feared the dark. Janu had said as much. Hounds shut in to spare their howling. A sentry pulled because Muthu complained of wall duty. Oil saved. A bar for a bad dream. Each was an ordinary order, and every one had a plain answer if she asked.

On purpose, he had distrusted the match from the start, as any man would. He knew what the council might send up his hill. And he had built a cage out of small orders, one at a time, each with its excuse, so that if the bride was what he feared, her kill would hang her. It was how she would have done it herself.

Neither reading cost her a seam. She tried them again from the other end and they held just as well.

She did not like not knowing. She liked even less how much she wanted to.

*

Thirty-one nights.

She counted them at dusk while he sat at the table with his cloth of wax squares and she sat at the window trimming the bird lamp. When the light went he got up and barred the shutters himself. She watched him do it. He lifted the bar, dropped it into the brackets, and the wood knocked once, softly. He did it like a man closing a purse. He did not look at her.

He lay down on his side of the bed. She waited, and counted his breath, and heard the small hitch come a third of the way through each long count.

Then she lifted the bar herself, in the dark, and stood it against the wall. She uncorked the flask. The smell was scorched tamarind and pine sap. She drew the cold smear over her throat and wrists, and the burn came up through the old scars like a name being called, and then the long pull, and the floor tilted away.

The hill took the hunger out of her first. She worked it down for hours, wet-bellied and quick, the way you work a cramp. Near the small hours she came back along the parapet where no sentry stood. The ginger tom on the wall gave her a long insulted look and left. She went in through the shutters she had unbarred and dropped to the floor without a sound.

The room came at her in smells. Sandalwood soap. Old iron from the sword that lay on the floor on her side of the bed, hilt toward her, as it had lain since the first night. She had never understood it. The cold, clean smell of the brass kindi on her side, spout toward the pillow. Full again. Janu's girls, she supposed. Janu filled everything.

She crossed to his side.

The bed was low. His throat lay a hand's length under her jaw, with the pulse moving in the notch of it, slow and even. The animal in her knew precisely what that was. The hunger said what it said. Her mind ran the kill to its end, one pass, quick and clean, and it was good work.

Then it ran on, as her mind always did, to what the kill would cost by morning.

Her eyes went down, away from the throat, and found his hand.

It lay on the blanket, palm down, fingers loose. The knuckles were ridged with old scars, pale and flat as split seeds, the kind a man gets from years of hitting wood and stone. Seven across the right hand. She counted them. A thin white line crossed the base of the thumb. It was a hand that had hit things for a long time and then stopped hitting anything that hit back, and she could read the stopping in it, the way she could read a path in a yard.

She did not know how long she stood. When she came to herself the count in her head had gone past sixty and she had done nothing.

Think.

No beast could carry this kill. That was why. She told herself so twice, and the second time she was still looking at his hand.

She lowered her head toward it. Slowly. Her whiskers trembled in the warmth coming off his skin, and she stopped a hair short, with her muzzle level with the scars and her breath moving the fine hair on his wrist.

His breath hitched. The fingers curled a little tighter against the blanket, as a sleeper's will, and eased, until they lay a finger's width from her nose.

She waited. He did not wake.

She drew back. She went across the stone floor, past the kindi and the hilt-first sword, and leapt to the sill. At the ledge she looked back once, which she did not do.

His hand still lay open on the blanket.

*

First light found her on the ledge, human, grey with cold and shaking from her teeth to her heels. The hollow came behind it, the sick wide hunger of the morning after. She went in over the sill with nothing on her and nothing in her, and crossed the room on a floor that felt like ice.

The kindi was where it always was. She drank from the spout with both hands, cold water running down her chin, and then she stood with her forehead against the brass and let her breath come back.

Behind her he slept.

Beasts were out, then. What was left was hands.

The guild had taught her the points before it taught her the other thing. There was one at the base of the skull, a thumb's width below the bone, that the old masters called the door. A man struck there with the right weight did not cry out, and he did not look like anything but a man who had fallen. A fall in a pit, in the dark, at the hour no one was watching. No bar. No beast. No bride at a window.

She pictured it as she would any job. The pit, the dark, her fingers finding the door. And in the picture his right hand came up unasked, the seven pale scars, to close on her wrist. Or it did not come up at all, and lay open on the red earth, and she was the one who had ended it.

Tactics, she decided. A man with that hand would block fast, and she should allow for it. She filed it where she had filed *no beast could carry this kill*, and it sat there badly.

Janu had given her the hour herself, and the pit lamps had shown her the place. He went down to the kalari under the east wall in the last dark hour, alone, with no guard and no witness.

The ache could count one night. Tomorrow she would leave the flask in its fold of cloth.

It was a good plan. She told it to the kindi and to the grey window, and no one argued.

Then she turned, and saw the window plainly, and the plan snagged.

It was first light. The sky in the shutter slats was the colour of dishwater, and the cistern chain had not yet clanked the hour. And he lay a yard from her, abed, breathing like a man with all morning to spend.

Janu said he rose in the last dark hour. This was the fourth first light she had come in off the hill and found him exactly so. Each time she had found a reason. A late night. A bad one. Janu's word against her own eyes, and she had let Janu's word win for a week.

Either the old woman was wrong, or he rose later than the fort believed, or he had stopped for a reason.

And if she was right, the pit was his. He had drilled in it ten thousand dawns. He would know every stone of the floor. She would have one strike, and no second.

So she would not trust a story. Tomorrow, human, in the dark hour, she would go down and see the pit for herself, and find the way to the door.

Behind her the hitch came, a third of the way through the count.

Chapter 11

Dawn Drill

The smell caught her halfway down the east path, and she was sick in the dirt before she knew it was coming.

There was little in her to lose. She knelt in the dark with one palm flat on the cold red ground and heaved up water and bile, while the thing that had done it hung in the damp air around her. It was sharp and green and rank, like a crushed bug on hot rubbish. Lantana. It grew down the whole slope under the east wall in tangled banks higher than her head, with flowers like small orange fists, and her feet had trodden a mat of its leaves into the path.

Neela had hated that smell for as long as she could remember, and had never found a reason. In the Resin House sheds she had been the one to stand upwind of any hedge being cut, a cloth tied over her face, and nobody had asked her why.

She wiped her mouth on her wrist and told herself her hands shook from the cold.

Thirty nights.

Last night she had lain beside him as nothing but a woman, the flask in its fold of cloth and the shutters barred. She had listened to him breathe. The small hitch had come a third of the way through each long count, over and over, until the last dark hour. Then the breathing had changed. The bed had moved by the width of a man leaving it, and there had been no other sound. She had counted sixty and followed.

Rising was something she had only ever heard of, from Janu and from the lamps in the pit. Now she stood up out of the lantana with the stink in her hair, put the back of her hand over her nose, and breathed through her mouth down the last of the slope.

The pit lay below the east wall like a dropped coin. It was a round hollow, twenty paces across and shoulder-deep, its sides cut into the red earth and shored with laterite blocks. Lamps burned in niches all round the rim. The air above it smelled of sesame oil and, under that, of hot clay. Steps were cut into the north side. She crouched at the lip behind the last of the bushes, where the lamplight did not reach, and looked down.

He was already working.

Barefoot, bare to the waist, his mundu hitched high, he moved across the floor of the pit with no sound except the snap of cloth and the hiss of breath. She had braced herself to see skill. She had seen skill. Vellan was skill, all of it packed into a body like a bear's. This was something else, and for a moment she could not name it.

It was arrival. The strike was over before she knew where it had been aimed. A turn, a drop, a palm that stopped a finger's width from nothing. His forearm cut across at the height of a throat. His heel came round at the height of a knee. Between one count and the next he was ten feet away with his weight low and his hands loose, as if he had stood there all along. Vellan hit harder. This man simply got there first.

All of it was aimed at a man who was not there.

She watched his hands and began, against her will, to read them. The temple. The hollow under the ear. The soft place beneath the ribs on the left. The notch under the skull that the old masters called the door. Each blow landed on a point, exactly, on an enemy only he could see. He had put every one of the points in the air and killed it, over and over, in a pit with nobody in it.

Eight years, she thought. Janu had said it in the first week, at the lip of this same pit. *He used to have a partner.* Eight years of rehearsing the

death of a stranger, and no one ever allowed to stand in the place where the stranger went.

She counted his turns. At the sixth she saw it.

He turned to the right, fast, with the right hand sweeping high. And the left hand came down, only half a hand's width, to rest at his hip. It was the most natural thing in the world. It would also open him from the cheek to the belt for the time it takes to say a name. In the whole pit there was nobody to see it but her.

She had not come to be useful. She had come to kill him. She went down the north steps anyway.

*

He stopped before her foot reached the third step.

Not startled. He simply stopped, in the middle of a turn, and the stillness was worse than a shout. For one count she felt how far she was from any wall.

"Neela."

"Warden."

He stood with his chest rising and falling slowly. Sweat ran down the old scars on his ribs. He did not reach for anything, because there was nothing to reach for. He studied her the way he studied a ford, patiently and from every side at once.

"It's early," he said.

"So are you."

"I'm always early."

"I couldn't sleep." That was true. It was a pleasure to say a true thing.

"The lantana's bad on that path." His eyes went to her face, and then to the damp on her sleeve. "Gopan keeps meaning to cut it."

"It's only a smell."

"Mm."

She came down the last steps and out onto the pit floor. The earth was warm from his feet and came off red on hers. She went to stand a

few paces from him, where a bride out for a walk might stand, and took care that her hands were empty and in plain sight.

"Show me a form," she said.

"Which?"

"One with two people in it."

"No."

He said it without heat. It was the same voice he used for *Not tonight, Janu*.

"I don't spar," he said.

"Janu says you did."

"Janu says a great deal."

"For how long have you not?"

"Eight years in the spring." He gave the figure as plainly as a tally of grain. Then, after a moment, as if he owed it to her: "Muthu asks me every seventh day. I say no every seventh day. He's a patient man."

"Is that a kindness to him, or to you?"

"I haven't decided."

She did not smile, though she felt the place where a smile would go. She looked at the swept ring of clay where he turned and said the next thing as lightly as she could.

"Then let me look at you. I won't touch you with anything but my eyes. Your stance is wrong."

For the first time something moved in his face. It was not offence. It was a kind of astonished interest, the look of a man who has been handed a bill and finds it correct.

"Who taught you to look?"

"A man who guarded pepper." It came out smooth. Kunjan Chirayil's warehouse had kept two guards, and one of them had once stood on a quay with a cudgel while she did not need him. "He thought a girl in a counting house should know when a man was about to lie to her, or hit her. He said they started in the same place."

"Where?"

"The feet."

He weighed her. She had given him a true thing again, wrapped in a false one, and she wondered whether he could tell which was which.

"Go on," he said.

*

"Take it from the turn."

He went back to the place where he had stopped. She walked a slow circle round him, at the distance of a long arm, and said *again* twice, and the third time he went through the whole movement at half speed with her at his shoulder.

"Right turn. Hands high." She watched them. "There. Your left hand drops. Not much."

"I know my hands."

"You know where you put them. Again."

He turned again. The left hand came down.

"You see?"

"I see you telling me that I have something I don't."

"Then I'm wrong, and you can laugh at me later." She moved in behind him. "Your head's wrong too. It rides forward when you turn. May I?"

The silence in the pit was exact. A lamp spat. Somewhere above them, behind the wall, a goat coughed.

"Yes," said Devan.

She laid her fingers on the back of his neck.

His skin was hot and damp, with a ridge of old muscle under it. She pressed the head back an inch, where it belonged, and he let her. His chin came down. His neck stood straight and bare in the lamplight, the short hair clipped close to the nape.

At the base of the skull, a thumb's width below the bone, her fingers rested on the door.

Her hand knew it before she did. It had made this exact shape on sandbags and sheep, in practice, and once not in practice. The heel at the right angle. The weight dropping through the wrist, not the arm. A

quarter-turn and a push, quick and clean. He would not cry out. He would fall as a man falls in a pit in the dark when no one is looking. By the time the day watch came on, there would be a widow in black with a seal in her lap and every honest man in the fort to say that the warden had always been careless in his own kalari.

She felt the pulse under her fingers. It was slow.

"One," she said, so low it was hardly a word.

The lamp flame leaned. A bar of grey had come into the sky above the east wall. She could do it by the next breath and be up the steps and in the chamber before the chain clanked. There was no bar to explain, no beast, no cage. This was the plan she had made, and it was a good one. She was free to be a woman who had finished her twelfth contract. Her page would burn and she would have a name.

"Two."

He had not turned his head. He had heard the number, and the next, and he knew what they were counting down. His hands hung at his sides, open, the palms half out. She knew that hand. It had lain on a blanket in the dark with seven pale scars across the knuckles, a finger's width from her nose, and it had not closed then either. His shoulders sat low and quiet under her palm, like a man's in a chair he trusts. She thought him a fool, or this a trap, and waited for the trap to close, and it did not. He only stood and breathed.

Then she thought of nothing at all. That was the strange part. The pit went quiet around her the way the langurs had gone quiet at the gorge, all at once, and her mind did not run the kill to its end. It stopped short of it, like a hand at a closed door.

"Three."

On the third breath he let the air out of his chest, slowly. He did not draw the next one at once.

He was waiting. He had heard every number, and he knew what her hand was resting on. She understood it with her whole body in the space of that held breath, and still she stood there with her fingers on his neck.

She lifted her hand.

"Your guard drops on the left," she said. Her voice came out level. "When you turn right the hand comes down half a palm. Somebody fast enough would use it."

Devan did not move at once. When he did, he turned slowly, as a man turns when he does not want to be mistaken for a threat. The lamplight lay on the plain, tired look of his face.

"You'd have had me," he said.

"Yes."

That was all. She had expected him to ask her something, and the question hung ready in the lamp-smoke between them. It never came. He regarded her as if she had given him a figure he had expected, and he was quietly checking it against his own count.

She did not explain. She had no explanation to give him that she could stand to hear herself say.

"The left," said Devan, at last. He said it to himself, in the voice of a man filing a rule.

Neela turned, and went up the north steps.

*

Her knees did not give out until the top.

She stood at the lip with one hand on the cold laterite and the other flat against her ribs, and the shaking came up from her heels in long waves. Her hands were wet. She looked at the right one, the one that had touched him, and could not make it close.

Below her, he had not gone back to his forms. He stood in the middle of the swept clay with his head bent and one hand lifted to the back of his own neck, exactly where hers had been. He held it there as if he were testing a bruise.

She went into the lantana with her breath held, and the smell found her anyway. At the bend she gagged again. Nothing came up.

*

The chamber was empty and the shutters were still barred.

She lifted the bar and set it against the wall. Grey light came in through the slats and laid ruled lines along the floor. She sat down on the edge of the bed and put her hands between her knees to hold them still.

Reasons, she thought. *Make a list.*

The east wall, first. The pair on the walk above the pit were never off it at dawn. If she had struck, a man might have looked down and seen a bride bending over her husband. That was the first reason, and she turned it over and found it sound.

It stayed sound for about as long as it took to remember that the east wall pair faced the hill. She had watched them from the lantana. Neither had once turned round.

The flask, then. She had come with no resin and no beast. If the strike went wrong she had nothing behind it. But the door did not go wrong, and she knew it better than she knew her own name, which was a poor joke, because she had never known her name.

The ache, then. One night off the flask already counted against her. A woman starting that count should not take chances. That was almost reasonable. She tried it twice and it would not stay put.

Something else would not stay put either, and she made herself pick it up. Four first lights in a row she had come in off the hill and found him abed. Last night she had stayed in, and he had gone down in the dark. On the nights she was out, he lay there until she was back. On the nights she was in, he went to his pit. She laid the two side by side and they fit like halves of a tally stick. It could be chance, or habit, or his bad sleep. But a man who rose by his own clock would not care where she was.

Was he waiting for her?

She had no answer, and the question was bigger than the one she had started with. She put it down unfinished and did the sum she had been walking around. Chathu's message had been plain. Once the writ landed, every day counted double. Thirty nights on the calendar were fifteen by his ledger. If the account stood open when the pass closed, he would put resin on her himself and read her page at dusk. And Chathu

balanced every loss in some other coin. Ammu, humming her fishing song, with a nick on her knuckle.

Neela let out a long breath and said it aloud to the empty room. "It was the wrong morning. Thirty nights is plenty. I wanted a better one."

It was a good lie. It cost fifteen nights and a girl at an inn. She told it again anyway, and it sounded more like a plan. She got up and poured water from the kindi into the basin and scrubbed her hands to the wrist, over and over, until the skin went pink. The lantana came off, and the smell of him with it, clay and sesame oil and clean sweat, and then there was only water.

Men who are about to be killed flinch. She had seen it a dozen times. They flinch and they twist and they turn their heads at the last, whatever they have promised themselves. He had stood quite still and breathed out.

That did not go on the shelf with the rest. She had no shelf for it.

Above the east wall, Gopan's chain began to clank the hour, and she stood with her wet hands over the basin and counted every stroke.

Chapter 12

Parrots

Devan put his hand to the back of his neck. The skin was still warm where hers had been.

She had had him.

He made himself say it plainly, the way he would write a report. She had come down the north steps with her hands empty. She had laid two fingers on the door of his skull, at the exact point, with her weight set behind the wrist. He had felt that weight gather. Three breaths. He had counted them, because counting was the only way not to turn round.

Then she had lifted her hand and told him his left was dropping.

It was. Alone in the pit with the lamps burning out, he had checked four times since, and she was right to the half-palm.

His body had decided to stand still, and his mind had come up behind it to find itself holding a very bad wager. He could not say if he had been testing her. He could not say if he had wanted to be caught out.

For ten days he had watched her as a thing the guild had left in his bed. A blade with a woman's hands. A blade does not pull a strike. A blade has no mind to change at the last. He had looked at the woman on the ledge at dusk and thought only of the cat, and of the one word in his mouth that would close her in it for good.

But a thing that stops has a will. A will can be asked questions. A will can be bargained with.

He had one thing she needed, and it sat behind his teeth. She had one thing he needed, and it sat in her head: who had paid. He weighed the trade as he would a blade he did not like to carry. A man who held a word over a woman and called it a bargain was doing what the guild did. He knew that.

He weighed it anyway.

*

Janu was waiting in the kitchen passage, which she never did. She had a key on a cord in her fist, and she held it out the way she held out a cup to a child she suspected of fever.

"Asha's room," she said.

He did not take it at once. "Why now?"

"Because there is a wife in this house, and a house with a wife shouldn't keep a shut room like a grudge." Her mouth worked. "And because I can't be the one. I tried. Twice. I got to the door."

He took the key. The cord was warm from her hand.

"Open the shutters first," said Janu. "It's been dark in there since the rains she died. She never liked a dark room."

She walked back to her pots without looking at him, and the pots took a beating.

*

The room was at the end of the south passage, the last door before the wall. It smelled of dust and camphor and mice.

Devan opened the shutters. Light fell across a cot, a stool and a peg with a leather cap still hanging from it. He did not look at the cap. At the foot of the cot stood her chest, its brass hasp gone green.

He sat on the floor in front of it. It seemed the only honest way to do it.

On top lay a slate. He knew it before he picked it up. In her first month as an officer of the fort she had written the name of every recruit on it, with his mother's village beside, because she said a man fights

harder for a captain who knows where his mother lives. The chalk had faded to ghosts. She had given even the cook's boy who ran water to the recruits a line. *Unni, salt fish, lower village.* He read the ghost twice. The same boy, grown thin and tall, now held his gate.

Under the slate were notes. Forty or fifty, folded small, tied up with red thread. He slipped the thread and opened the top one, and there at the bottom was the bird.

She had signed every note with it. Five strokes: a round head, a hooked beak, one lazy tail. As a girl she had drawn it on the walls of the cistern house until Janu scrubbed them. The beak was always whole.

His thumb stopped on the beak.

He read three of them. Reminders. A joke about Bhaskaran's boots. A list of what the garrison owed the baker. Then, in the bottom corner of the chest, wrapped in a square of oilcloth tied with the same red thread, he found the other thing.

A tally stick, split ash, notched for a cart. At its end sat a thumb of old wax.

He did not touch the wax at first. He held the stick by the oilcloth and studied it in the light from the shutters. Dull brick red. A pepper sprig pressed in it. He lifted it to his nose, and under the dust there was still clove.

Council wax. And folded into the oilcloth, a scrap in her quick hand:

First one. Not yet. Need a second to be sure. Tell nobody at the gate. — and the bird.

He had never known she had it. He had thought the first token lost, taken by whoever had taken everything else.

From the pouch at his belt he drew the square of beeswax he carried everywhere now, the impression he had lifted from the dead raider's tally. He laid it beside hers in the light. Under the stem of the sprig, a dot with a small split beneath it. Then the other, the same dot, the same split.

One of three seals in the council's keeping, then and now. Whoever held it had been selling the pass while she was alive, and was selling it still.

He sat very still. Far off, the cistern chain began to clank the hour below, as if in another house.

*

"May I come in?"

She stood in the doorway with her hand flat on the frame, as she had stood at the lip of the pit. She was grey about the mouth. The hollow-eyed look had not left her since dawn.

"Janu said you'd be here," said Neela. "She said not to bring anything, and then she sent a plate. I left it in the passage." A pause. "I'll go if you say."

Devan folded the oilcloth over the tally and put the whole in his sleeve. It was not a lie. She had not asked.

"Come in."

She crossed the room and did not sit on the stool. She lowered herself to the floor opposite him, the chest between them, and looked at the cap on the peg and the faded slate.

"Is this Asha's?"

"Asha's. My sister." He said it as flatly as a ration count. "Four years younger. My second, after."

"Janu said you'd lost someone."

"Janu says a great deal."

"So I've heard." The corner of her mouth moved and went still again. "Tell me about her. Or don't."

He had not said her name aloud in that room since the rains she died. He found it did not break anything.

"She was fearless with soldiers," he said. "Forty men on a muddy field, and she'd give the order like a woman asking for salt, and they'd walk into a ford for her. She learned every recruit's mother's village in a month." He touched the slate. "She was afraid of the dark. Not of any-

thing in it. Of the dark. She'd stand a night watch on the wall with a hundred spears behind her, then come in and ask Janu to leave a lamp."

"Everyone's afraid of something."

"Yes."

Neela's hand went out to the slate and stopped above it. Then one finger came down on the ghost of Unni's name.

"I do this too," she said, to the chalk. "Raiu has a cowlick. Kannan's goat bites. Chinna's hip is worse when it rains." Her thumb moved along the line, and it was not steady. "I don't like anyone on my wall to be a number. I was one, once. For a while."

She did not look up. Her thumb stayed where it was, as if the chalk might hold her.

He had watched her do it for ten days. The pause at the kitchen door until Chinna looked round. Raiu's name before his rank. Kannan's goat. He had taken it for a bride's manners, or a spy's craft. It was neither. It had cost her something to say, and she had said it to a slate rather than to him, which was the only way she could.

"She'd have liked that," he said. "She'd have said you were cheating, and then she'd have copied you."

Neela made a small sound that was nearly a laugh. Her thumb lifted.

"What happened to her?"

"She was killed. Six years ago. Under contract."

He watched the words reach her. She did not move. He knew that stillness, because he had seen it in the pit this morning, the stillness of someone adding up a figure she did not want. He took it for what it looked like. A woman who had been sold into a house and had just learned that a wall in it had once been breached.

"Someone paid for it," she said, slowly.

"Someone did."

"How?"

"I won't answer that."

In his head, where it stayed, were the west stair at first light, and Janu's face when she came up from it. The long parallel wounds, deep and spaced wide. A bear's. Inside walls no bear had ever climbed.

Neela looked at him, and then she did what he had not expected. She left it alone. She did not press and she did not offer comfort she did not mean. She sat with her hands between her knees and let the question lie where he had put it, and the room did not feel emptier for it.

"May I?" She nodded at the notes.

"She wrote them to be read aloud."

She unfolded the nearest and tilted it to the light. Her eyes went down it. Then the thumb of her right hand came to rest on the signature, and stayed.

"She gives it a beak," she said.

"She always did. The one on the west stair has lost its own." He heard his voice go careful. "She said it was an insult to a bird, and drew it mended."

Neela's face emptied. The colour went out of it so fast that he half rose.

"You haven't eaten," he said.

"No. It's nothing. It's the morning." She waved the hand with the paper in it. "It's all right. Let me read."

She read. He sat back down.

Her lips moved on the last line, and then she laughed. It was a short, startled sound, surprised out of her, nothing like the dry noises she made at table. She put her fist against her mouth and said through it, "Oh, she's *good*."

"Which?"

"'Muthu says you're the best fighter in the pass. I told him you're the best at looking like one. I'll take your two best points on the seventh day, brother, and you may have my two worst.'"

Nobody had laughed in that room since she died. Devan put his own hand over his mouth, and under it his face did something he could not

have stopped if he had tried. He let it. She had her head down over the paper and did not look.

"Did she win?" asked Neela.

"That seventh day? She took both points."

"Of course she did."

She folded the note on its old creases and set it back with the others, squared, the way a person puts away something that is not theirs. Then she asked, still looking at the thread.

"What would she want now?"

He could have said something pretty. He had a dozen.

"She'd want whoever sold the tokens found," he said. "Not hanged in a hurry. Found, and asked why. And she'd say I was doing it the slow way, alone, in the dark, because I'd decided no one else could carry it." He looked at the faded slate. "She'd be right. She was usually right. It was hard to live beside."

"Hard to live beside," Neela agreed, gravely, and he laughed again, once, through his nose.

They sat there. After some time he noticed that he had moved. He was no longer across the chest from her. His knee was nearly touching hers on the boards, and the chest stood at his shoulder, and he could not remember crossing the floor.

He did not move back. He was less alone in the room than he had been when he opened it.

*

At dusk he went down to the padippura to count the watch.

The light had gone orange and low. In the gate yard a rider sat his horse with the palace green on his sleeve, Sudhi, who brought the royal post up every ninth day and took the fort's down. Muthu stood at his stirrup with a letter in his hand.

It was a plain fold, sealed in grey wax with no mark on it.

Muthu saw him coming across the cobbles. For half a breath he said nothing at all. Then the great laugh came out of him, the one that carried to the wall.

"My mother!" He held up the letter. "Don't look at me like that, Warden, it's the usual quarrel. She writes me once a month, I answer once a month, and every time she says her son will die of the pass, unfed and unmarried and unlettered. I'm the first captain in Varanad to be scolded by post."

"Unmarried?" said Devan.

"She hasn't heard about *yours*. I'll let her find out from the neighbours. Better a rumour than a letter." Muthu clapped the rider's leg. "Take it, Sudhi, she'll want it before the rains."

The rider tucked it into his satchel with the palace's own post and clicked his tongue to the horse.

Devan stood a moment. A plain seal, no mark, at the gate. *Tell nobody at the gate*, Asha had written, and her note lay in his sleeve against the sight in front of him. He made himself set the two side by side.

Muthu lied quiet. Devan had known it since they were boys in the pit. When the man had something to hide he went still as a stone in a stream, and this had been the loudest laugh on the wall. The half-breath beforehand was a man embarrassed over his mother's scolding, nothing more.

And the wax was grey. The wax on Asha's tally was brick red. Grey was not council wax, and this letter was going to an old woman in Kodiyur.

"Tell her I'm sorry about the pass," said Devan.

"I'll tell her you're a hard man to feed." Muthu grinned. "Go and eat something."

He believed him. He went up.

*

The chamber was empty. Neela was at supper in the hall, with Janu piling a plate in front of her; he could hear Janu's voice through the floor.

The shutters stood open on a last green strip of sky. He took the oilcloth from his sleeve and unfolded it. The tally lay in his palm. Beside it lay the last note from the chest, the one he had kept back and not shown her. He had found it folded under the camphor block at the very bottom, and it was not about boots.

If you're reading this, I was right, and it's ugly. Say it anyway. The truth protects whoever finds it. The bird, with its whole beak.

He read the line three times in the going light. It had not protected her. She had found it alone, in a fort that was too small for her, and told nobody at the gate, and it had come up the west stair after her in the dark.

He knew the shape of the offer now. On one side, his silence. On the other, the name of whoever had bought his death. Nothing more, and no lie in it.

The light went. Below, Janu's girls were lighting the evening lamps.

He folded the note into the oilcloth beside the tally and knelt to set both in the carved box under the bed. The boards were cold under his palm. He thought of the floor in Asha's room, and the place beside his own knee where hers had been, a hand's width away, unasked. Once he named the bargain, she would not sit like that again. She would sit across a table from a man who held a word over her, and she would be right to.

He laid the lid down. Then he lifted the bar, set it across the brackets, and let it go. The wood knocked once, softly.

He would offer her the bargain. Once, and plainly, and knowing what it was.

Chapter 13

The Cat on the Sill

The arrow only kissed him. That was why he rode home on it.

It came from the ridge above the second ford, a hundred paces off, and laid a line along the outside of his left forearm, shallow as a thorn scratch. Muthu's men ran down the two who bolted. Devan knotted a rag over the cut, gave the order to turn for the fort, and thought no more about it.

By the time the padippura came up out of the dust, the arm was a hot post. By the time he climbed down in the gate yard, Unni's face had gone strange and wide, and the cobbles had begun to lean.

"Warden?"

"It's nothing," said Devan, and sat down on the mounting block, because the ground was making another suggestion.

*

By evening he had been bled twice.

Eravi, the fort's physician, was a stooped man with a voice like a dry gourd. He had opened the vein in Devan's right arm with great ceremony and filled a brass bowl. Now he stood over the bed with his hands folded, wearing the face of a man who has done everything and would like it noted. Red lines ran up the inside of the left arm toward the shoulder, thin as threads. The wound itself had gone the colour of a plum. Raiders smeared their arrowheads with dung for exactly this.

"It is in the blood now," Eravi said to Janu. "We draw what we can. Tomorrow's sunrise will tell."

"Tomorrow's sunrise," said Janu, "tells every fool in the country something. What does it tell *me*?"

Devan heard them as if through a wall of water. The ceiling swam. He knew the room, the bed, the kindi, the third shutter slat that never stopped creaking. He knew that dusk was coming, because his bones knew it. He tried to say so and got only a dry click.

Then the door opened, and the room changed its mind about the air.

Neela did not run. She walked in fast, with her sleeves already pushed to the elbow and her hair tied back with a strip of kasavu. She looked at the arm the way she had looked at his neck in the pit, as something with a place in it that mattered. It was not the same look.

"How much have you taken?" she asked.

"Two bowls, madam, a proper measure for—"

"He's had enough." She laid two fingers on the inside of his wrist. His pulse jumped under them, hard and sudden, and her eyes flicked to his face and away again. She counted under her breath. "He's thin in the pulse. You're draining the one thing he's fighting with."

"The poison sits in the blood, and bleeding—"

"Draws him down with it." She said it without heat. "Janu. I need a pot of water boiling hard, a clean cloth boiled with it, and toddy spirit, the sharp kind from the store. Turmeric and honey. A knife, the small one from the kitchen. Boil that too."

Janu looked at her. Devan saw it happen, through the swimming ceiling: the old woman's face, which had been braced for grief, found something to do instead.

"Chinna has the sharp toddy," Janu said. "I'll bring it myself."

"Tell Chinna it's for the warden. She'll hurry." Neela glanced at the door. "And have Raiu send up Kannan with whatever neem he can strip. Tell them thank you."

She said it as though it cost nothing and they would remember it. Devan thought he had known that about her already.

"Madam," Eravi began.

"Do what she says," said Devan.

It came out in a thick voice he hardly recognised. Every face in the room turned to him. He had not meant to give an order. He had meant to be quiet.

Neela's eyes met his, level in the failing light, and for a moment she looked as if she would say something. Then she looked away and took up the lamp.

*

He lost some time.

He came back to the sound of her counting. She sat on the edge of the bed with his left arm across her knee, pressing the hollow behind his elbow with her thumb, then a place below the knee, then the inside of the other wrist. Marma. Healing points, the ones that pull heat down out of the body. He knew them. He had only ever used the other kind.

"Forty-one," she was saying, very low. "Forty-two. Forty-three."

Beneath the counting there was pain, and then there was the knife. He felt that only as a distant, orderly pressure, like a man being swept. The water was hot. The spirit was fire. She cut the dead edge from the wound and he heard a small sound go out of him that he would have preferred not to hear.

"I know," she said. "Forty-eight. It's nearly done. Forty-nine."

She was not speaking to him. She was speaking to the number. But he held on to it, and after a while the number became a rope.

Somewhere in that, the light behind his eyes went orange. Dusk.

His body had known it first. Then it came to the front of his mind with a horror so complete that for a moment he was clear.

The shutters were open.

Janu had opened them herself while he was gone. *Your father's rule*, she'd said. *A sick room breathes.* A last slab of copper sky lay across the floor, and the wide stone ledge outside the window stood out against it, empty and waiting.

He tried to say *bar them*. What came out was "No," and then, with great effort, "Janu."

"Hush," said Janu, from somewhere. "Hush, my heart. Lie still."

"Janu," said Neela. Her voice was easy and exact. "He'll take broth if it's thin. Would you? Not the first pot, the second. And ask Chinna for another jug of the boiled water, cooled. It will take a while."

Janu went. She went grumbling, which meant she was relieved to be given a job. The door closed.

Neela stood up.

For ten nights he had watched her do this through his lashes, with his face a sleeper's and his breath kept slow, and he had done it well. Tonight the fever had taken his lids away from him. They hung half open and would not be told. She had her back to him. She took something from a fold of cloth, a small corked flask, and drew the cork with her teeth.

Then she turned and looked at his face. He could not even close his eyes. She studied him for the length of one slow breath, the way she might look at a lamp to see whether it would burn till morning. If she read anything in the slit of his eyes, she did not show it. They were glazed, and the room was dim, and what she saw seemed to satisfy her. She turned away.

The resin went on at the throat and the inner wrists, the old pale ridges taking it. He smelled it across the room, burnt tamarind and pine sap. She climbed onto the ledge with her hands braced on the stone, and her shoulders drew together.

He had seen it ten times before tonight. It did not get easier. It got worse, the more of her he knew.

The bones moved. The spine bowed and lengthened. The sound was soft, a wet creak like a green branch bent, and then gold came up under the skin like a lamp turning, and she was gone, and the cat was there.

It stood in the last of the light. Its flanks were still pulling for air. It looked back at him over its shoulder, steady and level, and in the green-gold eyes was something so clearly her that he nearly said her name.

Instead he said nothing. There was only one word he could say, and it was the wrong one. It was right there in his mouth, whole, smooth as a stone in a sling.

On the sill the cat settled and curled its tail around its feet. It faced the room, not the hills.

Then the door opened.

"There, I've the second pot and Chinna says if—where's the girl gone?" Janu stopped. Her voice went high and thin. "Something's on the sill. There are eyes. Devan, there's an *animal*—"

The bowl fell. Broth ran across the boards.

"A great—" said Janu. "Mercy, it's the, it's the—"

The word came up in him like a swallowed coal.

It would have been so easy. He had the whole shape of it ready. His mouth began it without asking him: the tongue lifting to the roof, the first hard sound, *L*—

He bit down.

With everything he had, he bit on his own tongue, and the pain went through him white, and the taste of copper filled his mouth. The sound broke off against his teeth. The room sharpened. For a moment he could see Janu's hand on the doorframe and the dark shape on the ledge, and he knew exactly what he was holding.

"It's the cat," he said. It came out thick and wet and slurred through blood. "Leave the cat. Draw the curtain."

"That is no cat, Devan—"

"The *cat*, Janu." He had no strength for more. He put all of it into her name. "Draw the curtain."

She crossed the floor on stiff legs. She never took her eyes off the ledge, but her gaze stuck on the two points of light and slid off again, as people's gaze does. She dragged the cotton curtain across the window with a rattle of rings. The cat was gone behind it, and the shape of it, and the shine.

Janu stood there with her hand on the cloth, breathing hard.

"Eyes," she said, to no one. "Only eyes, in the dark. I'm an old fool. I've told those stories too long." She turned. "And where's that girl? She never said she was leaving."

"Sent her to sleep," said Devan. He made it flat and quick, the way a true thing sounds. His tongue was swelling. "Sit, Janu."

She sat. After a while she took his right hand, the bled one, and held it in both of hers.

He lay with blood pooling under his tongue, and he did not swallow it.

*

The other one lay behind the curtain with her chin on her paws and listened.

The cloth had cut off the last of the sky. It did not cut off much else. The other one's ears took in every word in the room, and her nose took in the rest. Hot cloth, spirit, turmeric. Janu's old fear-sweat, sour and brave. And through all of it, blood.

Not from the arm. This was fresher, sharper, and it came from his mouth.

He was raving. She could hear the pulse in his throat tripping, and the words came thick and wrong. *The cat. Leave the cat. Draw it.* Then a stretch of nothing but breath, then *cat* again, and a slurred, sticky sound that began a word and gave it up. He'd bitten his tongue in the fever, she supposed. Men did. She had seen a man in the Resin House sheds, shaking with ague, chew his lip to ribbons.

He had told Janu she was asleep, too, in a voice so level it nearly fooled her. A fevered man's kindness, she thought. He did not like Janu to worry.

The cat. Janu's stories had put it in him, she thought. Or the notched ginger tom that walked the parapet in the mornings, whom the warden had been feeding off the table since the second week and had never mentioned. It was a small joke the house kept. He was raving about the tom.

She thought nothing more of it. She didn't have room.

The stone had been the plan: she was to be there by the middle watch. There was a flat of cut laterite in the pala grove on the second spur, and a cup in its top, and Ammu would be crouched at it by now with her ears flat, waiting for a mark. A report. *The warden is guarded; the opening is narrower than I said.* Twenty-nine nights. The hollow dawn hunger would come for her at the end of this one, as it had after every turning, and she had perhaps that many mornings left to finish. And Chathu's message, five days old, had said what would be done if the account stood open at the pass's closing.

She had come up on the ledge to go. She had stood there with the night full of hill scent and the stone a mile off. She had looked back into the room.

Under the pulse she had counted all evening, his breath had gone wrong. That was all. The wide, quick, shallow pull of it, the lines of red going up the arm. She had known that breath. She had heard it on a girl in the sheds, two nights before they carried her out.

A man dead of a raider's arrow needed no cat. No one would ask her anything. The guild would call it the world's work, and the account would close by itself, and she would be a widow with a seal in her lap and a name coming. She had weighed that on the ledge, quite coldly, with her tail twitching. She had weighed it and laid it down. Then she had sat.

It was the third time in two days she had not done the sensible thing. The other one had no shame about it. The other one only knew who was breathing in the room.

Janu slept at the second watch, upright on the stool with her hand still locked on his. Neela could hear the cistern chain clank the hours, and the dogs, and the creak of the third slat when the wind changed. Beside the bed, the kindi slowly warmed. Twice in the dark he said *cat* and once he said a name that was not hers, and it was *Asha*, and the other one lay with her eyes closed.

Toward dawn the sweat came.

She smelled it before she saw it: the sour break, the heat going out of him all at once. His breath slowed and deepened. The hitch came back into it, a third of the way through each long count, as small and steady as a thing she had memorised without knowing.

In the last dark, when the lanterns burned low, a jackal called from the second spur.

It was thin and far across the terraces. Three short yips. A pause. One long note, climbing.

The other one's ears turned toward it before she had decided anything. She and Ammu had made that call in the yard behind the sheds when they were eleven and nine. *Tomorrow, I will find you.* It had never once been used by someone who was not coming.

She did not answer. She could not have, with that throat. The call came again, longer, and went up and up, and then the hills took it.

*

The grey came, and the change took her.

It pulled at the throat first. The bones shrank and slid, and she was on her hands and knees on cold stone, shaking, naked, with a hollow inside her where all the hunger of the night had gone to sit. The ledge scraped her palms. She got her cloth from the corner where she had left it folded and dragged it over her head.

Behind the curtain, the room smelled of nothing but a man asleep.

Janu had gone, leaving the stool crooked and a bowl of gruel cooling beside it. The lamp was out. In the grey light the warden lay on his back with the bandaged arm across his chest and his mouth a little open. A dark crust had dried at the corner of it.

Neela put the back of her hand to his forehead. Cool. Damp, and cool.

Her knees were swaying under her.

Go, she told herself. *Wash. Find Ammu. You missed the stone. Explain it.* Tomorrow, in the guild's tongue, meant whatever came after the dark you stood in. That meant this day. Ammu had waited all night with an

empty cup and then come to the ridge to look. By the gate-bell she would be in Valli's market shawl, asking Bhaskaran for the warden's lady, and Neela would have to say what she had been doing instead.

She had a hundred sensible things to do, and the hollow place in her was louder than any of them. Her legs did not move. They folded, quite gently, and set her down on the boards beside the bed with her back against the frame and her knees drawn up.

The cistern chain clanked once. The first light came gold through the curtain's weave.

Above her shoulder, his right hand hung over the edge of the mattress, open, a finger's width from her hair. She felt it there as she'd feel a fire.

She did not touch the hand. She did not stand.

Chapter 14

Varanad Coin

Neela heard the route before she understood it was an argument.

She was in the kitchen passage with a basin of boiled cloth. The warden's voice came through the hall door, level and a little too slow, like a man climbing stairs one at a time.

"Out the east postern before the first clank. Down to the second ford. Up through the lower narrows to the shelf, and home by the cart road before the day watch."

"No," said Muthu.

Muthu never said no. He said *Warden* and *come now* and *by my mother's pots*. The flat word sounded like a stranger's. Neela set the basin on the step and stood where the doorway shadow was deepest.

Devan sat at the long table with his left arm strapped across his chest. The brown of his face had gone grey underneath. Janu stood behind his chair with a cup of broth she kept lifting and lowering, as if the cup might argue for her.

"Eravi gave you a week in bed," said Muthu. His big face had no laugh in it. "Yesterday you sat down on a mounting block because the yard tilted."

"I sat because it was there."

"You were *put* down. By a poison. In front of the whole gate."

"The narrows are where Raman died." Devan said it without weight, the way he said every fact. "Spring, on my patrol, in single file under that

shelf. His boy is nine. I'll not send eleven men through that cut and sit in a bed counting them."

"Then I lead it."

"You lead the second file."

"And if the arm opens on the shelf?"

"Then you'll have the pleasure of telling me so."

Neela did what she had learned to do in other people's houses. She listened to the road inside the sentence. East postern, first clank. The ford. The narrows. She had seen the cut from the east terraces, a notch in the far hills, and she knew the kind of going it held: a ledge of laterite along a cliff foot, one horse wide, the only dry way through. A rider on it could be reached from above by anyone with a bow and patience.

She caught herself measuring it. Her mind went quiet and cold and said, with no heat at all: *Twenty-eight nights. And a road that is nearly a gift.*

Valli had not come to the gate by the bell, either. Neela had watched it all morning with the patience she gave a lock. No grey shawl, no pepper trader's girl. She did not know what that meant, and she disliked not knowing more than she disliked the road.

"Madam."

Devan was looking at her. Muthu's ears went red.

"The whole passage heard you," said Neela. "I'm told the cistern chain did too."

"Then you'll have an opinion."

"Would it change the route?"

"No."

"Then I'll keep it for something that might." She crossed to him and looked at the strapping, not his face. The knot was Janu's, the dressing hers. It had held. "I'll see that arm tonight."

"I'll be in bed."

"Then I'll look at it in bed."

His mouth went still, the way it did when he was pleased and hiding it. Muthu barked a laugh in spite of himself. "She's said no to you in four lines, Warden. I've been at it eight years."

*

By dusk he was in bed, flat on his back, his right hand on his chest and his eyes shut. Janu had banged the room into order and gone. The shutters were closed.

Neela lit no lamp. She unwound the dressing by feel and tilted the arm to the grey light at the slats. The red lines had faded to pink threads. The wound was clean at its edge. She wrapped it again, slowly, and he did not stir.

His breath hitched, a third of the way through the count, the way it always did. She found she had been waiting for it. *Chance*, she told herself, and put the thought away with the others.

She lifted the bar herself. She drew the curtain, took the flask from her cloth, and pulled the cork with her teeth. Resin at the throat and wrists. The burn, the old ridges taking it. She went up onto the ledge, and the dusk took her bones.

The other one came down the east terraces in the last of the light, low under the pepper vines, past the goat shed and the white goat who bit, and out over the wall by the lantana. She did not go to the stone. She went to the narrows.

She did not know why, and she did not ask. The other one only knew the hills were wide and the road in them was narrow, and a man would ride it at dawn.

The wind came up the cut, and with it the news. Cold fat. Bow-wax. Old ghee going rancid in a skin. Bronze, which smelled of nothing and so of something. Two men. No smoke.

She went up the back of the cliff by a chimney of broken laterite, belly low, and lay in the rocks twenty paces above the shelf.

The men had made a cold camp in a notch of the lip. Two bundled shapes in wool, backs to the stone. One sat awake with a bow unstrung

across his knees. The other slept with his hand on a round thing wrapped in cloth. A mirror. The other one knew the shape, because Neela had been taught what a mirror was for. At first grey they would string the bows. When a column came along the shelf in single file, one of them would flash the count to whoever waited beyond the cut.

Neither had eaten. A man who plans to move at dawn does not spread his stores.

She lay there while the stars came out, and Neela made herself do the sum.

A warden with one good arm, riding at a walk on a ledge one horse wide, under two men who could not miss. Last night she had only needed to sit still while a fever did it. Tonight she needed only to lie still and let two strangers' arrows do it, with not a claw of hers on the work. The guild would call it the world's work and close the account. She would be a widow with a seal in her lap. No cage, no ache, no page read aloud at dusk.

It was the cleanest road she had been offered in twelve contracts.

Then the other side of the sum. The stone had stood empty last night. If she went to the narrows, it would stand empty again at the hour Ammu looked, a second cup with no mark in it, and Ammu would count that as she counted everything. Valli had not come to the gate. Whatever that meant, Neela would not be there to learn it. And Chathu's word hung over both: *after the writ lands, every day counts double.* Two days she could not spare, spent on a man she was paid to kill.

She counted it all, to the last coin. Every column said lie still.

The cistern chain came up faint from the fort, once, twice, and the stars wheeled. She did not move. Behind the sum came the names. They arrived without being asked, as they always did. Raiu and his cowlick. Unni, whose mother sold salt fish. Bhaskaran at the gate with his stubborn jaw. Eleven riders behind a man who would not send them where he would not go. Raman's nine-year-old, whom she had never met.

She had known every one of them by name for nearly two weeks. That was the trouble with her. The guild had given her a number, and she had spent her life refusing it.

The chain clanked again. Four hours to first light, then three.

It is the contract, she told herself. *He is mine. I will not have a stranger's arrow take what I was paid for.*

It was a lie, and it was a good one. She used it.

The watcher turned his head toward a loose stone that had not moved. The other one went over the lip.

It was short, and it was not clean. The man with the bow had time to open his mouth. The sleeper woke under her weight and got a hand up, and the blow took it away. A knife came out and scored her shoulder, hot and thin. Then there was no more knife. The wool heaped in the notch went still, and the wind took the smell of it down toward the ford.

A leather purse had burst under her forepaw. Coin ran across the rock, bright in the starlight, and the other one, mid-snarl, breathed it in.

New silver. Not the dull, thumbed smell of a coin that has been in a hundred pockets. This was sharp and clean, like a blade fresh from the stone, with oil still in the milling. She turned one over with a claw. A pepper sprig on one face. Varanad's sprig. The edge was cut so fine it nicked her pad.

Nobody had spent these. Nobody had even handled them.

She nosed the dead man's satchel open. More silver, wrapped in a rag. A scrap of paper. And a split-ash tally stick with a thumb of wax on its end, and from the wax, faint and unmistakable, clove.

She knew that smell. Janu's kitchen. The broken tally on the hall table, the day the patrol came in. Real council wax, poured to keep it from cracking in damp.

Why would a raider carry that? Neela asked, and the other one, who had no use for questions, took the strap in her teeth.

Neela did the thinking while the animal dragged. The warden had broken one tally open in the hall. One tally was a story; two were a case.

Here was a second, and he could have it. That was one reason, and she let herself have it.

The other was colder. Left up here, the satchel would be found with two men mauled in a camp, and the fort would hear a cat-kill on its own hill and start asking what cat. A bag on the path made them raiders, and made the coin the story.

And it had a price. A bag lying where no bag should be told the warden someone had stood on this ledge before him. He was not a fool. He would ask who. She weighed that against a patrol riding past a dead camp and never learning what the scouts carried, and chose.

The path was a long way down. She dragged the satchel over the lip and down the scree, a hundred paces of slithering stone, and dropped it on the shelf at the exact place where the first horse would set its foot. Then she climbed back to the camp, and the bodies, and the bronze mirror still wrapped in its cloth. She left the mirror where it lay.

She meant to leave the men. The other one stood over them with her sides heaving.

Yes, said the hunger. It had no other word. It was the animal's, and so it was hers, and it came up through her like a tide.

No, said Neela.

It was the hardest thing she did that night. She turned her back on a meal still warm, put the wind in her face and walked away stiff-legged, with her jaws shut so hard her teeth ached. Every step was a thing she had to choose again. She had killed to keep a man alive. She would not also be the thing that ate them.

She went by the long way to the cleft in the rocks under the second spur, and on the way she passed the meeting stone. She stopped there, late, with blood drying on her shoulder, and dragged her cheek across the cup in its top. A scent-mark, no more. It would be a night old by the time Ammu read it, but it would be there.

The cleft held a bundle she had hidden that morning, because she had woken on the floor beside his bed and never meant to wake there again. A day cloth, a shawl, a water gourd. The guild taught it: *keep your*

dawn where you can reach it. She lay down in the cleft with her nose in her paws, and shook, and let the night go by with its hunger unfed.

*

The cut on her shoulder pulled first, a hot thread through the cold. Then the change took her.

She came back to her hands and knees on frozen rock, naked, with the sky going the colour of dishwater above her. Her teeth rattled. The knife cut had opened in the turning and bled a bright thin line down her arm. She dragged the cloth on over her head and wrapped the shawl twice round and could not feel her fingers on the knots.

There was nothing to eat, so she walked home.

Her feet bled quietly on the laterite between the pepper vines. A goat bit her hem. By the time the cistern chain clanked for the first time that she could count, she was on the east terrace, wrapped to the chin, with her back against the wall and the whole valley in front of her.

The narrows showed from here, a notch in the far hills like the bite in a flatbread. At the third clank, the line of riders went small and dark into it.

Then they stopped.

It was a long way off, and a small thing. A bunching, a spreading, one rider climbing off his horse. No flash came from the lip. Neela watched for it and it did not come, and the thought turned over in her belly. Whoever waited beyond the cut had been promised a signal. They would be wondering now why the mirror was dark. A man who wonders sends someone to look.

Birds were already turning above the lip of the cliff, slow circles, and then more of them. And on the far ridge beyond the cut, a dot moved. One man, coming over the skyline and down toward the dark camp while the column still stood bunched on the shelf. The scrub took him. She watched the place where he had gone and he did not come out.

She could do nothing. By day she was a woman on a wall with bleeding feet, and the ridge was a morning's climb away. Her hands shook so hard she sat on them.

The riders came home at midmorning by the cart road. She watched from the terrace above the gate yard as they rode through the padippura in a column that held its shape too carefully. No horn. No man down. Muthu rode in front with a leather satchel across his knees. Behind him Devan sat his horse with his bad arm strapped and his face the colour of ash. In his right hand he held something small and bright, turning it over with his thumb.

He did not look at the terrace. He lifted his head and looked at the hills. He looked at them for a long time, at the notch in the east where the kites were still turning, and then along the ridge toward the second spur, and then at nothing.

Neela stayed very still against her wall. A thin cut on her shoulder, a night of fasting in her belly, one clean road thrown in a ravine: she did not feel brave. She felt like a woman who had put her own foot through a floor.

*

At supper she ate like a field hand.

Janu watched her go through the third plate and beamed. "There. Good. A wife should eat." She did not ask where Neela had been all day, and Neela did not tell her. The hall was loud with it anyway. The whole fort knew by noon.

"Two of them, mauled to the bone," said Muthu, tearing bread. "Bows, a signal mirror, a cold camp on the lip above the shelf. They were waiting for us, madam, I'd swear to it. And something got them first. A leopard, the men say, and I'll tell you, I've never seen a mark like—"

"A cat," said Devan.

He said it mildly, without looking up. Neela's hand stopped on the bread.

"A big one," said Muthu. "Fine. A *cat*."

"Left them, did it?" Janu said, and made a small sign against her chest. "Left the meat? Cats don't."

"This one did." Devan set a single coin on the table beside his plate. "Look at the edge."

Muthu picked it up, grumbling. Janu leaned. Neela did not need to lean. She knew what it looked like.

"Sharp," said Muthu. "So it's new. Loot, from some trader. Is that what you think?"

"I won't answer that."

Muthu opened his mouth and shut it. Devan took the coin back and turned it once under the lamp, and said nothing more. He had ridden home with a satchel and a second tally and a long silence, and he gave the hall an edge and a sharp coin and no more. A man laying out a trap does not describe it to the room. Neela's eyes went, without her leave, around the whole hall: Chinna at the kitchen door with her bad hip, the servers with their pots, the open door to the yard where anyone might stand and listen.

"So who killed the scouts, then?" said Muthu. "And why leave the bag where we'd walk on it?"

"I don't know."

"Well, if it's a friend, I'd like to meet him."

"I'd like to thank him," said Devan.

He reached for the dish of fried fish and, without a glance, pushed it toward Neela's side of the table. "The pepper-store cat has been busy," he said.

Janu snorted. "That ginger rogue? He hasn't caught anything since the fever year."

"He's been busy." Devan's eyes came up, level and brown, and rested on Neela for the space of one breath. "Someone should leave him a bowl of milk. He's earned it."

It was said lightly. His face was grave. The corner of his mouth might have moved, or might not.

Neela looked at him over the rim of her cup and turned the sentence like a coin to find its edge. A joke at the table, over Janu's fish. A cat, the whole fort's cat, the one who walked the parapet and was fed from his plate. Or something else, so lightly handed across that no one but her could have picked it up.

For twelve days she had read his face, and she knew most of its weather. This she could not read.

"I'll see he gets it," she said.

"Do," said Devan, and went back to his rice.

Chapter 15

First Storm

The rain took the trail in the time it took to blink.

One breath, the other one had it: pony sweat, lamp oil, wet wool, two men and a pack animal threading the ridge track north of the narrows, a hundred paces ahead and in no hurry. The next breath the sky split from edge to edge and the water came down all at once. The smell went out of the world. Red mud, wet stone, torn leaf. Everything smelled of rain, which meant nothing smelled of anything.

She stood in the track and turned a full circle with her nose to the ground. Nothing.

Eight nights she had worked this ridge. Eight nights of lying in thorn above the cut, watching the beyond for whoever waited there with the other half of a bronze mirror's answer. Tonight, at last, the couriers had come out of the dark, a lamp hooded in a shirt, a pony stepping soft. They carried tokens. They had to. She had meant to follow them to the hand that took delivery.

Thunder cracked directly overhead. The other one flattened to the stones with her ears back and her whole hide twitching, and Neela, behind the animal's eyes, said the only dry thing she could think of.

Well. That is the monsoon, then.

She cast along the ridge, wide and then narrow. A hoofprint filled with water as she looked at it. Then another, and both were only holes. Frogs started up in every ditch at once, a screaming chorus. The pass

would close with this. Not tonight, not this week, but the sky had said its first word, and she had twenty nights left to hear the rest.

The trail was gone, and it cost her something to admit it. She turned for home.

Then came the question of the hour, and she had nothing to measure it with. No stars. No moon. The cloud sat on the hills like a lid, and the dark it made was the same dark whether it was the second watch or the fifth. The animal had never kept time. Her own body kept it for her, a slow dull ache in the bones, and tonight the ache was drowned in cold.

Two hours of night left, she decided. Perhaps a little more.

Her cache lay under the second spur, in the cleft where she had hidden a cloth and a gourd. It was a long climb the wrong way up the slope, and by now the cleft would be a gutter running red. The ledge was nearer. Two hours was plenty for the ledge, she told herself, and she ran for it.

Down the ridge to the cut, across the scree on feet that skidded, along the base of the cliff where the shelf ran, and the water ran with her, ankle-deep and loud. Once she went down on her side in a gully, and the cold slapped the breath out of her. She heaved up and ran on. The fort came out of the weather as a darker block on dark. Laterite walls. A bar of weak yellow where the padippura lamp burned.

By the lantana it came. Not the ache now. A pull, low in the throat. A drag at the bones of her forelegs, as if someone far off had taken hold of a rope tied to her.

No, said Neela. *Not yet. Not yet.*

First light did not ask. Behind the cloud, past the east hills, the sun had come up on its ordinary schedule, and under the rain the sky had gone from black to the colour of wet slate. She had misjudged the hour by one, and then by more. The mistake was hers, and the spur was now a world away.

She went up the terraces low, as fast as the slope allowed. The pepper vines slapped her face. A goat shouted from the shed. Pepper, the white one, who bit. On the parapet above, the ginger tom sat out the storm

under an overhang with his notched ear flat, and watched her go up the wall with deep personal contempt.

The change came on in earnest at the base of the wall. She climbed it with her claws going soft on the stone.

*

The ledge was still a reach above her when her front paw became a hand.

The pad flattened and the claws drew in with a tearing ache, the knuckles lengthening, and she was clinging to the lip of the sill by fingers that were not quite fingers. Fur fell off her in wet clumps and stuck to the stone. The spine was the worst. It unbent from the middle, one bone at a time, so that she was half a cat and half a woman on the ledge outside the warden's window. She could not do this part faster. She could only get in out of the rain.

The shutter stood ajar, as she had left it. The third slat gave its little creak when she shouldered it wide.

She got her chest over the sill and her head up, gasping, and saw the room.

A lamp was lit. That was the first wrong thing. It was turned low on the chest at the foot of the bed, throwing a small yellow room inside the larger grey one. The second wrong thing was the bed. The quilt lay smooth, unslept. And on the edge of it, his boots flat on the boards and his forearms on his knees, sat Devan, fully dressed.

His eyes were open.

Not through the lashes. Not a sleeper's face. He looked straight at her, the way he looked at a ledger on a hard day, a thing to be taken in whole.

She could do nothing but finish.

The rest took perhaps a minute, and it was the worst minute she had ever spent in her skin. The fur went. The gold under it dimmed and shrank to skin, goosefleshed, shuddering. The cat's long jaw drew back into a face. Her breath broke from a rasp into something that nearly had words in it. She dragged herself over the sill and down onto the cold

boards, on hands and knees, and the cloth she kept folded in the corner was an arm's length away and might as well have been in Kodiyur.

He said nothing. He sat very still, hands loose and open between his knees, and watched the whole of it without looking away. When the last of the fur came out of her wrist in one wet strand and fell, his eyes went to the strand and stayed there a moment. Then they came back up.

Only when she was wholly a woman, naked on the boards with her teeth knocking, did he speak.

"The cloth is where you left it," he said.

She took it. Her hands were not steady and she got it over her head on the second try, and when her face came out of the neck of it she found he was looking at the shutter. At the third slat. Politely, as a man looks away from a stranger changing in a coach.

Her tongue was a strip of dry leather. She asked the only question she had.

"How long?"

"Since the wedding night." His voice was low and even. "You went out as soon as I lay down. I was awake. I have been awake for every one you made here. Twenty days."

Neela sat on her heels and let the number go through her.

Twenty. She counted back and found the third slat in every one. Every dusk at this window, the bar lifted, the resin burning. Every dawn she had come home to it, with fur coming off in handfuls and him a body's length away, his breath slowed to a sleeper's. Not all the dawns. Some mornings she had turned back in the cleft and walked up the terraces in daylight, and he had been out at the pit or on the road, and she had thought herself clever. It made no difference. He had been awake for the dusks, and a dusk was enough.

The hitch. A third of the way through the long count, every time. She had filed it under chance, on the day it fell on the exact beat of her laugh, and had congratulated herself on her thoroughness.

And that supper eight nights ago, over Janu's fish. *Someone should leave him a bowl of milk. He's earned it.* The corner of his mouth that might have moved or might not.

She had turned that sentence over like a coin, looking for its edge. It had one. She had simply not been willing to cut herself on it.

"Why tonight?" she said. It was a coward's question, a way to stay on the doorstep of the answer. She asked it anyway.

"The rain," said Devan. "You were late. I wanted you to come in to a lit room."

She looked at the lamp. It stood on the chest where the dark should have been, turned low, the way one is left for someone coming in from weather. She did not know what to do with that, so she put it down beside the rest.

"You were asleep," she said.

"I was not."

The cold went all the way in.

Witnesses. She had never needed to count them. There were two, and they were hers: Chathu, who wrote her page in resin-ink in a locked room on the day she first turned, and Ammu, who was fourteen and shaking and held her hand through it. Chathu, who read pages aloud at dusk to women who owed him. Ammu, who had never said the word and never would. Two, for eleven years.

And a man on the edge of a bed, with his own sword lying on the floor on her side of it. Hilt toward her, every night. It had lain there so long she had stopped seeing it. Now she saw the worn grip, and the whole of the last twenty days tipped toward it.

Three.

Her body moved before her mind did. She rolled, shoulder and hip, along the boards to the end of the bed, away from the lamp, and her right arm went down into the gap between mattress and frame where the knife lay. Guild steel, plain, six inches. The grip came into her palm cold as the night it had lain through, and as familiar as her own wrist. She came up on one knee with it in her hand.

Devan let her.

She saw that as she rose. He had watched her cross the floor and had not shifted a boot. Now she was an arm and a half from him, near enough to count the pulse in his throat. The place under the ear. A marma strike could do it with no blade at all, one thumb, and she was close enough.

And then what? A warden dead in his own bed at first light, his bride naked in the room, was no leopard kill. It was a murder with her name on it. The contract would fail whatever she did next. She would hang, or run with the guild behind her and the crown ahead, and Chathu would read her page at dusk all the same.

That was the reason, and it was a good one. The second was smaller, and she did not look at it. His hands had stayed open between his knees, and his eyes, steady and brown, stayed on her face and not on the knife.

"I thought you might," he said. "Do it, if you're going to. I'll say what I came to say first."

It was a thing he might have said about breakfast. Her pulse went up behind her ears. She did not lower the knife. She did not lift it, either.

"Say it, then."

"Someone paid for my death." He said it without drama, as a fact about weather. "The council pressed this match on me, and a bride came out of Kodiyur with a ward's name and nothing else, and she counts exits in a room she has been in a hundred times. I never took you for anything but what you are."

"And what's that?"

"Sent." He let it sit. "Here is what I can offer. What I saw, I keep. To the household, to the fort, to anyone, at any hour. I swear it on Asha's name. And I say nothing in your hearing, ever, after dark. Not in anger. Not in my sleep."

Her mouth was open. She shut it.

"For a price," she said.

"For a name. Whoever bought it." He kept his weight where it was. "The raiders hit the coast villages before the pass shuts, and whoever sells

them tokens sells them my road. Raman's boy is nine. His father is under that shelf. I need the man, and I'm giving you the only thing I have that you want. I will make the offer once. I won't make it twice, and I won't pretend it's kindness."

Rain drummed on the shutter, the cistern chain clanked over it, and her own breath rasped under both.

There it is, said the cold animal sense that had kept her alive through eleven contracts. *Not a blow. A bargain. A thread in the mouth.*

She had known it would come. Every witness she had ever had held the word, and every one of them had put it in a bargain sooner or later. Chathu's tin of jaggery sweets. *A gift is the start of a bill.* This one had only taken longer than most.

"I don't have a name," she said.

His face did not change. "The guild never tells."

"The guild never tells." She wet her lips. "You know that already. You knew it when you asked."

"I hoped."

"Hope is cheap." Her voice was hoarse but it did not shake, and she was grateful for that. "Suppose I did have it. Suppose it was written on my arm. I wouldn't buy my life from a man who can take it with one word."

The room went quiet.

Whatever he gave her, he could take. Whatever he kept silent about, he *kept*. She had been owned for twenty-one years by a man who called it mercy.

He looked at her a long while. Then he nodded once, slowly, like a man setting down something heavy.

"That is fair," he said.

"It isn't fair. It's only what it is."

"Then we both know where we stand."

Devan rose carefully, favouring the mended arm. She was braced against the bedpost with the knife held low before she knew she had moved. He saw it. He saw all of it, and made no show of seeing.

At a respectful distance, the way one gives room to a dog of uncertain temper, he went by her. At the door he stopped with his hand on the latch and said, without turning, "You should eat. After a night like that. Janu will have rice up soon."

"Do you want me fed so I'll be useful?" The words were out before she could swallow them.

"I want you fed," said Devan, and went out.

The door closed softly behind him. She heard his feet go down the passage at the same unhurried pace, never breaking stride. He had stepped over the sword where it lay and left it there. He would go to the kalari with nothing, as he did every dawn.

*

Neela stayed where she was until her legs gave.

Then she went down onto the sill and sat with her knees against her chest and the knife in her fist and the shutters wide behind her. The rain blew in. It came sideways through the gap and over her shoulders and down the cloth, and she did not close them. A closed shutter had been a lie for twenty days, and she wanted, for a little while, to sit in the weather and be told the truth by it.

Her shaking was real, the great ugly shudder she had only ever had after a bad turning. It was not the cold. It was not the hunger either, though that sat in her hollow as always.

She made herself do it the way she did a lock.

Exits. The door he had gone through. The window, and a drop of thirty feet. The knife.

Breaths. She counted eight, lost the number, and began again.

What do I know?

That he had seen her turn, at least twenty times, and said nothing. That he had let her cross a floor with a blade and kept his hands open. That he had sat up through the last of the dark with a lamp lit, waiting for her to come home. That he had held his tongue until the last strand

of gold was out of her and the sky was grey and the word could do her no harm. That he had *known* when that was.

A hunter knew that. A hunter would know to the minute, and wait, and have a kind of grace about waiting.

She tried the other reading and could not hold it. It slid out of her hand. The man who closed the shutters on her, the man who fed a cat. She could not afford it. Every kind thing that came to mind was also, from another side, a very good trap.

He offered the thing once and I said no. She sat with that. *And he said, "That is fair."*

It was the worst thing he could have said. She turned it over and found no seam. She looked at the third slat, at the sword hilt lying on the boards, and could not tell which of them had been keeping watch on her.

Under the rain, round the curve of the east wall where she could not see, something began. Bare feet on packed earth, a soft rhythmic scuff, then the slap of a palm on a bare shoulder. A thread of sesame oil came up the passage on the wet air, from a lamp lit somewhere below. She knew the sound. She had heard it in her sleep on the mornings she slept at all, and taken it for the dream-noises of a restless house.

He was drilling. In weather like this. With one good arm, and no one to strike at but the air.

The cistern chain clanked, and she counted it. She sat on the sill with the rain at her back and the knife in her hand and her whole life lying in another person's mouth, and could not tell whether the man in the pit was practising or waiting.

Chapter 16

Terms Withdrawn

Devan stood in the middle of the pit with the practice staff in his good hand and could not finish the form.

He had come down after leaving her, with her voice still in his ears, and begun as he always did. Plant the left foot. Drop the weight. Let the staff speak. For an hour his body did it by rote while the rain beat the red earth to paste and the lamps guttered in their niches. Once he wondered whether the slap of his palm on his shoulder carried round the curve of the wall to the west window. He did not know where she was. He did not let himself guess.

Then the rain thinned to a drizzle, and in the quiet something surfaced that he had not thought of in twelve years. His left foot stayed where it was, halfway through the third form. The strapped arm ached with each breath. That was not the trouble.

I will make the offer once. I won't make it twice.

He heard it in his own voice, level and unhurried, and then he heard it in someone else's.

At the border school, in his second year, an instructor had read the class a letter taken from a dead guild courier. It had been addressed to an odiyan who had balked. The letter was kind. That was what made the room go quiet. *Your silence about the matter pleases me, child, and I shall be pleased to go on keeping mine. I expect you will find a kindness of your*

own to return. The instructor had folded it and said only, "That is how they do it. Nobody is ever struck. A debt is simply mentioned."

Devan had been twenty. He had thought it the vilest thing he had ever heard read aloud.

He set the staff's butt in the mud and leaned on it.

The offer had been meant as honesty. He had told her exactly what he would give and exactly what he wanted, and named it plain, so she could refuse it plain. And she had. *I wouldn't buy my life from a man who can take it with one word.* She had said it with a knife in her hand and the fur still drying on the boards. It was the truest thing anyone had said to him in eight years.

His silence for her name. A kindness, and a debt mentioned. A word kept behind his teeth for the day it became useful.

For eight years he had laid his hands on no living body, and he had told himself the rule was about his hands. Then came the west stair, the morning Janu found Asha, with Janu's scream rising from the court below and his sister's blood gone brown on the step. He had stood there and made a second vow, the one that stretched the first. *Whatever I am, I will not be the one who holds a throat.* A hand was not the only way to hold one. A word would do it, if it was the right word and you were the only man who could say it.

He had built a man around that vow. He had cut every kind of power off at the root so it could never be turned on anyone.

And at first light he had sat on the edge of his own bed, holding the one power he could not cut away, and put a price on it.

He had even been pleased with how fair it sounded.

"Warden?"

Muthu stood at the top of the north steps with a cloak over his head and a cheerful, careful face. "You've been stood there since the second clank. Gopan's laying wagers on whether you've died upright."

"I am considering."

"Considering what?"

"A mistake."

Muthu came down two steps. “Is it one of mine?”

“No.” Devan looked at the lamps. “Mine. I’d like to mend it before dusk.”

“Then I’ll bring broth and not ask.” Muthu went back up, and at the rim he stopped. “For what it’s worth, Warden, you’ve the look of a man who has decided.”

Devan hadn’t. But when Muthu was gone he found he had planted his left foot. He ran the third form through once, badly, one arm tucked against his ribs, and stopped with his answer clear.

You cannot hand a woman her own cage back with terms attached. You hand it over, or you do not.

*

At dusk the room was grey, and the shutters stood open on a sky the colour of wet ash. Rain tapped the sill. The cistern chain clanked once, far below.

She sat on the chest at the foot of the bed, her back to the wall, where she could see both the door and the window. Her hair was wet. She had eaten; the rice bowl was clean and set aside. The knife lay across her knee. The cork flask sat beside her, and she was not looking at it.

He stopped inside the door and did not come farther.

“Before the light goes,” he said. “I have something to take back.”

Her eyes were on his hands. He turned them palm out, empty, and then felt foolish and let them hang.

“This morning I offered you my silence for a name.” He kept his voice flat. It was the only way he knew to say a hard thing. “I called it a bargain. It wasn’t. It was what the guild does. A word held over a person, and a price named for not saying it. I heard myself doing it and I did not stop. I have been trying all day to find a gentler way of putting that, and there isn’t one.”

She did not move. The rain went on.

“I withdraw it. The whole of it. There’s no name to pay, now or later, and no favour owed. I won’t ask for the name as the cost of anything.”

He drew a breath. "What I saw, I keep. That isn't a gift with a string. It's yours. You don't owe me for it, and I won't count it against you."

"You can say it any night you like." Her voice was low and had no heat in it. She was laying the fact on the table like a card. "That's what it is. You know that."

"Yes." He did not look away. "That's the one thing I can't mend. I can't unwitness myself. I can only tell you I won't, and let you watch whether I do." He nodded at the window. "The shutters are yours. Barred, open, whatever you want. I won't touch them. I'll sleep, or not, and I won't watch."

He turned to the door. His hand found the latch.

"Why?"

It came sharp and quick from behind him, the question of a woman who had been holding it all day and had finally run out of room to hold it.

He stopped, his back to her and the latch cold under his thumb.

*

"Because I don't want to own anyone."

Neela weighed the words, rapping at them the way she'd rap a wall for a hollow. They rang solid all the way through.

He turned then, and she saw his face in the last of the light. It was the same face as ever, brown and spare and shut, with a tiredness at the eyes that had nothing to do with the arm.

"That isn't an answer," she said. "That's a motto."

"It's the whole of it." He shrugged with one shoulder. "I was a bad master this morning. I would rather not be a better one."

"Everyone wants something."

"I do." He said it at once. "I want the name. I'd be a liar to say otherwise, and I don't lie to you. I want it badly. But I won't buy it, and I won't get it by sitting on you."

"And if I never give it?"

"Then I'll go on wanting it." The corner of his mouth moved, and was gone. "It won't be the worst thing I've wanted and not had."

She waited for the rest. The clause. The small, soft *but.* In eleven contracts she had never met a gift that didn't arrive with one, and she watched his mouth the way she'd watch a lock for the click.

It never came. He nodded, as if she had answered him, and went out. His feet went away down the passage, unhurried, as they had that morning.

She sat in the grey room with the knife across her knee.

Reread it, she told herself, the way she'd go back over a house after a job. The first half. All of it, from the night of the wedding.

She got up and crossed to the west window. The long teak bar leaned against the wall beside the frame, where she had left it that morning. She had lifted it a dozen times, in the dark, to climb out. Now she took it in both hands. It was heavier than she remembered, a good arm and a half of seasoned wood, and her shoulders felt it. Barred from the second dusk. She had thought it a bar to keep something in, or a bar to shut her out. It had been a bar to keep the fort out.

Below, the yard lay quiet. No hound bayed. Fourteen loose hounds would have bayed the other one across the court every night of her life here, and she had tied the kennels to his *Rain* at dusk under a clear sky, and stopped there. She had stopped short of the end of the rope.

She set the bar down. The rest came all at once, short, like stones down a stair. The empty rampart over the sill. The corridor lamp outside the door, left unlit, so nothing would light her coming in at dawn half-dressed. *The cat.* A bowl of milk, and *he's earned it.* Janu's man-eater cut off over the rice. *Not tonight, Janu.* The bowl of rice waiting after every hollow morning, and she had never once asked who told Janu.

Her breath had got short. She put her hand flat on the cold lid of the chest and counted until it was even.

Each of them was a kindness. All of them together were a fence built stone by stone around a single thing, so carefully that no one could see the thing without looking at the fence.

Or they were one other thing, if you stood where she'd stood for twenty-one years on the guild's page.

Chathu had never struck a new intake. She remembered that now. He learned which girl cried at night, and left a tin of warm sweets by her mat, and asked after her cough. He saw that she was fed, and kept her from the older girls, and was gentle for years. Every girl in the yard would have walked into a cage for him. Then he read the page.

A caged odiyan would guard a pass. A caged odiyan would be a weapon no council could argue with. The one thing in the fort worth more caged than killed was her.

Twenty nights, said the quiet voice. *Nineteen now. He needs only wait for one dusk when you are most useful, and say it.*

And today he had given back the one thing she could use against him. He had made himself harmless in her sight. If that was Chathu's craft, it was the finest she had seen.

She couldn't prove it. That was what she hated. She couldn't prove it, and she could not disprove it either, and he had stood in the door and said *I want the name* in the same level voice he had used to say *rain*.

So there were two mistakes open to her. If she trusted him and was wrong, she lost her life, and Ammu's behind it, and the cage for every sister who ever took a kindly word at face value. If she distrusted him and he was honest, she lost only this, whatever this was. A man at a door who asked for nothing.

The first mistake ended her. The other only hurt. She would make the one that hurt, and make it on purpose, and she would not call it anything else.

A single night could not prove mercy. A patient man would behave beautifully tonight too. But tonight his word could not touch her, because with no resin on her there would be no other one to cage. What she would test was her body: a woman lying down human beside a stronger man who was awake. Would the sword move? Would a hand come near her? Would he reach for the knife in the gap by her hip?

She picked up the flask and held it to the window. The light was nearly gone. The cork sat tight in the neck, the bitter smell of scorched tamarind leaking round it.

It had a price, and she made herself read it off. No resin meant no scent on the posts, and no mark left in the cup of the meeting stone. Ammu's jackal had found that cup bare once already, on the fever night. The narrows mark had come late, and late had passed. A second bare cup would tell Ammu that something was wrong, and Ammu would come asking. Chathu had said every day counted double now. Another night went unmarked against the moon, too, and the ache, nine or ten days off by her count of rationed nights, kept its own ledger.

She would pay it, and she corked the flask harder than she needed to and pushed it deep into the fold of her cloth.

The dark came on. The cistern chain clanked. The lamp stayed unlit on the chest. Somewhere in the passage a door closed, and some time after, the latch of their own door lifted, and she heard him come in.

She did not turn. She lay on her side, her face to the wall, in her day-shift, with her hands and throat clean. She had never felt so naked in her life. The knife lay in the gap between mattress and frame where it always did. She did not touch it, though her fingers wanted to, and she kept them curled under her chin.

Behind her the boards creaked. Something was set down on the floor with the soft knock of a steel pommel on wood. Hilt toward her. It had always been hilt toward her.

She could not tell any more if it was trust or a leash with a handle.

The bed shifted at the far edge. Sunset had come and gone, and her body noticed. It began as an itch deep in the old scars at throat and wrist, the skin expecting a burn it was owed. She pressed her wrists against her breastbone and breathed through it with her teeth together, and it faded. Craving, and nothing more. There was no resin on her for it to turn.

He lay down on his back, and the quilt rustled. She listened for the thing she had come to test. No hand. No creak of the sword lifted from

the boards. No shift of weight toward the frame and the knife. He lay as far from her as the bed allowed, and he did not move at all.

His breath was too even. For a long time it ran smooth as a ruled line, with no catch in it anywhere, and she knew that was a man taking care. Then, a third of the way through a long count, the hitch came. Slow. Deliberate. Exactly where it had always been, and exactly as long.

The hitch had never been sleep. It had been him, all twenty nights, and now he was giving it to her on purpose, so she could count him.

So she counted. She lay still with her eyes open on the wall and counted that catch into the dark, over and over, and could not make the number come out to mercy or to patience.

Somewhere past midnight she counted something else. Grey was five hours off. At grey the watcher in the pass village would walk the hill's edge and read her posts, and find not one of them fresh. A second refusal, written down for Chathu in a stranger's hand. The cup at the stone would be bare, and Ammu would be climbing the spur by noon.

She closed her eyes on it, human, with her back to him and the knife untouched.

Chapter 17

The Keeper's Letter

The first rule of the dark was that she could ask him anything.

Nobody had agreed to it. It had simply grown there on the second night, the way a path grows where enough feet have gone. She lay on her back with the lamp out and the shutters open to the rain, and he lay at the far edge of the bed with the sword on the boards on her side. For a long time neither of them spoke.

Then she said, to the ceiling, "Why is the hilt on my side?"

"So you never have to reach across me for anything."

She turned that over. It was exactly the sort of answer he gave. A fact, with a kindness folded inside it like a coin in a cloth, and no comment from him on either.

"You knew about the knife," she said.

"Under the mattress, your side. Since the second week." He breathed out. "I never moved it."

She had suspected as much. It still landed low in the belly. "Were you afraid? That first night."

"Yes."

She waited. In her old life, a man who said yes meant *no*, or *a little*, or *but I mastered it*.

"For about a breath," said Devan. "I know what the word does, and I thought, it will see me. Then it looked away, and went over the ledge like

something that had done it a hundred times. After that I was afraid of the wrong thing."

"Which was?"

"That you'd look round."

Rain ticked on the sill. Somewhere below, the cistern chain clanked, and she counted it out of habit and lost the number.

"What would you do with the name?" she said. "If you had it."

"Take it to the high court at Kodiyur, with the seals in my hand." No pause. "I would not kill him. I'd like you to know that, since you will wonder."

"I wasn't going to."

"You were."

She had been. She let it go.

The third question she had carried all day, and it came out smaller than she had planned. "How did she die? Your sister."

The bed did not creak. His breath, which had the little hitch in it a third of the way through, did not hitch.

"I won't answer that," he said.

It was the second time he had refused her that question. Tonight the words sat in the dark as plainly as the sword on the boards.

She was glad. That was the ugly part. Something low in her went slack with relief, as if she had put a hand near a stove and been told not to. She didn't ask herself why. She lay and was ashamed of the gladness instead, which was easier.

"May I ask one?" he said.

"You can ask."

"I'm not asking for a price."

"I know." And she did, which was new. "Ask."

"What do you call it? When it isn't me saying *the cat*."

The room waited. The word sat in her mouth like a stone she could swallow or spit. She had never said it aloud, not to anyone, not to Ammu.

"The other one," she said.

"Thank you," said Devan, and no more. He did not turn to her. After a while his breath went long, then came the small hitch, and she knew he was awake and letting her hear it.

Two nights without resin, and she'd paid the ledger for both. No hunting the ridge. A cup at the meeting stone left bare. The ache would start in a week if she kept on, a slow fever in the nails first. She had made the sums on the sill that evening, and the sums said this was foolish.

She lay in the dark and spent the night anyway.

*

Sudhi came up the hill on the ninth day with the royal post in an oilcloth bag, a steaming pony, and a face the colour of a boiled prawn.

Neela knew the pony's name, because she knew everyone's. Biscuit. The groom was Appu, nine years old and in love with it. She stood on the lower terrace with a basket of pepper clippings on her hip, watching the rider hand his bag to Unni at the gate. Muthu came out of the guardroom with his big laugh and a grey-sealed letter ready in his fist.

He was talking about his mother. He was always talking about his mother. Sudhi took the letter without a word, tucked it into the bag, and rode on to the stable to be fed.

Plain grey wax, no mark. She put it on the shelf in her head where she kept things she didn't yet know how to use.

Devan took his own post at the gate and said nothing all afternoon. At dusk he came up, shut the door behind him, and lit the lamp himself. He stood with one letter, three sheets, and a face that was too still.

"This is addressed to me," he said. "It speaks of you. I would rather you heard it in my voice than Janu's." He held it out so she could see the seal. "Council wax."

It was brick red, with the pepper sprig pressed deep. She caught the smell when he cracked it, a faint sweet note of clove.

"Read," she said. "All of it. Don't skip."

He stood by the lamp with the rain black in the window behind him, and read.

"*To my friend Devan, Warden of Kettamala, from his friend Ittan, Keeper of the Passes. Greetings, and may the rains find you well roofed.*"

Neela folded her arms. She began, without meaning to, to count.

"*My friend, I write in haste, which is why this runs to three pages. My friend, the council has voted what we all knew it must, that the Monkey Pass be sealed for the season. And I have asked, my friend, that I be the one to do it. A man ought to look upon the gate he locks. I shall climb to you before the last carts go down, a fortnight, perhaps less, if the roads allow. I ask only a dry bed and a plain supper, my friend. I know your Janu by reputation. I fear her plain suppers.*"

He read the joke flatly, as he read everything. It did not make it less of a joke.

"*I hear the pepper is heavy this year. I hear your hounds are well. My friend, I hear many things, and I keep them like an old woman keeps buttons, for no reason but the comfort of having them. And how does your bride, my friend? I think of her often. A young woman far from the coast, and the long rains coming on. Such a comfort to a house, my friend, a wife. Such a comfort, should anything befall the fort in the dark months, to know there is one within its walls.*" He turned a page. "*Give her my regards, my friend, and my hope that she is well and happy and not overwhelmed. Do not trouble to answer, my friend, for the roads are bad and I shall be with you soon enough. I remain, my friend, as ever, your friend, Ittan.*"

He lowered it.

"Eleven," said Neela.

"Eleven what?"

"*My friend.* Eleven times, and *your friend* at the close. Twelve." She tipped her head. "It's more than a man says to a friend, Devan. It's what he says to someone he's not sure of."

"Ittan writes like that to everyone. He's said *my friend* to the queen's cook." But he looked at the page again, and she saw him run his eye down it, counting. "Twelve," he agreed.

"And it asks after me. Not after the fort. After *me*, and what I am to the fort." She kept her voice level. "*Should anything befall.* Befall what? He doesn't say the warden. A man who writes three pages and doesn't write the word *you* there is choosing not to."

"Or he is a fond fool with a lot of ink."

"Is he a fool?"

Devan was quiet. Then, slowly: "No."

"Who is he to you?"

"Keeper of the Passes. He has written me a kind letter every season for six years. Since the rains Asha died." He flipped the sheets over, as if the back might confess. "He has never once climbed this hill. The council sends a clerk to seal the pass, with a sack of lead wafers and a bad cold. Ittan says he is coming himself."

"Then I mark two things," said Neela. "First, that he climbs himself. Second, the comfort."

"The comfort."

"Comfort to whom? You don't send comfort to a man whose house is fine. You send it to a man whose house you've an eye on." She spread her hands. "I don't know what it means. I only know it was chosen."

He set the letter on the chest. For a moment she saw him weigh whether to say the next thing, and decide.

"Here is what I have. Three seals." He held up three fingers, the way a man tells off cattle. "The council keeps seven tally seals. Four are cut with a bar at the sprig's stem. Three are cut with a dot and a split under it. The forged tallies bear the dot. So it's one of three boxes, or a copy of one. Three keepers on the council. Each box passes through a clerk's hands, and clerks have wives and debts."

"And the keepers' names?"

"I have them." He didn't give them. She noted that he didn't, and noted too that he hadn't hidden it. "The Keeper's office holds one of the three."

She stilled.

"I'd be a fool to say that proves a thing," said Devan. "The Keeper's office holds a great deal. Boxes, ledgers, the key to the pass. If the pass is sold, it was sold from his desk or past it."

"And the fourth?"

"Fourth, a man called Sudhi."

She hadn't expected it from him in that voice. "The rider."

"He carries the palace post up and the fort's post down. He carried the sandalwood box. Anything that can be wrapped in a letter can ride in his bag, and no one looks in the bag of a man in palace green." He rubbed his thumb along the chest's edge. "I've watched his hands for three posts and seen nothing. He is a boy with a sore saddle. That doesn't make him clean."

"Muthu hands him letters."

"To his mother." Devan said it quickly, the way a man says a thing he has said to himself on a long night. "Muthu has stood at my back for eight years."

And you, Devan, have not turned around to look. She did not say it. She weighed it, though, with a small cold interest. He had no doubt of Muthu. It was the one place his eye did not go.

"A rider, or a keeper," she said. "Which do you think?"

"The seals. A rider is a thief. A keeper is a thing that has to be dug out."

"I'd say the letter." She nodded at the chest. "A man who sells passes by the cartload doesn't write. He sends a man with a purse and no signature. Only someone who wants it on record that he was kind would write *friend* twelve times."

"Or someone who is kind."

"Or that." She heard her own dry note and let it stand. "We'll see which, when he climbs."

Devan looked at her. She had expected the old, shut look. Instead he looked as if she had set a stone on a scale he'd been trying to balance for six years, and the needle had swung.

"We," he said.

She didn't answer, which was an answer of a kind.

*

Later, past the middle watch, with the lamp out. The shutters open, the rain gone to a mist that smelled of red earth.

She stood at the window with the flask corked in her fist and did not open it. That made three nights. The cost of a fourth sat on her tongue like a bitter seed.

Devan lay with his eyes shut and his boots off, the whole bed between him and the sword, doing a very good impression of a man resting. She watched his mouth. She had caught herself at it all week, the way she watched a lock for the click, waiting for the lie to land.

"You haven't asked again," she said.

He didn't open his eyes. "Asked what?"

"The name. You said once. You said you wouldn't say it twice. Then you took it back and I thought you'd pick it up again as soon as I'd forgotten. It's been three days."

"I said no terms."

"You meant it?"

"I don't say a thing I don't mean."

"That's not an answer."

At last his eyes opened. They went to her, steady and brown, and stayed. "It is, though," he said. "If I ask, I'm asking for a price, however I put it. You told me what that is. I would rather lose the name than be the man you described."

She stood with the flask in her hand and felt a small, sharp disorder in the place where her plan for him lived. A hunter doesn't say that. A hunter says *take your time*. A hunter keeps the door ajar.

Or says it, so you'll think he isn't one.

She gave it up. She could not tell, and she was tired of not being able to tell, and the tiredness itself was a danger.

Out on the hill, thin and high, a sound began.

Three short yips. A pause long enough to count four. Then one long note, climbing, climbing, and held until it broke.

Her hand closed on the flask hard enough to hurt.

Tomorrow. I will find you.

She had made that call herself, at eleven, behind the sheds, with Ammu's skinny arm round her neck and the whole Resin House asleep. It was the only thing in her life that had been hers and Ammu's alone. Now it came over the terraces like a hook thrown across a river.

She did not move. Behind her, in the dark, Devan did not move either. His breath stopped for a count, then started up again, a shade slower.

She waited for him to ask. A man who knew what a jackal's yip was and what it was not, who had spent twenty nights learning the shape of her silences, would ask. And she had no lie ready. For the first time in eleven contracts, she hadn't built one.

"That's not a jackal," Devan said.

"No."

He said nothing more.

She turned around. He lay as he had lain, on his back, one arm across his ribs, eyes on the ceiling beams. He had the face of a man who had decided not to look at something and would see it through.

"You're not going to ask," she said.

"I'd rather you told me. If you tell me." He kept his eyes upward. "I'll want you to be able to say *I won't answer that* to me as easily as I said it to you."

"Even if it's about someone who could hurt you."

"Especially then."

"That's not sensible."

"No," he agreed. "It's a term."

She laughed. It escaped her, a short, startled breath, and she covered her mouth with the back of her wrist, bangle cold against her lip. It was not a pleasant laugh. It was the laugh of a person who has been handed something and cannot find the pocket for it.

"Tomorrow," she said, "I'll be gone from the terraces. If Muthu asks."

"You went to the market. Parukutty's girl has a cough." He said it at once, to the beams. "It's even true. She has."

She stared at him. He had given her the lie before she asked, and chosen one that wasn't a lie.

"Go to sleep, Devan."

"I'm trying."

She did not take the resin. She lay down on her side of the bed with her back to the wall and her face to the room, where she could see the lamp-black shape of him and the pale line of the sword. Seventeen nights left. Seventeen was also the number Chathu had written over her page.

The cistern chain clanked. The mist drifted in at the window and lay on the boards like milk.

She lay awake a long time, and the worst of it was the wanting. It was the plainest want she had known in years. She wanted to give him something. Not the name. She didn't have the name, and if she'd had it she did not know that she could. She wanted to put a thing in his hand the way he had put the lie for the market in hers. A clean thing, with nothing behind it.

She went through what she had. A flask. A leopard's tooth in the waistband, the guild's. Eleven contracts that had ended in the dark. Not one of them was a gift.

Ammu will find me tomorrow. She held the thought still and looked at it. Ammu would ask where the reports had gone, and what kind of woman sleeps three nights without resin beside a man she has been sent to kill. And Neela would have to say something, and in the whole of her life she had never had trouble with that.

So she chose, there in the dark, what Ammu would get. The seal boxes. The Keeper's letter and his coming. The hill, the pass, the rider. All of it true, and all of it hers to spend. She would not give Ammu the man.

Across the dark the hitch came, a third of the way through his breath.

She counted it. It came again. She went on counting, and for once the number did not come out to a trap. It came out to a man lying awake so she would know he was there, and a woman lying awake so he would know she was.

She slid her hand into the gap between mattress and frame and closed it on the hilt. Six inches of plain guild steel, kept there since the wedding. She drew it out slowly, so the slats wouldn't ring, and leaned across the dark. She laid it on the boards on his side of the sword, hilt toward him.

The hitch stopped. She heard him not breathe.

"It's the only thing I have that's mine," she said, to the ceiling.

He did not touch it. He did not say thank you. After a long while his breath began again, and the hitch with it, and she shut her eyes with her hands empty for the first time since she was six.

Chapter 18

Kirri's Anklet

Ammu was already at the meeting stone, sitting on it with her heels drumming the laterite, and she did not look like a girl who had come to chat.

Neela climbed the last of the second spur at the slow pace of a trader's ward gathering wild pepper leaf. She had told Muthu she was going down to Parukutty's, and she had gone, and the child's cough was real. Then she had walked the long way round, up through the pala trees, with a basket on her hip and a count running in her head. Sixteen nights. Her nails had begun to itch at the quick, the way they did before the ache.

"You're late, chechi," said Ammu. "And thin."

"And you're loud."

"Nobody's here but monkeys." But Ammu dropped her voice anyway. Her cover was a coast girl's blue cotton and a pepper trader's sack, and under it she looked sharp as a split reed. Her eyes went over Neela's wrists, her throat, the grey under her eyes. "Three nights, the cup was bare. Four, if I count the night of the fever. I came to the gate yesterday and the gate said you were abed. I thought, she's dead, or she's in love, and I couldn't decide which one I minded more."

"Neither."

"Chathu minds neither. He minds the days." Ammu pulled a twist of paper from her sleeve, read it with her lips moving, and tucked it away

again. "He sent word with the last cart. Sixteen nights and the account is open. Every day counts double now, and he is *patient*, and you should remember what patience costs. Then he sent the sweets."

She held out a small tin. Neela knew its smell before it opened: warm jaggery and sesame. It had come before every job. She took it and put it in the basket without looking.

"Not hungry?"

"Not for his."

Ammu laughed, too fast. Then she began to hum, low and tuneless, *pull and pull, the tide is coming in,* and stopped when she heard herself.

"You only hum that when you're frightened," Neela said.

"I hum when I'm happy."

"You haven't been happy since you were nine."

Ammu picked at a chip in the stone. For a moment the quick talk ran out, and what was under it showed, thin and tired.

"Kirri swore," she said. "Do you remember? The night before they released her. She said, *I'll have my boat by the first monsoon, and the first thing off it is my anklet, in a fish-basket, so you'll know it's real.* A little silver anklet with the bells cut off, the one she never took off, not to bathe. She'd send it to us. A sign." She looked up. "Two years, chechi. I've written four times now to the address she gave. Nothing. Not a note, not a bad one. Nobody could be that busy with a boat."

"Messages get lost."

"Hers don't. She was the best liar in the House. She could send a letter through a fire." Ammu's voice cracked and she bit it back to something light. "Maybe she's fat and happy and forgotten us. Maybe she's sitting on a beach laughing. That's what I tell myself. Then I ask Chathu, and he says, *Kirri is where she wished to be, child,* and pats my hand."

Cold ran down Neela's arms. She had been given the same pat, with tins.

"Did he say where?"

"That's it. He never says where." Ammu shook herself. "Never mind. Release is a good thing. It's what we're here for. Twelve contracts and your page burns, and then there's you with your own name, and me after, and no one with a word in his mouth. So. Tell me you're close."

This was the moment. Neela had known it was coming since the jackal call, and she had still built nothing. She stood with the basket on her hip and looked at the one face in the world that had ever known all of her.

Devan has seen me turn. Devan has watched me since the wedding night and held his tongue.

Ammu would have it out of her in a breath, because it was Ammu, and then Ammu would do the sensible thing. She had been raised to it. A second witness in the world was not a gift. It was a hole in the wall, and holes were stopped.

"I'm close," said Neela.

"How close?"

"The pass shuts in sixteen days. I know his guards, his hours, the shutter slats. He has a bad arm and a worse temper."

"That's the fort. I asked about him." Ammu tipped her head. "Chinna at the kitchen door says the bride was seen at the window at dawn in her sleeping cloth. So why three bare nights, chechi? Why human, with him, in the bed?"

"To learn his sleep."

"You can learn a man's sleep from a window ledge."

"Not his waking." Neela made her voice dry and bored. "He wakes at the middle watch to walk the wall, and goes back. I wanted the pattern. If I'd smeared up every night I'd have missed it."

It was a good lie because it was nearly true. She watched it go into Ammu's face and watched Ammu turn it over, the way they'd both been taught.

"And he hasn't noticed anything?"

"What would he notice?"

"A woman who goes out at dusk and comes back at dawn with fur in her hair."

"He sleeps like a log."

"Does he." Ammu leaned in, grinning now, the old teasing grin. "Then who told you the hounds were kennelled? Who shut the shutters? I'm Valli at that kitchen door, chechi. I hear the whole fort talking. Chinna has wagers. Chinna has one on whether the warden's wife has tamed him or he has tamed her."

"A man with a fear of damp." Neela shifted the basket. "Why are you asking me this? Do you think I'm lying to you?"

She had learned as a girl how to turn a question like a blade. She hated how easily it came.

It landed too well. The grin went out of Ammu's face as if a hand had wiped it.

"Because I'm scared," she said. It came out flat and fast. "Because three bare nights is how you start to be caught. Because if anyone but us has seen you, if one person in that fort has watched you turn, then every night you sleep beside him is a night he can say it." She caught Neela's wrist. Her fingers were cold. "We're safe as long as nobody but us has seen. That's all. That's the whole of it. It has kept us alive twenty years. Tell me nobody's seen."

Neela looked at the hand on her wrist, at the scars on the inside of Ammu's, pale and ridged like her own.

She could not argue with it. That was the cruelty. It was true. It had been true when two orphans hid in the sheds, and when Vellan's bear-shape stood over them in the yard, and when other girls went into the kennels. Nobody but them had seen, and so nobody had said the word. Ammu had never spoken hers in all that time, and Neela had spent every year of it living on that silence.

"Nobody's seen," she said.

The lie had a taste, exactly like the resin on a bad night. Bitter, then burning, and then you went on.

Ammu's grip loosened. She let out a long breath and laughed at herself, and the laugh was real, which was the worst of it.

"Good. *Good.* I'm a fool. I've been sat in an inn for three weeks with nothing to do but think." She wiped her eyes with the heel of her hand. "Leave me a mark in the cup tomorrow night. Anything. A stone. I'll know."

"I'll try."

"Don't try, chechi. Do." She slid down off the stone. Then, light again, Valli the pepper girl once more: "That's a pretty gold bangle. Is it real?"

"It's real."

"Keep it." Ammu was already going, down through the pala trees, a quick blue shape between the trunks. At the bend she hummed three notes of the fishing song and stopped.

Neela stood a long time by the stone with the sweets tin in her basket. Where was Kirri? Maybe the boat was real, and the sea had taken it, and Chathu's pat on the hand was only a kind man sparing two girls a grief. Or Kirri had never left the Resin House at all. She could ask. A line in the cup, a question in the next message. But a girl who asked where a released sister had gone was a girl who doubted release, and Chathu kept a ledger of doubts as carefully as he kept the other kind.

She would not ask. She knew what that cost, and she paid it anyway. She stood and listened for the small silver sound of bells that had been cut off, then made herself walk home.

*

By evening the rain had gone, and the hall at Kettamala smelled of wet cloth and frying onions and lamp oil.

Janu had commanded it. "Nobody's done anything with their hands but the sword for a month," she told the long room, rapping a ladle on a pot. "Hands want something else. Seven wells, and I'll have the new lady learn it."

Neela had expected to endure it. She had learned long ago to sit out a household's games with a polite face, counting the doors. But the hall was loud and warm, and the old woman ordered people about in a way so plainly loving that it was hard to stand outside it.

The board was a plank scratched with seven small hollows in a ring. Each player took seven grey pebbles from a bowl. You tossed them one by one at the wells from an arm's length, and the first to seat all seven won, but only a pebble that struck a wall of the hollow and *then* dropped counted, and you could knock a rival's stone out with a good flick.

"Skill," Janu said. "And a clean conscience. Cheats get a rap on the knuckle."

"Has anyone ever been rapped?" Neela asked.

"Every one of them. Muthu most."

"Slander," said Muthu, from the bench, with the big laugh already coming.

Across the board sat Devan. He had his bad arm propped on his knee and a face of grave attention, as if the game were a council. He took his seven pebbles from the bowl and set them in a neat row.

"You've played this before," said Neela.

"Once. I was eight." He considered a stone. "Asha beat me."

It was the first time he had said her name in the hall. Janu's ladle stopped. Then he flicked his pebble and it clipped the rim of the first well, spun, and dropped. "She cheated," he added, in his flat voice.

"She did *not*," said Janu, outraged, and the silence broke.

The game ran. Neela threw badly at first, on purpose, to learn the board. Then she saw it: the plank rocked a finger's width on its trestle if you leaned your elbow on the near edge. A pebble thrown in time with the rock dropped dead into the well. It was a trick for a cheap fairground. She did not even decide to do it. Her hand simply went.

Three wells. Four. Muthu groaned. Unni, who had been drafted from the gate, cheered with his mouth full.

Five. She lined up the sixth and leaned her elbow.

"Your elbow," said Devan.

"I'm resting it."

"On the plank." His eyes had not moved from her face. They were bright, and for a moment she did not recognise what was in them. "You lean when the board rocks. You've done it four times. I have been counting."

"Counting what?"

"Your elbow." He leaned forward, and she saw the corner of his mouth go, and keep going. "It's very good."

The hall had gone still to listen. Janu had a hand over her heart. Neela put the sixth pebble down in its well with great dignity and said, "I don't know what you mean."

"Then you won't mind if I throw."

He took his own seven. He did not lean on the plank. He leaned on the *trestle*, with his knee, at the far leg, and the whole board tipped by a hair. His pebble hit the wall of the well and dropped. Then the next. Then he flicked a third at her sixth and knocked it, cleanly, out of its hollow and into the rushes.

A pot lid rattled on its pot and settled. Nobody breathed over it.

"That," said Neela, "is a foul."

"It's a rule. Hands want something else."

She stared at him. He was grinning. Not the corner of the mouth, not the slow dry thing she had learned to read. A real grin, wide and boyish and astonished at itself, as though it had been stored in a drawer for eight years and had come out creased.

She laughed. It came up before she could stop it, a rough peal, and she put her hand over her mouth, and then took it away and let it go.

The hall roared. Muthu banged the bench with both fists and bellowed that he had *seen* it, he had seen the warden *cheat*, and he wanted it written in the chronicle. Unni was crying with laughter. Janu thumped Devan on the shoulder with the ladle, hard, and he took it with his eyes shut, shaking. Behind them, Chinna's shrill voice called for the wager to be settled.

"Rapped," Janu declared. "Knuckles, both of you."

Neela held out her hand. Devan held out his. The ladle came down on each in turn with a flat wooden clack, like a shutter slat dropping.

Under the noise, across the board, he turned his hand over and showed her the red stripe across his knuckles. He did not say anything. Neela turned hers up beside it, the same stripe, a finger's width lower, and he looked from one to the other as if they had matched a lock.

She had never had this. Not once, in eleven contracts and twenty-seven years. A room full of people, and no one counting the exits.

She was still smiling when she looked down and saw her bangle shining in the lamplight, and thought of Ammu's cold hand.

*

Later, in the chamber, she sat on the chest with the shutters open on the dark.

He had gone down to see to the wall. She had said good night to a dozen people by name. Janu was Janu. Raiu was Raiu. Kannan, the goat-boy, had given her a pebble to keep, white as a tooth. She turned it in her fingers now.

The laugh was still in her chest like a coal. It was warm, and she did not trust it.

She did what she always did. She wrote it down in her head.

Today I told Ammu nobody has seen me. I have told her small lies before, to keep us out of trouble. This is the first I have told her to keep someone else safe.

It sat in the ledger of her mind in a neat, small hand. She looked at the line beneath it, the one she did not want to write.

Tonight I laughed in a hall with a man who has seen me. It was the first time I have ever laughed for nothing.

She read the two lines together, and did not strike out either.

She set the white pebble on the sill. Beside it stood the corked flask, where she had left it that morning. *Leave me a mark in the cup tomorrow night.* A mark meant the other one, out on the hill, with Ammu watch-

ing. It meant resin at dusk, and turning where Ammu's eyes could find her, and leaving behind the shutters he no longer touched and the sword he laid hilt-first on her side of the bed.

Sixteen nights. She laid her hand on the flask, and the glass was cold, and she sat there with her fingers closed round it until the cistern chain clanked.

Chapter 19

Resin on the Rampart

The split reed lay across the cup of the meeting stone at dawn, and Neela did not need a note to read it.

Show me.

In the Resin House a reed across the cup meant one thing. Not a report on paper, not a tale told over sweets. The work itself, done where the sender could watch. Ammu had waited three weeks at an inn for a woman who slept three nights human beside her mark. She was done being told.

So at sunset Neela stood on the east rampart with the flask open and the cork between her teeth.

Fifteen nights. The sun had gone behind the keep and left the wall in blue shade. Beyond the terraces the second spur climbed, higher than the rampart, to the pala grove, a dark line of trees against the last of the sky. Somewhere in that line, Ammu lay in wait.

Neela had watched the pairs all evening. They passed at the far corner and swung inward, and east of the cistern housing the wall made a low shoulder. There she would have thirty counts with no one to see her go over. She had checked it twice.

She tipped the flask. The resin was black and slow and smelled of scorched tamarind. She drew it across her throat with two fingers, then over the inside of each wrist, along the old ridged scars.

Sixty.

The count began the way it always did, without her choosing. Cold on her skin first. Then the faintest heat, like a lamp wick lit a long way off.

Fifty-six. A door scraped in the man-high stone housing beside her, and Devan stepped out with chain oil on his hands.

He saw the flask. He saw her wrists. He did not look surprised, which was somehow worse than if he had.

"The pair on this stretch are at the padippura," he said. "Bhaskaran has a cart he doesn't like. It will hold them until the next clank."

Fifty-one. "You arranged that."

"You watched the east wall all through supper. Twice you looked at the shoulder and your lips moved." He wiped his hands on a rag. "I'd rather be the man who made the gap than the man who found out how big it was."

She ought to have been angry. The skin of her throat was too busy for anger.

"And the cistern?"

"Gopan's chain jams in damp. I had the wheel apart, and that part is true." One corner of his mouth moved. "It's also a very good place to stand."

Forty-six. The heat had reached her wrists and begun to climb. She corked the flask with a hand that did not shake, and was proud of it.

"My sister wouldn't come up here after dusk," Devan said. He said it to the dark over her shoulder, easily, the way a man mentions weather. "Asha. She'd walk into a crowd of drunk soldiers with a stick and a joke, but she'd go the long way round by the lit court rather than cross a dark yard. She counted the steps on the stairs. Under her breath, all the way down. She said numbers kept the dark from filling in."

Neela said nothing. Forty-three.

"You do it too," he said.

"I don't."

"Your mouth moves. At the window, at table, on the stair to the hall. Fourteen steps, and you take the turn on the eleventh." He looked at her

then, not at the flask. "I noticed in the first week. I didn't say so, because I thought it was private."

"Forty," she said.

It was out of her mouth before she could stop it. He frowned.

"Forty what?"

"I'm counting down." Her voice came out dry, almost light, and she held on to that. "I smeared this before you came out. It takes about a minute. We're at forty."

His hands stopped. The rag hung from his fist. "Then you should be on the other side of that wall."

"Probably."

"What do you count?" he asked. "The rest of the time. I'd like to know."

It was the plainest question anyone had ever put to her. No bargain in it. No hook. She reached for the usual answer, the one she built for strangers, and found she had not made one for him.

Thirty-six.

"Exits," she said. "Steps. How many strides it takes a man to cross a room. How many breaths I've been holding." The heat had reached the corners of her jaw, and she swallowed. "Lately I count yours."

"Mine."

"It hitches. A third of the way through, when you're lying awake and pretending you aren't."

He was quiet for two of her counts. "I didn't know you counted it."

"I do."

"Thank you for telling me."

That was all. He didn't ask what she meant to do with the knowledge. He took it as he took the sword hilt, the kindness and the fact together, and left it where it lay.

She looked at him. She had been looking for weeks and had called it study. The faint stripe across his knuckles where Janu's ladle had landed. The oil under his nails. The set of his shoulders, braced for eight years

against a blow that never came, and tonight, in the blue light, not quite braced.

Thirty-one. Half a minute, near enough. Her bones would start soon, and if she stayed in reach the turning would begin against his chest. He had watched it from the bed and from the dark of the chamber more times than she had known to count. He had never watched it this close, with his hands on her.

Thirty. The grove. Ammu in the trees, who had laid a reed across a stone at dawn and gone to sit with a lifetime of rules in her head. *We're safe as long as nobody but us has seen.* Whatever Ammu saw tonight, she would carry home to Chathu with a face full of love.

Twenty-nine. His mouth. A good mouth, quiet and careful, and it held the one word that could close a door on her for good. A man lost in a kiss might say anything. He might say it with his eyes shut and mean only her name.

A mouth that is busy cannot say much. She thought it with the dry bitterness she kept for her own cleverness. It was also the most honest thing she had thought all week.

Three reasons, and the sum came out with no remainder. She wanted it anyway. No debt on the far side of it, no plan, no tin of sweets.

Twenty-eight. She did not go to him. She went the other way, two paces to the housing door, and stood in its lee, where the thick laterite flank and the low parapet shoulder met. She had judged it from the wall-walk, level with the housing, and from there it was a wall of stone. No watcher in the thorn would see a thing.

Then she crossed the three steps between them.

He stayed where he was. She put one hand flat on his chest and felt his heart going under the linen, fast and uneven, nothing like the calm he showed the world. His hand came up to her face and stopped a finger's width from her skin. Waiting. Asking in the only way he knew, without a word.

"Yes," she said, and kissed him.

His hand landed light, as if testing whether ice would hold. Then it held. He kissed her back with the same patient attention he gave everything, a kalari master learning a new form. He tasted of pepper tea and cold metal. His thumb found the pulse under her jaw, the one the resin had already begun to heat, and stayed there.

She stopped counting, and knew it only because the number came back like a slap. *Twenty. Nineteen.* His breath caught on the hitch, a third of the way through, in her mouth. She almost laughed.

Then the hitch was gone, and his breath ran ragged. His free hand fisted in the cloth at her back and dragged her an inch closer. Then he drew back a hand's breadth, and she knew that look, the look of a man about to be sensible. "Neela, the resin—"

She pulled him down again and he stopped being sensible.

Her wrists were burning now. The ache climbed her forearms like warm wire. His other hand closed on hers, on the scarred inner skin, and the touch should have been agony and was instead the opposite, a hand laid on a wound and not flinching from it. He knew what the ridges were. He did not pull away from them.

Twelve.

And then it came. The first burn, at the throat, a white line drawn tight across the skin as if someone had finally tightened a thread. It took the breath out of her.

Not here. Not in his hands.

She tore her mouth free and stepped back out of the circle of his arm. His hand was still open in the air where her face had been.

"Neela—"

She ran.

The east stair was a narrow flight cut into the thickness of the wall, ten paces along the rampart. She took it at a sprint, boots slapping stone, the burn moving down her spine like a hot nail. At the stair head she looked back, because she couldn't not.

Devan was exactly where she had left him, hands open at his sides. His boots were planted like the wall itself. He was breathing hard and looking straight at her, and he did not take a single step.

A man who wanted to catch a woman would have followed. A man who wanted to keep her would have caught her wrist. Devan had stayed where he was, as if his own feet were the lock on the door.

She could not tell whether that was the kindest thing done for her in years, or the coldest. She noted that she could not tell, and she went down into the dark.

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Four turns of stair. A niche at the second, where the wall made a shelf for a lamp that Gopan never lit. She tore the day cloth off her shoulders and shoved it in the niche with the flask on top, and the burn took her at the knees.

It was never gentle. The bones went first, a long grinding shift in the back and hips, then the skull drawing forward, then the teeth. The scars at her throat and wrists turned to bands of fire. She dropped to her hands on the cold step, and her hands stopped being hands, and the stair-dark that had been black went suddenly grey and sharp and full of smells.

Lamp oil. Wet laterite. Chain grease. Pepper tea, still faintly, from a mouth she had left behind.

The other one shook herself and stood.

She went up the stair on soft pads, and the rampart opened ahead of her in a new language of sound. Far off, the cistern chain turned its slow wheel. Above, on the spur, the pala grove breathed. On the walk, ten paces from the stair head, a man stood with his back turned to the stair.

Devan had faced the wall. Not the stair, not the dark where the cat would come from. He stood looking out over the terraces with his shoulders squared, and he did not look round when she passed behind him. His hands were flat on the parapet as if he were holding it down.

She went by his boots close enough to feel the warmth of him, and he did not say a word.

In the animal way that comes before thinking, she understood what the silence cost him.

The shoulder of the wall took her in two bounds, and she crouched on the stone.

The night came in whole. The terraces lay below, ranked in pale steps, and beyond them the spur rose to the trees. At the top of it, at the edge of the grove, where the thorn thickened, something sat very low and very still, and two eyes held the last of the light.

Green-gold. Round. Set close and unblinking, at the height of a dog sitting on its haunches.

A jackal's eyes.

They did not move. They did not turn to follow her up the wall, as a watcher's would, to catch the clean line of the leap. They stayed fixed on the housing door, ten paces back along the rampart, where a man stood alone with his hands on the stone and his mouth shut. Fixed on the spot where, not two hundred counts ago, there had been two people.

She saw her mistake from up here, as plainly as a slate wiped clean. She had judged the lee standing on the wall-walk, where the housing's flank was a wall. But the grove stood higher than the rampart, and Ammu had been looking down. The housing was only man-high, and the low parapet shoulder beside it hid nothing from above. A stone wall had only hidden her from herself.

Ammu had asked to be shown the work.

She had been shown the kiss.

The eyes held a long moment more. Then they went out, the way a lamp goes when a hand closes over it.

Chapter 20

The Name Given Back

Ammu was sitting in the cleft under the second spur with Neela's shawl folded in her lap.

Neela stopped at the mouth of it, naked and shaking, still tasting the hollow of the turn-back. First light had dragged her out of the other one's skin on a bare ledge of rock, and she had crawled the last stretch on her hands. Her thighs trembled. Her mouth tasted of ash.

"Sit," said Ammu. She held out the shawl. "Before you fall."

Neela took it, wrapped it, and sat. The cache cloth and the gourd were where she had left them. Ammu had touched nothing else. That was a message too.

"You followed my scent."

"I followed your—" Ammu stopped before the noun, as they all did, even by day. Her mouth twisted. "Your scent. Straight from the wall to here. You never even looked back." She did not smile. "I was in the grove, chechi. All night. I watched the east wall."

Neela caught the swerve and said nothing about it. "Then you watched me work."

"I watched you kiss the mark."

It was not an accusation. Neela had braced for one and it did not come. Ammu's voice was low and unsteady, and her hands, which were never still, lay clenched on her knees.

"I told myself I was seeing wrong," Ammu said. "The light was bad. But I know your back. I know how you stand when you want something, with your weight on the toes. You've stood like that once in your life." She swallowed. "You put your hand on his chest. You didn't use it to find a rib."

"It was a way in. He's careful. A man who's kissing—"

"Don't." Ammu said it gently. "Don't do the blade thing with me. I'm not Chathu."

Neela shut her mouth.

"A mouth is where the word lives," Ammu said. "Whatever else he is, a husband has a mouth. You know what the House does with a girl who loves her mark? It doesn't beat her. It waits. It lets her get fond. Then it sells what she's fond of back to her, one piece at a time." Her eyes were bright and furious. "I saw Kirri get fond of Chathu. I'm not watching it again."

"It isn't that."

"Does he know what you are?"

Neela weighed the question like a coin she could not afford. If Ammu learned that Devan had watched her turn, Ammu's own rule would take over: *safe as long as nobody but us has seen*. A witness she could not unsee was a page she had to write. And Chathu had other eyes on this hill. They would not forgive a sister who sat on it. The truth would not cost Neela alone.

So it was a first lie, and she told it tired and smooth.

"He thinks I'm a bride who sleeps badly and walks at night."

Ammu's eyes narrowed. "He didn't turn round, chechi. I watched that too. You went past his boots, close enough to touch, and he stood there like a post."

That one Neela had not been ready for. She built the second lie as she spoke, out of what Ammu could have seen from the trees. "He heard something go by behind him. He didn't turn. He said, 'Go on, then,' into the dark, the way you do. You were too far up to hear it." She made

herself shrug. "The fort tom walks that wall every night. Half the garrison feeds it."

Ammu looked at Neela's hands. They were wrapped in the shawl and quite still. Then she looked at her face.

"He didn't even turn his head?"

"Why would he? It's a cat on a wall."

Ammu searched her for a long moment. Neela let her, and kept her eyes steady, and hated how easy it was. At the end of it Ammu let out a breath, and the clenched hands loosened, and the relief in her face was so plain that it hurt to watch. She wanted it to be true, and she chose it. She took the lie the way a cold child takes a blanket, and did not look at its seams.

"All right," she said. "All right. Then there's time."

"How much?"

"One week." Ammu held up a finger, shaking. "I write nothing for one more week. Not what I saw on the rampart, not the three bare nights, nothing. If Chathu hears it from his other eyes first, he'll know I sat on it. So a week. In a week you either have a plan that ends in a body, or I write what I saw and you tell me I'm wrong, and I'll be so glad to be wrong."

"A week."

"Don't thank me."

"I wasn't going to."

That got a short, cracked laugh. Ammu pulled her knees up and began to hum, under her breath, and it was not the fishing song. It was slower, a heavy, rocking tune that Neela half knew from the tapping sheds, the kind the old men sang to keep the knife in time. Ammu's voice slipped into words without her seeming to notice:

Tap the bark when the sun goes low, let the black sap run and the lantern burn slow. What the dusk has taken, the dusk will say, the name given back at the closing of day.

She stopped. Her face went blank, like a girl who has stepped on a stair that was not there.

"I never heard that last verse," Neela said.

"You were always counting, not listening."

"What does it mean? Given back how?"

"It's a song." Ammu rubbed her nose with the back of her wrist. "The tappers made them up to stay awake. They don't mean anything. Half of them are about goats."

"Ammu."

"It's only a song, chechi." She stood and brushed the dust from her blue cotton. Her eyes went to the sky, to the sun clearing the ridge, and her voice went quick and bright and wrong. "You'll want to hear the real news. I didn't come here to sing."

Neela waited. She had learned a long time ago that the way to hear a thing was to let someone avoid it for a little while first.

"Chathu's sent word again." Ammu's mouth thinned. "It came in with the last cart, while you were out. If the account is still open at the new moon, he sends Vellan."

The cold went through Neela slowly, from the cleft floor up.

"Vellan."

"Nine nights. Chathu says it's not a punishment, only a kindness, so the work gets done before the pass shuts and you don't have to spend the winter under his roof explaining yourself. He says it like he's offering you a seat." Ammu's hands twisted in her cloth. "Vellan doesn't come to talk, chechi."

Vellan, who carved small wooden birds for the youngest girls and left them on their sleeping mats. Vellan, who had stood over two children in the yard, big as a hut, and let them live.

"I know what he comes for," Neela said.

"Then do it," Ammu said, very low. "Or do something. Anything. Just don't let him find you stalling." She leaned down quickly and kissed Neela on the forehead, which she had not done since they were girls. "I'll leave an unsplit reed in the cup on the seventh night. If it's there, I've kept my word."

She went out into the morning and did not hum again.

Neela sat with the shawl round her and counted the ridges in the cleft wall. Nine. She counted them again and got nine.

Nine nights to the new moon. A week of grace. A reprieve bought with two lies, and Ammu's face, relieved and trusting her. And a bear walking toward the dark of the month.

She looked at her shaking hands, and then she began to dress.

*

By dusk she had worked out three ways to say it, and discarded all of them.

The chamber was dim. Neela had closed the shutters herself before the light went, slat by slat, with the third one creaking as always. The corridor lamp outside was unlit. The fort was settling toward night in small sounds: the chain, a dog, Janu's voice scolding someone in the court below.

Devan had said only, at the evening meal, in front of Janu, "You didn't eat," and had put a plate of rice and fried pepper in front of her without asking. Now he stood by the bed, undoing his sword belt, and she saw him decide to wait for her to speak.

She had the flask in her hand. She had not opened it.

"I want you to promise me something," she said.

He laid the belt down. "If I can."

"Never to say it." The rasp of her own voice surprised her. "Not in anger. Not drunk. Not in sleep. You say you won't, and I believe you mean it. I want you to promise it. Never."

He looked at her for a long time. In the dim, his face was hard to read, but she had learned to read his hands, and they were very still.

"No," he said.

Her chest went tight. "No."

"I won't promise that." He came a step nearer, and he spoke slowly, because he was saying something he had clearly turned over many times. "If I promise never, and I mean it with all I have, I'm still promising what I can't hold. A fever doesn't ask. I said *cat* a hundred times, Janu

told me, while I was out of my head, and the only thing I've been grateful for in eight years is that was the word I had." He drew a breath. "Sleep doesn't ask either. I can promise to try. I can promise I'll never say it awake. But you'd be hearing a promise that breaks the first night I'm ill, and you'd hear it in the dark."

"That's the point of a promise."

"No. The point is that you can lean on it." His jaw worked. "I'd rather give you something that holds."

She felt the old cold in her chest, the shape of every kindly voice that had said *trust me* with a debt behind it. She waited for the bargain.

It didn't come. Instead he put his hand in the pouch at his belt and drew out something small, and held it out in his open palm.

A river pebble. Smooth, grey-brown, no bigger than a plum stone.

"Gopan taught me this when I was sixteen," he said. "On the cistern wheel, the winter watch. Forty nights awake on a post with nothing to do, and old men talk in their sleep standing up. The old watchmen hold a stone in the cheek." He tucked it behind his molars, between tooth and cheek, and spoke around it. "Like thish."

It came out a soft, wet smear of sound. She heard the shape of words in it and no word at all.

She stared. "Say it. Properly."

"Can't." Another smear. He took the stone out and set it on his palm. "A man can mumble round a stone. He can hum. He can't make a clean word that anyone could mistake for one. Not asleep, not in a fever. Gopan tested it on me with a bucket of cold water." One corner of his mouth lifted, and went. "It's no promise. It's a plug in the mouth. But it's a thing that holds whether I'm brave or not."

"Every night?"

"Every night you smear." He said it flatly, as he said facts. "From tonight. I'll sleep badly with it. It'll go in at dusk and out at first light, when you're back. I'd sooner choke on a stone than on that word."

She had a white pebble of her own, in the pocket of her day cloth, a gift from a goat-boy. She dug it out. It was a little rounder than his and a lot whiter, and she held it up between two fingers.

"Try mine."

"Kannan's?"

"It's cleaner."

He laid his grey stone on the sill, took hers, wiped it on his sleeve with ridiculous gravity, and put it in his cheek. Then he looked at her, grim as a judge, and said, "Cashh."

She laughed.

It burst out of her before she knew it was coming, the same rough peal as in the hall, and she bent over the flask with her free hand on her knee. He raised his eyebrows at her, bulging one cheek like a boy hiding sweets, and said something that might have been *Cat* or might have been *Ought* or might have been the name of a goat.

"Stop," she said. "Stop, I'll drop it."

He took the stone out. His eyes were laughing, and his mouth was not, and then both were quiet.

And so was she. The laugh stopped in her all at once, like the cistern chain caught mid-clank.

She stood in the near dark with a stopped flask in her hand and a man in front of her holding a damp white pebble on his palm.

Eleven years the word had hung round her neck, hers to carry and hide. Chathu held it as a leash. Ammu held it as a silence too dangerous to break. Everyone else's mouth was only the place it could fall from.

No one had ever said, *This is mine.*

"Neela," he said quietly.

"I'm all right."

"You've gone white."

"I'm all right." She had to say it a second time. "It's stupid. I'd just never thought of it as something you could carry."

"It's heavy enough," he said. "I'd rather carry my share."

He did not ask her to say what that meant. He only held the white pebble out to her, and waited.

She took it. It was warm and wet against her palm.

"About the rampart," he said.

She went still.

"I stood where I was because you ran. Not because I didn't want to follow." He said it to her face, plainly, as he said everything. "I won't ask for it again at dusk, with resin on you and a word in my mouth. When you want it, you'll find me. In daylight, if you like."

"In daylight."

"I'm told it's allowed."

Outside, the cistern chain clanked once. The slats of the shutter glowed a last dull orange and went dark.

She crossed to the sill and set the flask down on his side of it, next to the grey stone, close enough that his hand could reach it as easily as hers. Then she uncorked it. The resin smelled, as always, of scorched tamarind. She drew it across her throat and her wrists.

Before the first heat came, she took his hand, turned it palm up, and pressed the white pebble into it. "Keep Kannan's. It's the clean one."

He closed his fingers over it. He put it behind his teeth, and sat on the floor with his back against the bed, facing the door.

Fifty-nine, she counted, and the burn began. *The name given back at the closing of day.*

Chapter 21

The Captain at Twenty-Four

"Why won't you spar?"

Neela asked it without looking up, the way another woman might ask about the price of thread.

Rain had shut Kettamala since before dawn. It came down the red walls in sheets and filled the kalari pit to the knee, and Devan had taken refuge in the tack room beside it, where the thatch leaked in two places and he had set a bucket under each. He was restringing a bow. Neela had come down the east path under a sack, with a pot of tea and no explanation, and sat on an upturned feed bin as if she had always sat there.

Muthu had left a quarter-hour ago, streaming water, laughing. He had asked for his round on the seventh day, as he had every seventh day for eight years, and Devan had said no, as he had every time. Neela had watched the whole exchange over the rim of her cup.

"I'm not going to answer that yet," Devan said.

"Then we need a rule." She set the cup down. "A question for a question. You ask, I answer. I ask, you answer. Either of us can say *I won't answer* once, and the other lets it lie."

"Once a day?"

"Once. Total."

He tested the string against his thumb. He had spent half his life refusing to be asked things, and he found he was curious what it felt like to be asked by someone who offered to pay.

"Start small," he said. "Then I'll know what the price is."

She considered. "Ask."

"What did they feed you at the Resin House?"

Her mouth twitched. "Boiled millet. Dried fish on feast days. Before a contract, a tin of jaggery-sesame sweets, still warm." The twitch went flat. "I don't eat them now."

"Mine," she said. "Who fills the kindi?"

"I do."

"Every night?"

"Since the second week. Spout toward the pillow, because you reach for it left-handed in the dark." He said it to the bow. "You thought it was Janu's girls."

"I did."

"They'd have put it on my side."

She said nothing for a moment. The rain drummed on the thatch, and a drip landed in the left bucket with a sound like a coin.

"That's two," she said. "Ask."

He asked what she had been afraid of at the House, as a child. She said the kennels, and a big man's shadow in the yard, and being the last one picked for anything. She said it fast and bare, a list.

Her questions came sharper. Which of Janu's stories had made him ask her to stop? He told her: *the one about the man-eater of the pass that left a man's sandals on the road.* Which scar was the oldest? Whether he slept.

"Badly," he said. "Eight years."

"Since Asha."

"Before Asha." He ran the string through his fingers. "Since the ford."

She let that lie. It was his turn, and he had been wanting to ask one thing since the first week.

"Why do you take the turn on the eleventh step?"

She had been reaching for her cup. Her hand stopped.

"The stair to the hall," he said. "Fourteen steps. You're light on ten, and on the eleventh your whole body turns, as if you'd heard something there. Every time."

"I don't know."

"You don't—"

"I don't know." Her lips moved, a small shaped count with no sound in it, and her thumbnail dragged along the edge of her forefinger nail, back and forth. "It bothers me. I've tried to stop and I can't. My feet do it." She saw him looking at her hands and put them in her lap. "That isn't a refusal. I've still got my one."

He thought of Asha, and let the thought go, since it was not hers. He nodded and went back to the bow. She breathed out, and he understood that he had been given something and had been wise enough not to pick it up.

She looked up at him then. She did not ask what the ford was. She set her cup on the bin, and he knew the next question was coming before she opened her mouth.

"Why won't you spar? Not *can't.* You could break any man in this fort. Muthu asks every seventh day and you look at him as if he'd offered you poison."

It was the cheapest-looking question of the afternoon. He had known since the first minute that it was the one she had come down the hill to ask.

He could say *I won't answer that.* She had given him the right, and she would keep her word. He laid the bow across his knees.

"I was twenty-four," he said. "Eight years ago, in spring. We took a raider captain at the lower ford after a village burned. Twelve dead, and children among them. He fought like a bull until Muthu opened his arm, and then he dropped his sword and knelt in the mud and put up his hands."

Neela did not move.

"That is the law. A man who yields is a prisoner. I'd taught it to every recruit in the fort. I was standing over him with a bleeding hand, and he

looked up and spat on my boot. Then he said what he'd done in that village, in detail, in a pleasant voice." Devan turned the bow in his hands. "I put two fingers to the notch below his ear. A marma point. Done right, it stops the heart in the time it takes to say a short word. I knew where it was. I'd been taught what it was for."

The rain went on.

"He was dead before he finished falling. Muthu was ten paces off and saw all of it. Nobody said anything. The captain was in the wrong, and I was in the wrong, and the village was still burned." He kept his voice level, a report. "I haven't struck a living person since. Not in practice, not in anger. I drill alone. If I held a sword against Muthu, I'd know exactly where my hand wanted to go."

He waited for the words he had heard from Janu and from his own head. *You were provoked. Anyone would have.*

Neela said, "He was on his knees with his hands up. You hit the point under his ear with two fingers and you killed him. He had surrendered and you had the right to hold him, and you chose the strike."

It was exactly what he had done. Hearing it said plain was like stepping into the cold pit water.

"And then you stopped," she said. "You didn't do it twice. You didn't do it to the next man who made you angry, or the one after that. You've had that hand and that rage, and every day since, you've stopped." She tilted her head. "I'm not saying it makes it smaller. I'm saying I see both. He's dead and you stopped. Neither cancels the other."

Devan found his eyes were stinging, and he was irritated, and then he was not. Nobody had forgiven him, because he had not let anyone get near enough. Janu had tried. Muthu had tried with jokes. They had all wanted to lift the weight off. This woman had looked at it, named each part of it correctly, and left it exactly where it lay.

He picked the bow up off his knees. He found the loose end of the string he had abandoned and began to wind it, round and round the nock, and his hands were steady again.

"That's the first time anyone has said it that way," he said.

"It's the only way it's true."

He nodded. His throat was not quite his own.

"My turn," she said, "and I'll give you one before you ask. You think it's the hand you don't trust."

"Yes."

"It isn't." She spoke gently, which was worse. "A man who didn't trust his hand would spar with a padded stick and find out. You won't touch anyone, because you're afraid of what you'd learn. That it isn't about the hand at all. It's about wanting to."

He should have been angry. He sat very still and let it be true.

"That's an answer, not a question," he said.

"Then here's the rest, and it's not a question either." She wrapped her hands round the cup. "I count the doors in every room I sleep in. Twenty-one years. I've never once been asked why."

Nothing came to him. He thought of a man who lay down each night with his back to a wall and his sword on the floor, every door in the fort watched. He thought of her at the foot of a stair, counting. Neither of them said what the two had in common, and he saw that she had not expected him to.

He drew the knot tight and did not bargain over it. "What do they call you? At the House. Not the cover. Not the Chirayil ward."

"Nothing."

"You don't have to—"

"I'm not refusing. I mean nothing." She turned the cup in her fingers. "I'm Seventeen. The seventeenth girl in the House's book. I answered to it for twenty-one years, the way a goat answers to a whistle. There was a name before that. I was six when they took me, and I lost it somewhere on the road. Chathu has it in a ledger, I think. He's never offered."

Seventeen. He turned the number over and found that it sat in his chest like a stone he had swallowed.

"So I learned everyone else's," she said, and shrugged. "It's a bad habit in my trade. A woman who wants to disappear should leave every servant

a stranger. But I kept finding out. Raiu's mother is dead. Chinna's got a bad hip. Kannan's goat is called Pepper and bites. Unni's mother sells salt fish." Her shoulder did not quite make it up. "Somebody should know them. Nobody ever knew me."

He had watched her do it since the first week. He had watched her say *Raiu* to the boy at the stair-head and see him straighten. He had taken it for craft, a spy's easy charm. She was collecting names for people the way other women kept birds, and every name was a thing she had never been given.

"Neela," he said.

She went quiet.

"That's yours," he said. "I know it's the cover's. I've said it every day since the wedding, and it's the one I'd answer to if it were mine." He stopped. "I'm saying it badly."

"You're saying it fine." Her voice was not steady. She picked up the pot and poured tea nobody had asked for. "Don't do that again until I've finished this."

He didn't. They drank in the sound of the rain.

*

She did not take the resin that night.

She said so at dusk, in the dim of the chamber, with the flask stoppered and standing in the niche where it lived. "There's nothing to hunt in this, and the scent's washed off the hill. I'd just be wet." Then, more quietly, to the flask: "Another bare night. It goes on the count."

Her nails had been itching all afternoon. He had seen her pressing them against her thumb. He said nothing about that, and she gave him a look that thanked him for it. He kept a tally of her bare nights, as she kept her steps, without ever having decided to, and he knew what a full moon of them would do to her hands.

He kept the pebble in its pouch. Tonight, for once, he would not need the stone.

She slept first. She slept the way she did everything, by the numbers, flat on her back with one hand over her breastbone. He lay beside her and listened to his own breath hitch and to the cistern chain striking the third watch. The rain had thinned to a whisper on the slats.

Past the middle watch she woke. He knew it by the change in her breathing. She did not move, except that her right hand came up and pressed her nails hard against her thumb, one after another, as if testing them for cracks.

"Eight," she said, to the dark. Flat, a sum. "Eight nights to the new moon."

He did not know what ended on the eighth night. He knew that she did, and that she had said it to the ceiling and not to him.

The question was there at once, whole. *What happens then?* He could ask it. She was awake, he had asked her harder things that day, and the right to refuse was already spent on neither side. He lay with it behind his teeth. She had not offered it, and a thing taken from her in the dark was the leash she feared. He would hold it through the night, and through whatever came of tomorrow, and spend it only if she turned to him first.

It cost him. He felt every breath of it.

Presently her hand fell back to her chest, and she slept again.

Later, much later, she began to count something else.

It was barely sound. Her lips shaped it more than her voice did. "Four. Five." A pause, a catch. "Six."

He turned his head on the pillow, slowly, and did not breathe.

"Seven. Eight." The cadence was careful, a step and a step, a child going down into water. Her hand had slid off her chest and lay open on the sheet, the fingers curling. "Nine. Ten."

She stopped.

He heard her swallow. Then a small sound came out of her, high and wet, a sound he had heard once from a hound that had come home across the ford with a broken leg. Her brow pulled together.

"Don't," she whispered. "It's broken."

Her fingers closed in the sheet. A tremor went down her whole arm.

"It's *broken*."

Devan held still. Every part of him wanted to reach for her, and he did not. A woman waking in a dream is a woman who does not know where she is, and he had no notion whether the hand that touched her would be his own in her mind. He thought of the Resin House. Of kennels, and the big man's shadow in the yard she had listed so fast, and a tin of warm sweets with a bill inside. Whatever was broken in there, the guild had done the breaking. Some stair in that yard, some girl's bone. She would have grown up counting steps toward the place where the bad thing waited.

After a time her breath came back down to a slow measure, and her fingers eased open. She did not say the number again.

He lay awake and watched the dark ceiling, and the thing he had refused to look at for eight years came up out of him and stood in the room.

Asha had counted stairs. She had said numbers kept the dark from filling in. Since the day she died he had gone to sleep every night with his back to the wall and his sword on the floor, every door in the fort watched and nobody at his shoulder. Six years of wall, laid over the two before it, over the ford. He had told himself that was strength. It was only the shape the grief had taken.

And she lay a hand's breadth away, who had counted at the bottom of the same dark. She had been paid to put a knife in him. She had pulled the strike in the pit, and killed for him in the narrows, and told him to his face what he was afraid of. She had done it with her eyes wide open, as if she had measured the whole of him and found him worth the telling.

He did not want a wall at his back. He wanted her there. He wanted her where he could hear her counting, near enough to hear her break, near enough to be told when he was wrong.

It frightened him more than the captain's spit ever had.

Beside him, very softly, Neela turned her face into the pillow and said a number he could not make out. He lay and listened, and he wondered what stair she was on, and who had broken it.

Chapter 22

A Night Without Resin

At dusk Neela opened the shutters herself.

The third slat creaked, as it always did. She let it. The west lay open below the sill, laterite red going to brown, the pepper terraces stepping down into shadow, the sun a hand's width above the ridge. The flask sat stoppered in its niche. She had not touched it all day.

Two nights without. The ache would count them both, the way Chathu counted every debt, and send the bill at the end of the moon.

Seven nights to the new moon. And on the second spur, in the grove, stood a split slab of laterite with a cup cut in its top. Ammu had promised to read that stone every night of her week of silence. The other one's scent-mark in the cup meant *still working*. An empty cup meant a woman who had stopped, or been stopped. Tonight the cup would be empty, and Ammu would stand in the dusk and wonder which of the bad answers was true.

Neela looked up at the spur. The grove sat higher than the fort. She had worked that out on the rampart, with her mouth still warm from his, and it was still true: anyone under those pala trees could look down into this room. A lit window would be a lamp on a hill.

She knew exactly what it would cost. She had hidden for twenty-one years, and for once she wanted to be seen on purpose. She leaned on the sill and left the shutters wide.

The door opened behind her. She knew his step: heavy heel, then the pause where he checked the corridor. The pause came. Then it didn't finish.

"The shutters are open," Devan said.

"Yes."

"You haven't—"

"No resin." She did not turn. "Not tonight."

He came to stand a pace behind her. He did not touch her. The light lay red across the floor between them, and she heard him take the white pebble from his pouch and set it on the shelf by the door, softly, like a man putting down a tool he would not need.

"Why?" he said. Then, because he was who he was: "I'm not refusing it. I'd like to understand it."

"A question for a question."

"Ask."

She turned round. "Do you want to be here? Not guard, not warden. Here, in this room, with a woman who can't turn into anything tonight."

"Yes." No pause. His ears had gone dark. "That one was easy."

"Then here is mine. I want one night when the only thing in this bed is a woman." Her voice was steadier than her hands. "I want to be looked at by lamplight and not run."

He lit the lamp himself. A little sesame oil, a wick, the flame leaning in the draught from the open window. He set it on the chest so that it lit her and not him, which was thoughtful, and a mistake. She crossed the floor and moved it to the shelf between them.

"Both of us," she said.

He nodded. Neither of them knew what to do with their hands.

She was twenty-seven and had spent twenty-one of those years answering to a number. He was thirty-two, a warden who had not let anyone this close since the ford, eight years gone. Neither had ever stood in lamplight and let the other look.

She unwound her day cloth slowly, because if she went fast she would stop.

The scars were the first thing the light found. Pale ridges across the throat, two bands on each inner wrist, raised and shiny where the resin had eaten. He had seen them in the dark, she knew, and in the grey before dawn. He had never been given them to look at.

He looked. He did not flinch and he did not soften his face into pity. She had to look at the lamp for a moment.

"I'd like to touch them," he said. "I'm asking. You can say no and I'll still be glad of tonight."

"Which?"

"Whichever you'll give."

"Wrists," she said. "First. With your thumb. Nothing tight." She held out her right arm, palm up. "No one holds my wrists. Not once. Not even for play."

"No one will."

He took her hand as if it were something that could spill. His thumb came down on the inner ridge and traced it, the length of the band. His hands knew every pressure point on a body; she had watched him in the pit, and she knew what that thumb could do. She watched him choose, deliberately and visibly, to know none of it.

"Does it hurt still?" he asked.

"Not since the first year. Chathu held my wrist the first time. He said it would hurt less if I didn't pull." Her voice was dry. "It hurt exactly as much."

"A question," he said. "Why tell me?"

"Because you asked what the scars were, in the second week, and I said a fall from a cart." She held his eyes. "That was a lie. I'm tired of that one."

He lifted her wrist and put his mouth to the inside of it, to the worst of the ridges, so lightly that she only knew it by the warmth. Her whole arm tightened to the shoulder.

"Throat?" he said, against her skin.

"Last."

"Last, then."

She took his hand in both of hers and put it where she wanted it, flat against her ribs, and felt him breathe out. Then she unwound his mundu, because she wanted to see how he held still when she was the one deciding. He held still beautifully. He had a soldier's body, scarred along the left forearm, a puckered white seam at the ribs, the long muscle of a man who drilled alone before dawn every day for eight years. She put her palm against his chest and found his heart going hard.

"You're nervous," she said.

"I haven't done this since before the ford."

"Eight years."

"I'm out of practice." He said it gravely, and she laughed, and he smiled, and some of the stiffness went out of both of them.

They went to the bed, and it was not graceful. His knee hit the frame. She had to move his sword, which lay on the floor on her side, hilt toward her as every night, and she slid it under the bed with her foot. "You can have it back after," she said, and he said, "I won't want it."

He was careful with her, almost too careful. When his thumb found the wrist ridge again he stopped on it and stayed, motionless, until she nodded. At every step he waited for her answer, and she understood that the waiting was not doubt. It was a man who had spent years learning what restraint was for, and had finally been handed a use for it.

"You can stop asking," she said at last, breathless, her back against the pillows. "Ask me with your hands. I'll tell you if it's wrong."

He took her at her word. His mouth moved down over her collarbone, her breast, the soft place under her ribs, and when his hand slid between her thighs, slowly, she put hers over it and showed him the pressure, the pace, the angle that made her catch her breath. He learned it like a drill. He did not drop a single detail. When he said her name against her skin, the cover's name, which was hers now by use, something low in her gave at the sound of it.

"There," she said. "Don't change anything."

"I won't."

She came with her fist in the sheet and her heels dug into the mattress, quietly, in the end, with a low cry that surprised her. Her sight cleared slowly. He was watching her face as if he were holding something he had not expected to be given, and she pulled him up by the shoulders.

"Now you," she said.

"You don't have to."

"Devan."

He came over her on his forearms and she guided him in, her hand on his hip, the angle hers. He went slowly. She felt the effort in him, the shaking just under the skin. She wrapped a leg round him and said, "More," and he said it was her choice, and she said that was exactly what she was making. He moved, and she moved with him, and the lamp threw their shadows huge on the wall, two bodies with nothing hidden in them.

His rhythm broke before hers, and he put his face into her neck, a hand's width from the scarred place, and stopped there, not touching it. His breath warmed the ridges.

"Now," she said. "Please."

His mouth closed over the pale band at her throat, gently, and a long shudder went through her from scalp to heel. No one had ever been allowed to put anything there but resin. He kissed the scars one by one, as if reading a line he had to get right. She broke a second time with her hand tangled in his hair, and he followed her with her name in his mouth, and the shutters were open the whole time and nothing in the dark moved.

*

Afterwards he lay with his head on her shoulder and she traced the seam at his ribs.

"Ford?" she asked.

"The captain's knife. Before he knelt." His voice was slow. "A question. What's the count tonight?"

She smiled at the ceiling. "Two nights. The ache will want its due."

"Then I owe it."

"It's mine to pay."

"Not alone."

She did not answer that. She said, in a voice she barely knew, "Stay till morning."

He lifted his head. He knew what it asked. A man had never stayed while she was awake and unguarded, and she had never asked one to. "Neela—"

"Please. I want to wake up here."

"I'll be here," he said.

He pulled the sheet over them both and did not put the stone in his mouth.

She woke once in the dark. The lamp had burned out. The shutters still stood open, and a cool wet wind moved across the sill, smelling of rain and laterite. Devan lay turned toward her, one hand open on the sheet between them, palm up, as if waiting. His breath hitched on its long count, the little catch a third of the way through, and she lay and listened to it.

Her nails ached at the quick, a dull, small warning.

Two, she thought. *Two nights.* She added the second one to the tally in her head and found she did not mind the sum. She laid her hand in his open one and slept.

*

An hour after first light she went up the second spur alone, in her day kasavu with the shawl over it, and found Ammu sitting by the stone with her back to the slab and her arms round her knees.

Ammu was naked and grey and shaking. The turn-back had taken her at first light, and she had not moved since. Her hands were scraped raw, and burrs and red dust clung in her hair. Neela dropped the shawl over her shoulders.

In the cup of the stone, thick and fresh, lay a jackal's scent-mark. Ammu's own, laid in the dark and left to say *I came, and I looked.*

"You came," Ammu said. Her voice cracked on it. "I thought you'd got yourself killed."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Be clever." But her grin was thin and bright. Neela sat down beside her, pulled a rice cake from her sleeve, and put it into Ammu's scraped hand. Ammu ate it in four bites. The hollow after a turning was the same for every one of them.

"Tell me," Neela said.

"Well." Ammu licked her thumb. "The watcher in the pass village doesn't count faces, chechi. He logs scent-posts. Every dawn he walks the hill edge and reads which of your marks have gone fresh in the night. No fresh marks, no one out on your account. A refusal. And a refusal gets written to Chathu."

"The rain night," Neela said.

"Already went down as a gap. Your three bare nights last week went down too. And the writ's landed, so every gap counts double now." Ammu tipped her head. "Another run of gaps on top of the rain night is the one he'd act on. So I ran yours."

"Yours is the stone."

"Mine is the stone. And then I ran yours: the east wall, the terraces, the sentry's walk." Her smile was shaky. "I took the day cloth from your cache under the spur, in my teeth, and rubbed it on every post you touch. Your own scent, laid fresh. He'd read it as you." She winced. "It works once, chechi. The cloth's rags now, and the cache is empty. Don't count on it twice."

"Ammu."

"I know. I was right under the rampart when the guard changed, with the wind wrong, and a boy with a lantern nearly trod on my tail." She leaned her head on Neela's shoulder. "It was reckless. I'm good at reckless. You always said so." The hum started, small and absent, the fishing

song. She stopped it herself. “The shutters were open. I saw from the grove. A lamp, and two people behind it, and nobody on the ledge.”

“I know,” Neela said. “I knew it would be seen.”

“I know you knew.” Ammu said it without heat. “I’m not going to say anything about that, today. I’ll be too hungry.”

Neela said nothing. The lie she had told at the cache, three dawns ago, lay between them, warm and wrong.

“I got you something,” Ammu said. She reached under the shawl, to her waistband, and drew out a folded scrap of paper gone soft with sweat. “I shouldn’t. It came up with the last cart. Chathu sends the carrier a balance sheet for every open contract so the man knows who to dun. I tore the strip clean off the foot of it, out of his satchel.” She held it out and did not let go at once. “The carrier will blame damp, or rats. Chathu will too. Until somebody moves on whatever’s written there. Then he’ll ask who read that line, and only one jackal was ever near that satchel.”

Neela unfolded it. Chathu’s neat hand, resin-ink, tidy as a ledger:

Balance due from the Keeper on the widow’s seal.

Nothing else. Not a name. She read it twice, and the cold came up through the soles of her feet.

The widow’s seal. The charter line. If the warden of Kettamala died married, his wife held the pass-seal in trust until the council named another. Chathu’s plans had made her that widow before she ever climbed the hill. The balance was due from the man who would come to take the seal from her hand.

Not the council. Not the queen. *The Keeper.*

The Keeper of the Passes. The office that held one of the three dot-and-split seal boxes. The office that sent the kind letter every season for six years and never once climbed the hill.

“Chechi?” Ammu said. “You’ve gone the colour of ash.”

“It’s nothing.”

“It’s not nothing. It’s the first time you’ve ever lied to me badly.”

Neela folded the slip along its creases and put it inside her bodice, against her skin.

Ittan. The name came up in her like a bell. Genial Ittan, my friend, the man whose letter had asked so warmly after the warden's bride.

Below the spur Kettamala stood red in the early sun, and in the warden's window, a small dark square, the shutters were still open. Somebody was in the pit under the east wall, drilling alone. She knew the shape of him at that distance, and the way he stopped in the middle of a form and glanced up at the hill.

She traced it through, step by step, as she would a route. Alone, the slip was nothing: a torn foot, blamed on rats. But Devan would not sit on a name. The day he moved on Ittan, the rats would stop being the answer. Chathu would hold the sheet up to the light and ask who had known that line. The carrier's satchel would lead to the one who had reached into it.

So the name was Devan's only chance, and giving it might be Ammu's cage.

Ammu was watching her, fierce and starving. Neela put the second rice cake into her fingers and said nothing at all.

Chapter 23

The Keeper's Name

By the time the sun cleared the east wall, Devan had run the long form eleven times and still could not make his hands stop.

Last night was in them. Her wrist under his thumb, the ridges at her throat, her fist in the sheet. When the form ended the eleventh time, he stood in the red earth with his chest heaving and the lamps burning pale in their niches, and heard a step on the stairs cut into the north side.

He knew it. Light, even, taking the third stair a fraction short, as if shortening a stride could make her smaller.

Neela came down into the pit in her day kasavu with a shawl over it. There was red dust on the hem and a burr caught in the border. She had been up the hill. Her face was set the way it was when she was counting something.

"You've been at it since the dark," she said.

"Yes."

"The hands wouldn't stop."

"No."

She nodded, as though that were a reasonable answer. Then she put her hand into her bodice and drew out a small, soft, creased slip of paper.

She did not hold it out at once. She looked at it, and then at him. In a month he had learned to read the order of her decisions. She chose, and then she checked that the choice was still hers.

"You said you wouldn't ask," she said.

"I won't."

"I know. That's why." She crossed the earth between them and put the paper into his hand. Her fingers were cold. "Ittan. Councillor Ittan, the Keeper of the Passes. He bought the contract. He is the man who wants you dead."

Devan did not look down at the slip. His eyes stayed on her.

She had said it flat, the way she said sums. But her eyes were wide and a little wild, the eyes of a woman who has just stepped off a wall and not yet landed.

"I didn't buy it," he said. It came out stupid and he knew it.

"No. You didn't ask, either. I'm not trading, Devan. I'm owed nothing for this." She wrapped her arms round herself. "I just don't want you to die of a man I could have named."

Once, in a wet dawn, he had offered her his silence for this name, and she had refused it. He had never expected the name to follow him into the pit, unasked, in her hand.

"Thank you," he said. It was too small.

"Read it."

The slip opened under his thumb. A neat hand in black ink, tidy as an accounts book. *Balance due from the Keeper on the widow's seal.*

"Where did you get this?"

"A guild-sister tore it off a carrier's satchel. It's Chathu's hand. I won't say more about her." She said it quickly, then lowered her voice. "I'm sorry. That's the one thing I can't give you."

"I haven't asked."

"I know you haven't." Her mouth tilted. "It's very annoying."

He looked at the paper again, and the fort he had been raised in shifted under him.

The widow's seal. The old charter line, the one the marriage writ had returned to him in plain words. If the warden of Kettamala died married, his wife held the pass-seal in trust until the council named a new

man. No warden in living memory had married in office. Someone had read that line and seen what it was worth.

Someone had *sent* him a wife.

The pieces slid, heavy and cold, one against the other, as if they had always lain in that order and he had been too close to see. The Keeper's office kept one of the three boxes that cut the dot-and-split mark. And the match itself had been pressed on him by the council, with Ittan's name first on the letter that proposed it. He had noted the name then. He had thought: *a man being kind.*

A bride to kill him in his own chamber, so that a woman who owned nothing would hold the one seal in Kettamala. And who would come to take it from her? The man who had arranged for her to have it.

"He doesn't want me dead," Devan said slowly. "Or not first. He wants the seal. Every cart that goes through the Monkey Pass on a wax tally goes through whoever holds it." He turned the slip over, as if the back might say more. "He wanted a widow, not a corpse."

"A widow who'd be given a kind man's help," Neela said. "A weeping girl from a pepper house, and a councillor who'd ride up to console her. Who'd take the seal off her hands for safekeeping."

"And if she'd refused?"

"I was to be gone by then. One more beast-kill on the hill road."

His grip closed on the slip. For a moment he did not trust his hands near her, and he put them behind him.

"Asha found the first token," he said. "Six years ago. She was dead within the month."

"Yes."

"He has been writing me kind letters for six years."

Neela did not tell him it was not his fault. She stood and let him have it. When he looked up she was a pace away, near enough to touch and not touching. It was what he had wanted from the beginning: to be told the thing, and not be soothed.

The stair took him.

He didn't decide to. His body was already on the north steps, the paper in his fist. Kodiyur is four days at a hard ride, he thought. A warden's writ. The queen's household. Muthu to hold the gate.

"Devan."

"Four days. I can be in the capital before the moon is dark."

"Devan, wait."

"If I put the slip before the council—"

"It's Chathu's hand on a scrap that says *the Keeper*." She had come up the steps behind him, her voice low and fast. "That's a title, and he has a dozen men under it. You'd stand there with a torn strip from a guild satchel, and they'd ask where it came from, and you'd have to say a woman of the Resin House gave it you. In your own bed."

He turned on the third step.

"And look at the road. The pass is sealed in eight days."

"Eight days," he said.

"Three days ahead of the rains. The council always seals early, and I've been counting to the rains, not the seal." She drew breath. "A warden who rides to the capital with the sealing at his back doesn't ride home in time. You'd leave Kettamala shut in with the sealing day coming and nobody but Muthu and a goat-boy. And you don't need to go to him. He's coming to us."

He stood on the step and let that settle.

"The sealing," he said.

"Every year a clerk climbs. This year he wrote that he'd come himself." She had stood by the chest while he read the letter aloud at the window, and she had counted the friends in it. "Why does a man who has never climbed suddenly want to seal the pass with his own hand? Because there's a balance due, and he doesn't trust a clerk to collect it."

A man ought to look upon the gate he locks. He had thought it kindly meant.

"He's coming to see whether I'm dead," Devan said.

"Or whether I'm still useful." She said it without pity for herself. "Either way he walks up the hill on his own feet."

The anger went out of him, not gone but turned, the way a sluice turns a river. He had wanted something to hit. He sat down on the stair, because his legs had gone strange.

Her thumb was pressed hard against the nail of her forefinger, and the skin was red at the quick.

"On the rain night you woke and said, 'Eight nights to the new moon,'" he said. "It's six now. I didn't ask what ends then. I'm asking now, because you've just given me everything, and I'd like to know what it costs you."

She was quiet long enough that the cistern chain clanked the hour.

"At the moon the account closes," she said. "If it's still open, the guild settles it another way. I won't say how yet." She kept her voice level. "The ache is already starting. Two nights I've skipped. My nails itch at the quick in my sleep."

"For me."

"For a bed with a woman in it." She shrugged, not much. "I'd do it again. I'm only telling you the count."

He took it as it was meant, without comfort. Six nights, then. The plan, whatever it was, had to live through them.

"There is a better place for this," he said. "The queen."

She went still.

"Not a slip. You. In person, before the court. The Resin House, the contract, the whole account of who buys. No one knows it as you do. If the queen hears it from an odiyan's own mouth—"

"No."

"Neela—"

"No." She did not say it loudly. She said it once, and it held. "Think what you're asking. A confessed odiyan before the crown, with no master to vouch for her. You know what the law calls that."

He knew.

"A rogue," she said. "Hunted by guild and crown both. The second I say what I am in that hall, I'm a thing your queen is entitled to cage. You'd have to choose between the crown and me, and I'd never do that

to you." She flexed her hand. "And it isn't only me. Every page in that ledger is a life. If I stand up in the queen's hall and say *odiyan*, Chathu doesn't need to wait for the moon. He opens the book. My sister's page is on the next leaf."

She did not say a name. He did not reach for one.

Argument rose in him. Asha had written, in her fast, laughing hand, *The truth protects whoever finds it,* and Devan had built six years on it. Here was the truth, a woman who could lay out the whole crooked house, and she was telling him that in this country it was paid for with another person's neck.

Two honest things, he thought. *Neither of them wrong.* The law he served had a hole in it exactly her size.

"Your word is the one thing I can't take from you," he said. "I don't want it as evidence if that's the cost." He stopped. "I'm not saying I like it. I'm saying the stake is yours, and it's yours to name."

She let out a long breath. She looked at him as though she had braced for a blow and found a hand instead.

"You'd have made a good witness at the House," she said. "They'd have hated you for it."

"Caged me, I expect."

"Eventually." Her mouth tugged. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me. Help me. If I can't carry you to the queen and can't ride to the Keeper, I have to bring him here and catch him in front of my own men, under my own law. Tell me how."

She sat beside him on the stone step, with the oil lamps guttering and the red earth drying in patches.

"Your law," she said. "What's the oldest thing in it?"

He thought. It was good to think about something that was only a problem. "Border law. The pass stands under the warden's seal, and any cart at the padippura is the warden's to search. On sealing day it's a custom older than the charter: every cart that passes the gate that day, in or out, is opened. Nobody has ever been refused. Nobody has ever been a councillor."

"Does it say *every* cart?"

"It says every." He saw where she was going and felt the first spark of something he had not felt in a long time, a plan with a shape. "It doesn't say except the Keeper's."

"Then his cart comes up with his baggage and his clerks," Neela said, "and your men open every box. Not because you accuse him. Because it's the day, and it's the law, and it would be rude to wave one cart through." She smiled, small and hard. "In front of the whole garrison."

"And if he carries nothing?"

"A man who comes to collect a widow's seal brings his instruments. A seal box. Tallies for the right hand."

"The box proves nothing," Devan said. "His office keeps one of the three. It's the Keeper's by right. He'll say he carries it to seal the pass, and he'll be telling the truth."

"I know. I'm not looking for the box." She held up a finger. "I'm looking for what he carries with it. Whoever sells passes on the road can't pour wax in a ditch. If I know how guild couriers work, and I do, he brings them ready. Blank split-ash tallies, already waxed with the dot-and-split. Not in any clerk's book. Cut from the same split ash, sealed with the same mark, as the tally in the satchel from the narrows."

He saw it. An honest Keeper had no use for a tally that no one had written down. "That would hang him."

"In front of your garrison, with your own men holding the box." She turned her hand over. "And if he leaves them behind, then we've lost a day. But he's walked up a hill to see a dead warden and found a live one." She leaned her shoulder against his, briefly, an offer. "And I'll watch the road at night. I'll know who's coming before the gate does."

"Muthu will hold the gate that day," Devan said. "He'll open the councillor's boxes himself. I'll tell him it's the custom."

"It *is* the custom."

"Yes. That's why it's good."

They sat a while. The sun had come over the wall and lay in a strip across the pit. He was aware of her shoulder, the dust on her hem. She

had given him a name unasked, and then the price of it, which she had not meant to give. He folded the slip smaller, once, twice, until it was a hard square in his palm.

"Neela."

"Mm."

"This doesn't bind you. If Ittan walks into the trap and we take him, nothing is owed from you. No second price. I'll say so before anyone."

"I know." She was quiet. "That's why I gave it."

She stood and brushed the dust from her palms. She glanced round at the earth, the lamps, the worn marks of eight years of one man's feet. Then she said it casually, as if asking about weather.

"Spar with me."

The words landed in his chest like a stone dropped in the cistern, and he listened for the bottom.

She hadn't asked to win. She had watched him from the east steps and the rim of the pit, and from a feed bin in the rain. She had named what he was afraid of. Now she set the offer down between them, lightly, and left the lifting to him.

His hands had gone cold. In his mind there was a mud-bank and a man on his knees and two fingers going to a notch beneath an ear. And beside it, patient, a woman who had said *you stopped.*

"Not yet," he said.

He heard how it sounded. He braced for the flat look he deserved.

She only nodded, slowly. He watched her hear the difference. *Not yet*, not *no*. He had said it in a voice that left the door unbarred, and neither of them had to remark on it.

"All right," she said. "Not yet."

She went up the steps. At the top she looked back, the sun behind her, the burr still caught in her border.

"Eat something. You've been at it since the dark."

He gave her the count of fifty, then climbed after, the slip in his fist. At the head of the stair the fort lay open to him, the cistern chain clanking its hour. Down at the padippura a rider sat a lathered horse that had

no business there. It was not the ninth day, not post day. Captain Muthu stood at the stirrup with his big back to the yard, pressing a letter sealed in plain grey wax into the rider's glove.

He was not laughing. Muthu, who laughed at everything, stood perfectly quiet.

Devan knew that quiet. He had known it since they were boys in the kalari pit, when Muthu had broken a practice staff and sworn it was the damp. Devan did not move. Six nights to the moon, he thought. Eight days to the seal. The plan needed a gate, and the gate needed a man he could read.

He did not say what he knew. He opened his shirt and put the folded slip inside it, flat against his ribs, where no sleeve could give it up. Then he went down the stair in no hurry, as a warden would who had only noticed an early rider.

"Early post, Captain," he said. "What's it for?"

Muthu turned. For one breath, his face had nothing in it at all.

Chapter 24

The Carved Bird

The second letter went into Sudhi's glove at the padippura an hour after sunrise, and this time Devan was close enough to see the wax.

Plain grey. No mark.

He had come down from the east wall with the cistern chain still clanking in his ears, meaning to check the carts for sealing day. Instead he stopped behind the gate pier, in the shade of the roof, and watched Muthu lean toward Sudhi's pony, a brown, bad-tempered beast called Biscuit, and say something low to the palace rider. Sudhi laughed. Muthu did not.

Two letters in two days. Muthu, who had told Devan every thought in his head since they were boys in the same kalari pit.

Devan waited until Sudhi had gone clattering down the Monkey road. Then he stepped out.

"Another one to your mother?"

Muthu turned. The big face was open and cheerful, and for a half-breath it stayed that way. Then something behind it went out, like a lamp carried past a window.

"Yes," Muthu said.

"She writes often."

"She worries." He rubbed the back of his neck. "I'm her only son. You know how it is."

Devan did know how it was. Muthu's mother wrote once a month, in a hand like hen tracks, and Muthu read the funny parts aloud over supper. Her letter had come and been answered on the last post day. Now there had been one yesterday, off post day, and one this morning. And Muthu stood in the sun with his hands hanging, silent as a post.

Devan had seen that silence before. At twelve, in the pit, Muthu had lost a bout he should have won, and when the master asked, he had gone exactly this quiet and said he'd slipped. He had not slipped. Muthu was loud when he told the truth. He only went still when he lied.

Ittan's. The thought was cold and complete. A kind man with a grey-wax hand in Kettamala, and a letter every season that never climbed the hill because it did not need to.

He might be wrong. He had been wrong about the oldest things before, about a girl who slept with her face to the wall, and a knife under her mattress that he had left where it lay. Accusing Muthu in the yard would warn whoever sat at the other end of the thread. Locking him up would blind Devan to everything the letters carried.

"Walk the wall with me," Devan said. "I want your eye on the east cistern before the chain jams again."

"Now?"

"Now. And on sealing day I want you at the gate. You'll open the Keeper's boxes yourself. It's an honour. The garrison should see my captain do it."

He said it lightly, as a kindness between friends. Muthu's laugh came late, and too big.

It was no kindness. If Muthu was Ittan's, then the Keeper's boxes were the one place he would want to fumble. So Devan would stand at the cart himself, an arm's length from those big hands, and Bhaskaran would take the second box whatever Muthu said. A man who meant to hide something could not hide it from both of them. And if Muthu's fingers hesitated over a lid, that would answer Devan better than any letter.

They walked the wall together. Devan kept his face easy and his own counsel. Below them the hounds ran the yard in the morning light, all fourteen, and for the first time in years he saw how few people in this fort he would have trusted with his back.

One of them was still asleep in his bed. He had slid her knife back under her side of the mattress the night after she gave it him, and she had let it lie.

*

The stone was warm under Neela's hand, and the cup in its top was empty.

She had come up the second spur in daylight with a plan, which was a thing she did not often have. She would leave a mark. She would wait for Ammu, and give her a message for Chathu: *the warden is near breaking, give me the full moon.* Five nights to the new moon, and she needed every one of them.

Ammu was not there. A man sat on the far side of the slab with his back against the lightning scar, and he was whittling.

"Seventeen," Vellan said.

She had taken a breath to call out. She let it go. Nothing in her face moved. Eleven contracts had taught her that much.

He was near forty, and he had been grey at the temples since she was fifteen. A big man, with a gate's shoulders. His hands were the surprise, as they had always been: thick and scarred, and as careful with a knife as a goldsmith's. A shaving curled off the wood under his thumb and dropped to the red earth between his feet.

"The jackal-girl's at her inn," he said. "I told her I'd keep the stone today. She didn't argue." A grumble that might have been a laugh. "You never could teach her to argue with a man my size."

"What do you want, Vellan?"

"What Chathu wants. New moon." He did not look up from the wood. "He sent me up to see the state of things. I see a bride in a good

kasavu with burrs in the border, who's slept soft and eaten well, and who hasn't put a hand to her husband's throat in thirty-odd days."

"The pass doesn't close until the rains."

"The rains aren't the deadline. The moon is." The knife turned. "New moon, Seventeen. Do it, or I do it, and you go home in a collar."

Collar. It was not a jest. She saw the kennels, the iron rings in the wall, Kirri's silver anklet with its bells cut off.

Neela made her voice dry. "He sleeps with a sword on the floor."

"Not on your side. He lays it hilt toward you. The watcher says." He glanced up, light eyes under a heavy brow. "A man who gives his wife a sword in the dark is either a fool or he's got something he wants you to see."

She said nothing. He went back to the wood.

But her mind had caught on the last thing he said and would not let go. The watcher walked the hill edge each dawn and read scent-posts. That was all he did. He had never seen the inside of a barred chamber, and he could not know where a sword lay on a floor. Someone inside the fort had told the guild.

She put that away, carefully, where her face would not find it.

"Give me till the full moon."

"No."

"One more cycle. He's closer than he was. I can—"

"I know what you can." There was no heat in it. "I have watched you for twenty years, girl. You've never missed. You've never been slow. Eleven for eleven, and then you stand on a hill and leave a mark in a stone and ask for time." His thumb ran down the grain. "Chathu counts. So do I."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I do it." Calm as weather. "I'll be quicker than you. And cleaner, and he won't know me when I come."

A small shape was coming out of the block under his hands now. A bird. A fat, short-winged thing with its head turned, no larger than a plum.

"You carve for the little ones," she said.

"Somebody should." He blew the dust from its back. "They sleep better with a thing on the mat. It doesn't matter what."

"And the ones you kill? Do they sleep?"

The knife did not stop. "A blade isn't guilty, Seventeen. Only the hand that throws it. I learned that young. It makes a man restful." He turned the bird in his fingers. "You carry it too, whether you say it or not."

She did. She had said it to herself on every road for twenty years. It tasted different in his mouth. In his mouth it tasted like the last thing a man says before the door is shut.

She sat down on the edge of the stone, because standing was beginning to show.

"Vellan." She kept her voice level. "Kirri."

The knife stopped.

"You've seen her. Haven't you? Ammu writes and gets no answer. Chathu says she's where she wished to be. You go to the Resin House more than any of us. Where is she?"

He did not answer. The wind moved the grove behind them, and far down the cistern chain clanked the hour. Vellan looked at the bird in his palm for a good while, then went back to the wood and took a very small curl from the wing.

It was the worst answer he could have given. She sat with it, and did not move.

"Three times," he said at last, to the bird. "Three times I've earned the release. Chathu says there's always one more." He closed his hand. "Go home, Seventeen. Eat something. Do whatever a woman does with five nights."

He was gone before she had counted ten. He did not seem to move. One moment the big shape sat against the lightning scar, and the next there were only shavings on the earth and a smell of scorched tamarind drifting on the wind.

She stayed until her hands stopped shaking. Then she went down the hill and did the thing she had not done for any person since she was six years old.

She broke a line.

*

"His name is Vellan," she said.

It was dusk, and he had found her on the east rampart by the housing door, as he did now at the end of most days. He did not touch her. He had a way of standing at an angle that left the wall at her back and the open air at his.

"The guild's enforcer," she went on. "Near forty. Grey at the temples. If you see a very large man who walks without a sound, don't ask him his business." She stared at the terraces going dark. "He's the one who comes if I don't. At the new moon."

Devan was quiet a moment. "You met him."

"At the stone, this morning."

"And he let you walk away."

"He wants me to do it first. It's cleaner." She made herself say the next part. "He gave me five nights. He said, *Do it, or I do it, and you go home in a collar.*"

Something crossed his face that was not fear. It was older than fear. He looked at her wrists, at the pale bands of scar at the edge of her sleeves.

"What does he become?" he said.

She had known the question was coming. She had walked it up the hill and down again all afternoon.

"He's a—"

Her mouth had already shaped the first hard, rounded sound. She bit it off. Devan's eyes had gone, without his seeming to know it, across the yard to the west stair and the dark knob of the newel at its foot. They stayed there a moment. Then they came back to her.

"I can't tell you that."

"Can't."

"Won't. It's the one line I have left, Devan." She heard how her voice sounded. "Everyone in that House has a shape, and the only thing none of us has is the right to say another's out loud. You wouldn't carry the thing in your hands if I gave it you. You'd carry it in your mouth."

He took a breath, and she waited for the argument. It did not come.

"I won't ask," he said. "That one I understand." A pause. "You've told me more than I had any right to."

"There's more. He knew where your sword lies at night. Hilt toward me. He said the watcher told him." She turned from the wall. "The watcher walks the hill edge and sniffs at posts. He can't see through a barred shutter. Someone in your house talks to mine."

He went still. "Someone inside."

"Someone who's seen the floor of that room."

"Janu's girls. Raiu. Half the fort has carried water through it." His voice was flat. "I'll find out."

"I've told you his name and his day. He'll come on the new moon. He's no soldier. He's quiet, and he's patient, and he's done it for twenty years."

"I'll double the watch." He was already counting under his breath. "Two more on the west stair. Another pair on the wall. Raiu on your door tonight, and two men at the stair head."

"Watches don't stop him."

"Everything stops somebody."

"Not him. I've seen him walk through a sentried yard that was full of lamps and leave a carving on a sleeper's mat. Nobody saw him go or come. Double the watch if it helps the men sleep. But don't think a line of spears is a wall."

He looked at her while the dusk went blue behind him.

"Then what is?"

"I don't know. I wish I did." She almost smiled. "Someone inside who doesn't want him there. That's all I've ever seen stop him, and it wasn't me."

The wind came over the rampart. He weighed it, as he weighed everything, the way a man tests a plank bridge before he trusts his weight to it.

"Muthu has been sending letters," he said. "Grey wax, no mark. Two in two days. His mother writes once a month, and he goes quiet when he lies. I think he's Ittan's man."

She considered it honestly before she answered. "He could be. He could be the one who told them about the sword." It made her point harder to say, and she said it anyway. "But a man who writes letters is a man who talks, and talk is slow. Vellan doesn't write. If you spend five nights watching your friend's hands, you'll be looking the wrong way when the other one steps out."

He did not answer at once. His jaw worked, and his eyes went down to the yard, where a big shape crossed the lamplight with a laugh she could hear from here. Whatever he had built about Muthu, he had not built it lightly. He held his own wrist, hard, as if it were something he might drop.

"Then I'll keep Muthu close and watch the stair," he said. "Both. But I'll set the stair first, because you asked."

Because you asked. It was a plain thing, said plainly. She had given him a name she owed to nobody, and he had weighed it against a man he had known since boyhood, and it had come down on her side.

"Thank you," she said.

"Don't." But his ears had gone dark, and he looked away, down at the housing, where the lamp in its niche was just catching. "You'll be in the chamber tonight?"

"Yes."

"I'll bar the shutters. Raiu's at the door."

*

The shutter bar went across at full dark. She heard it settle in its brackets, and the third slat gave its small creak, and Devan went to see the west stair for himself. He would be gone an hour. He had kissed her hand at

the door, just the knuckles, and gone down the passage with a sword at his hip and fourteen hounds' worth of worry on his shoulders.

Raiu stood outside with his cowlick and his torch. She had heard him cough twice.

She took her time. She undid her braid. She set the kindi right on its side of the bed, spout to the pillow, as every night, and sat on the edge to unwind the border from her day cloth.

The pillow was wrong.

It was only a little wrong. The cloth lay as Janu's girl had smoothed it. But in the dip where her head would go, small and pale in the lamplight, sat a thing the size of a plum.

A bird.

She did not touch it. She sat very still and counted. The door: watched by a man she knew by name. The shutters: barred on the inside by a man she trusted. The third slat: untouched, or it would have sung. A chamber with one lamp and one bed and no place at all for a very big man to hide.

Then she looked, and she made herself see it.

Fresh-cut wood. The body round, the wing folded close, the head turned a little to one side, the way it had been turning in his hands on the hill. The beak was whole. Under it, on the cloth, lay one curl of shaving, still smelling of scorched tamarind.

He had finished it on the hill, under her eyes. Then he had carried it down and into the fort.

She laid her palm over the bird and then took it up. It was cold. So was the cloth beneath it. It had lain here a good while, in a bed no one had touched since morning.

He sat in this room while I sat on his hill.

Sometime between the hour she went up the spur and the hour she came back, in a fort of sixty soldiers and fourteen hounds, Vellan had walked through the warden's chamber and set a gift where she would put her head. He had come straight from her. He had not troubled to

hide it. He had wanted her to find it. And he had walked in past someone, or been let in by someone, who knew where the sword lay.

She heard Raiu cough again, on the other side of the door. He was nineteen. He was still on his feet.

Five nights, she thought. And then, because she had counted all her life and did not know how to stop: *He means four.*

Chapter 25

Claw Marks

The cistern chain clanked the hour, and Devan set his foot on the first step of the west stair as the last red went out of the laterite.

New moon. The east was already black.

He had doubled everything. Two men at the stair head, with orders to hold it whatever they heard. Pairs on the wall, every one of them mid-change on the hour chain. At the last light he had found the stair lamps drained, not burned dry: the wicks still white, the cups tipped, a thumb of oil left in each. Somebody inside the fort had wanted this stair dark. With every post tied to the chain, Raiu had gone down to the lower court for oil, and Devan took the dark stair himself, because it was the only way to her door.

Behind the barred chamber door, Neela stood at the shutter with her sleeves pushed back. She had not smeared the resin. The other one could not warn anyone, she had said, and she wanted hands tonight. One nail had split at the quick that morning. She had hidden it in her fist, and he had not mentioned it.

He passed the parrot newel, its beak worn smooth, and the shadow behind it stepped out.

He had never seen the man. He knew him anyway. Grey at the temples, a gate's shoulders, a body that made no sound on stone. Neela had described him on the rampart, and her description had been exact.

Vellan was human. His collar hung open and his throat shone black with resin.

"Warden," he said quietly.

The blade was simply there. Devan's sword was half free when it opened him across the ribs, left side, a clean hot line. He felt the edge slide, then the cold behind it. The steel was smeared dark, and a bitter smell came off it like scorched tamarind.

He got the sword up and caught the second cut on the guard. The third he took on the flat. Then he was climbing, backward, his heel finding the steps by memory. Four. Five.

"You don't swing," Vellan said. He sounded almost curious. "Eight years since you struck anyone. Your house keeps good count."

"She told me your name."

"Good girl."

Devan gave ground. He could have killed the man. His body knew where: the notch under the ear, the hollow below the breastbone. Two fingers would do it. His hands remembered every line of it, and went cold with the remembering. A mud-bank. A man on his knees.

Eleventh step. It rang hollow under his heel, over the drain slot, and he almost went down on it.

"Warden!"

Raiu's voice, from the lower court. Then boots, fast, and a torch snatched from a court bracket jerking light up the wall. The boy had dropped the can and come at the first sound of steel, a spear in his other hand. Above, a stair-head man took a step down.

"Hold the head!" Devan shouted. "Whatever you hear!"

The man stopped. Devan had given the order himself, and he heard what it cost.

"Stay back, Raiu!"

Vellan said something under his breath that might have been *pity*. He stepped down and away from Devan, toward the bend, where the wall took him out of the torchlight.

Devan did not see what happened there. The stair turned, and the wall hid it. He heard it: a cracking, a long grunt that rose and thickened. He smelled resin, sharp enough to sting his eyes.

What came round the bend was already a bear.

It was huge and shaggy and black, with a pale muzzle and claws as long as a man's fingers. It took the boy before the torch had finished falling. Raiu got the spear halfway up. The bear struck once, straight across the chest, and the boy went back against the rail with a short, broken sound.

The torch hit the step and rolled. Its flame lay along the stone like a cut.

Devan was down the steps before he had decided. His legs were wrong, heavy, and the cut at his ribs had gone from fire to ice. He did not strike. He put his body between the boy and the beast. The bear swung a paw at his head, and the claws raked the rail beside his ear and took a fist of pala wood out of it.

He thought: *Not a word. He has not said a word.* A man in shape could not speak. Beside that was another thought, small and cold. *I did not see it turn. The wall hid it. I am nothing to him but a man he is trying to kill.* The word would have been only a word.

Then he saw the boy's chest.

Raiu lay across the third step, blinking at the sky. His tunic had been laid open in four parallel furrows from collarbone to belt, deep and wide-set, the edges dragged ragged by something that did not cut but tore.

Devan knew those marks. He had stood over them at twenty-six, in the grey before dawn, with Janu holding a lamp and his hands going out to the cloth over Asha's chest.

Four ruts. Wide as this. A bear, in the walls. On this stair.

The numbness had already reached his fingertips. He could not feel the rail under his hand. It rose up his side like cold water up a post, and as it came the thought went through him whole. *Asha. Asha, on this—*

And the poison put it out.

It took the thought as a flood takes a lamp. He could not hold it. He knew only that he had been about to know something, and that it had gone out of him, and that his tongue felt thick.

He braced himself on the rail. The bear reared over him, jaws open.

"Down!"

Her voice came from above, flat and carrying, the voice of someone giving an order on a ledge. "Down! Both of you! Now!"

Light feet on the stair. Even, quick, taking nothing short.

She came out of the dusk at the head of the flight with her day kasavu hitched to the knee and the plain guild knife in her hand. Her hair was loose, her face bare. She was human, down to her breath. She had heard the clash through the shutters, and she had unbarred the door, and she had come.

Behind her the two stair-head men broke from their post at last, spears levelled, lamps swinging high, and light poured down the steps.

The bear saw them. It dropped to all fours. Its head swung up the stair, from lamp to lamp, to the spearheads and to the knife, and the little eyes in the great skull went flat. Three blades, and light. It did not roar. It turned, in one heave of its shoulders, and took the low wall at the landing in a single scrabbling vault. It was gone into the drop and the dark, with a sound of gravel going down.

Neela did not follow. She was already on her knees beside Raiu.

*

The boy was nineteen.

Devan had taken four months and asked twice to learn his name. He had stood in the yard and said it wrong, and Raiu had laughed, and it had been the best sound that week. A cowlick that never lay flat. A mother he spoke of at the fire.

Neela had both hands pressed on the torn chest, and the blood came up through her fingers. She said, "Raiu." Her voice was perfectly level. "Raiu, look at me."

He looked at her. His eyes went to Devan, above her shoulder, and some question was in them.

"You held the door," Devan said. It came out thick. "You held it, Raiu."

"Raiu." She said the name again, as steadily as a woman counting. "It's all right. Raiu."

The breath went out of him slowly. She said the name the whole time, until there was nothing left to say it to. Then she bowed her head over the boy's chest, and her hands did not move.

The two men stood on the steps with their lamps, not knowing where to put them. After them came Muthu, enormous and white about the mouth, shouting for the physician. Devan heard it as through water. He had sat down on the step without meaning to.

"Don't," Neela said, not looking up. "Don't try to stand."

"I'm awake."

"You're grey."

She was across the step in a moment, her bloody hand at his side. She opened his tunic with a jerk. The line across his ribs was thin, and the flesh at its lips had already gone the colour of a plum. A black thread was crawling out from the cut toward his belly.

He watched her see it. Her face did not change. Only her mouth went small.

*

Eravi came with his case, stooped and wheezing, and hung his lamp from the bedpost.

They had carried Devan up between them. Muthu took the head and a soldier took the feet, and he had let them, because the stair had begun to slide. Now he lay on the bed with his tunic cut away. Janu stood at the foot with her hands knotted in her apron. For once she had nothing to say.

The old physician sniffed the cut. He sniffed it again, and drew back.

"Blackbark gall," he said.

No one answered him.

"I read of it in my master's books. It is not a fort poison. It is..." He looked from Devan to the ceiling, not at Neela. "A sap, rendered, mixed with a vegetable gall. It does not kill quickly. It goes into the blood and walks slowly to the heart. I cannot draw it. I have not the knowledge, and I do not think anyone in this country has."

"How long?" Devan said.

"Three days. Perhaps a little more, if you lie still and are kept cool." Eravi's mouth worked. "And if you are very lucky."

Muthu made a low sound. Devan looked past him. Neela had come to the foot of the bed, beside Janu. Blood was drying on her wrists. She did not look at the physician.

"It's the guild's," she said. "Chathu's, from the groves. There's only one antidote, and he makes it himself. It's at the Resin House. In the tapping shed, in a cupboard with a lock I know how to open."

"That is a day's hard ride," Muthu said. "Through the wood."

"A day there. A day back. I have three." She said it as a sum. "I'll be back before the third dusk."

"No."

It was Devan's voice, and it was louder than he had meant. The room turned.

Neela only looked at him. She wore the face she wore when she had already counted the exits.

"Eravi," she said, "give him whatever will keep him still, and keep him cool. Janu, vinegar and cold cloths, and don't let the fever frighten you. It doesn't kill. Muthu." She paused, and he saw her choose, and he saw her check that the choice was hers. "I need to talk to you outside."

*

He should have stayed on the bed.

Eravi had put something bitter in a cup, and Devan had drunk half and spilled half and, when Janu turned to the basin, got his legs under him. The room swung. He went down the passage with a hand on the

wall, the left side of his body a piece of cold wood. He kept hold of what he had: a torch rolling on a step, something dark at the wall. Where the rest should have been there was a gap, smooth as a swallowed stone. He reached for it and it slid away.

The stable smelled of dung and hay and lamp oil. A single lantern hung from a beam.

She was saddling the grey mare. She had changed into riding clothes, a dark mundu hitched high and a shawl crossed over her chest. Her knife was in her belt. Her hands moved on the girth with the speed of someone who had done this in the dark a hundred times. As he watched, she pulled the strap through, and her thumb flinched from the buckle, and he saw that three nails had split to the quick where there had been one this morning.

She did not look round.

"Go back to bed."

"You're going to the Resin House."

"Yes."

"The guild's house." His mouth did not want to make the words. He made them anyway. "The place that sold you, and made you, and wrote your name in a book. They know you didn't kill me. Vellan knows. By now, Chathu knows."

"I know."

"Then you know what you're riding into."

She turned. The lantern put gold on one side of her face, and the other side was dark. She looked at him for a long moment, at the way he leaned on the doorpost, at the colour of his lips.

"I do," she said. "I've been in that yard since I was six."

"Neela."

"Muthu will keep you cool. I'm trusting him with your body, not your secrets, and I hate it, but I have nobody else. I've told him what to do if I'm late. Don't argue."

"Muthu," he said. It was all the breath he could spare for the name he had been afraid of since the yard.

"I know what you think of him. I think it too." She tightened the strap. "He'll still not let you die in front of him. Whatever else he is."

"I don't want you—"

"I know what you want." There was no heat in it. She had gone gentle, and that was worse. "You'd have me sit here with your hand in mine and be the woman who could have gone. I won't be her. Nobody taught me this one, Devan. I'm choosing it."

She gathered the reins. He took a step, and the floor tilted, and he crossed the straw anyway. He caught the girth strap where her hand had been and touched one of the split nails. It was rough as bark. She let him.

He could not stop her, and he reached for her anyway.

His hand found her wrist. The pulse beat under his fingers, quick and living. The bone of it was narrow, the pale ridged scar there, and the gold bangle was warm.

"If you go there," he said, "they'll cage you."

He felt his grip begin to go, the way a rope goes slack in a wet hand. He tried to close it. His fingers would not answer. The word he had meant to say next lay on his tongue, and the dark came up over it.

"Neela, they'll ca—"

His hand opened.

Chapter 26

The Kennels

He did not finish the word. His hand opened on her wrist, and Neela caught his weight before the straw could.

"Muthu!"

The captain came at a run from the stable door, where he had been standing with his arms folded and his big face gone quiet. He took Devan under the shoulders without being told. Between them they got him down flat on a hay bale, his cheek against the sack.

"He's only gone under," she said. "The poison does that. Keep him cool. Vinegar, wet cloths, and the shutters open, whatever Janu says. Don't let Eravi bleed him again. He has no blood to spare."

Muthu nodded. He was not laughing. In five weeks of barracks noise she had never seen his mouth so still, and she knew what the stillness meant, because Devan had told her. She looked at him anyway, straight, and said the rest.

"If I'm not back by first light on the second day, put him in a cart and start up the wood road. Meet me on it. It saves a day he hasn't got."

"Neela—"

"First light. Not later." She pulled the girth tight, and the mare blew. "I'm trusting you with something I can't spare. Don't make me sorry."

"I won't." He said it low, with his eyes on Devan's face, and she could not tell what it was worth. She had no one else to ask.

She swung up. Bhaskaran opened the wicket at the padippura without a word. Then there was only the road and the dark, and the cistern chain clanking the hour behind her like a door being shut.

*

Rain began before dawn.

She rode the Monkey road downhill with the mare's breath smoking and her nails throbbing at the quick. By morning the ruts ran like streams. By noon the water had found her spine. She counted milestones, then breaths, then the mare's strides between breaths. It kept her from counting how many hours Devan had left.

Three days, Eravi had said. Perhaps.

She trusted no inn. She walked the mare through the fords and ate the heel of bread Janu had pushed into her saddlebag. A fever she had not given in to for weeks began to climb, and she let it climb, and rode.

By late afternoon the road forked at a leaning stone, and she took the narrower way. The trees changed. They went black at the foot, as though soaked in ink, then all the way up. Their bark hung in plates, and the plates wept. The smell reached her before the shadows did: bitter, scorched, like tamarind left on a fire, with pine sap running underneath. She had breathed it every day from six years old to twenty-seven. It was the smell of her bed and her bowl and the first time a man held her wrist still.

Blackbark Wood, she thought. *Home.*

She had never hated a word so much.

She tied the mare in a thicket a mile out and went in on foot along the old drain path she and Ammu had used as children, when the cook was asleep.

*

The Resin House rose out of the wet wood in tiers of dark roof, with tapping sheds along the east side and the long training yard lying open

between them like a swept palm. No lamps burned in the yard. They never had. Chathu said light was for those with something to show.

She went over the wall by the old fig and crossed the dark without a sound. The third shed had a loose hasp and a lock she had learned to open at fourteen, on a dare, with a pin and a held breath. It still opened for her.

Inside, the smell was thick enough to chew. At the back stood the cupboard, plain deal, with a brass lock the size of her thumb. She worked her knife tip in and felt the wards give one by one. Shelves of small clay vials, stoppered with wax, each tagged in the same fine hand she had once copied letters from. *Fever, young. Fever, old. Black gall, counter.* Chathu labelled everything. She had never found it funny until now.

She took the last one, no longer than her finger, with a pinch in the wax where his thumb had pressed. She pocketed it and locked the cupboard behind her. Her skin crawled to the roots of her hair.

Eleven for eleven, Vellan had said. *You've never missed.* She had walked in, found it and taken it. It had all been too quiet and too easy.

She stepped out into the yard. The rain had stopped. A smell came across the wet earth that was not resin. Wet fur and old musk, it sat much lower in her mind than a smell had a right to, a long way down, where she kept being six.

The bear stood in the middle of the yard.

It was upright, which they seldom were, its black shoulders roped with wet, the pale Y of its chest showing. Its head swung slowly to find her. *It was on the wall that night,* she thought. *He ran to be here first.*

It did not charge. It stood and let her see it.

Behind it, lamps opened, and a dozen men came out of the long shed with hooked poles and nets and iron rings on chains. She knew three of them by name. She had eaten beside Pachan at the long table when she was ten, and he had given her his sweet.

She had the knife out before she had decided anything. She took the first man at the wrist, the second at the knee, the third under the nose with the heel of her hand. She was fast. She was always fast. But she had

ridden a night and a day on bread and fever, her hands were shaking, and a net dropped across her head from behind like a sheet.

They pulled her down. A knee found her back. Someone wrenched the knife away, and someone else tore at the fold of her shawl. She heard herself make a sound as the vial came out and was held up in the lamplight.

"There it is," said Pachan. He did not sound unkind. "Master said she'd come for it."

Master said.

The bear dropped to all fours and went into the shadow without looking back.

*

The kennels lay under the oldest roof, behind the cook-house and a shuttered well. She had been told once what they were for. She had never been inside.

They carried her in by the arms, the net still tangled in her hair. A lamp burned at the end of a long aisle between iron cages, floor to roof, with straw and a bucket in each. A deer lay curled in the nearest, its hide gone patchy. Beyond it were a hare, a mongoose, something striped, and a very thin fox that did not lift its head.

Their eyes shone as she passed. They did not follow her. That was the worst of it. They looked at the lamp and the hunters' feet and the wall, as if they had once been looking for something and had forgotten what.

The hunters unlocked a cage near the end, put her inside, and knotted a leather cord from her wrists to a ring in the wall, high enough that she had to stand. Pachan tested the knot.

"I'm sorry, Seventeen," he said. He meant it, and it made no difference. They took the lamp away.

She waited until her eyes found the dark. Then she looked at the cage beside hers.

It was lower and smaller, the straw fresh that day. In it, curled with its nose against its tail, lay a civet: grey-brown, long-bodied, a dark mask

across the face. It watched the corner of the cage, where nothing was. Round its hind leg, worn smooth and thin, was a silver anklet with no bells.

"Kirri," she said.

Nothing moved. She said it again, louder, and then in the voice she had used at eight, across the yard behind the sheds, calling to a twelve-year-old Kirri who was far too clever for her own good and who had always answered, *What?* The civet's ears turned a hair toward the sound. That was all. They turned back.

Released. She had lived twenty years on that word. Eleven contracts, and one more, and the page burned and a name given back. She had believed in it the way other people believed in rain.

Kirri had been the best liar in the House. Kirri had wanted a boat.

She hung there by her wrists in the smell of straw and old fear and bitter resin, and said quietly to nobody, "Well. That's the price, then."

She counted the cages. Forty-two, and one of them was hers. She counted them again.

*

Chathu came at dawn.

She had not slept. Grey light reached the aisle through a high grille, and then came a step she would have known blind: soft, unhurried, a little uneven on the left foot where he had once broken it. The lamp in his hand swung a slow circle on the straw.

He was an old man, round-shouldered, in a clean white mundu, a plain wooden comb in his hair. A big ledger in black cloth was tucked under his arm, and in his free hand was a tin. His eyes were wet.

"Child," he said. "You look half dead."

"I rode a long way."

"I know. I'm sorry for it." He set the tin on the cage bar. "Jaggery and sesame. I had the cook make them warm. Eat."

She did not look at it. She had learned, around the fifth contract, what a gift was.

"No. Never, when you're frightened." He sighed, sat on an upturned bucket, and laid his palm on the ledger the way another man would stroke a sleeping dog. "I want to tell you how it comes out, Seventeen. People are better for knowing. It is only a matter of accounts."

"Chathu—"

"You came for the antidote. It was well done. You always had a hand." He nodded as at a good sum. "I made that vial, and I know how long it takes. Your husband will be dead by the end of tomorrow, and not before. At dusk I will put the resin on you myself, as I did the first time. I will open this book to your leaf and read it aloud. Then you will be in the cage next to Kirri, and by the next rains you will not remember your own name."

He said it as a physician might say that the bone had to be set.

"Ammu is coming back to me," he added. "I have recalled her. She will carry the resin pot at dusk, and she will stand and watch what comes of a covered scent-post. A lesson is best learned with the eyes."

Neela said nothing. Her throat had closed.

"And Vellan will finish your warden after. Tonight, when the cart comes in at my gate. He has only to wait for it."

The cart.

She went cold from the scalp down. Nobody had said a cart in Chathu's hearing. Only two people alive had heard it, in a stable, over a sick man's body. She remembered Muthu's stillness, and *I won't,* said low, and how she had not been able to tell what it was worth.

"Who told you about a cart?"

"A house pays its debts in news, child." He smiled, sadly, and did not say more.

So the order had been hers. *Meet me on the road,* she had said, and had named the hour, and someone had carried it out of Kettamala faster than she had ridden. She had built the trap herself and sent a dying man to walk into it.

"You sold her," she said. Her voice, when it came, was hoarse. "Kirri. You told her it was release."

"I told her what she needed to hear to do her work." He did not flinch. "And when she was tired, and the work had cost her more than she could pay, I gave her a place. Do you know what happens to an odiyan with no ledger? The crown hunts her. A rogue dies in a ditch with a rope round her neck. Here she is fed. She is kept dry. She is not afraid."

"She doesn't know her own name."

"No. But she is not afraid." He turned the ledger. "Twenty-one years I have kept you, Seventeen. Rice, oil, salve, teachers. A tutor for your letters. I have written down what you cost me. I weep when one of you is lost, and I mean it, and the book balances all the same. Without a leash you would all be hunted dogs. The ledger is mercy."

The old voice was gentle as ever. And she saw, for the first time, that it had never once been lying. He believed it. That was the worst thing about him. He had believed it at the table when he gave her sweets, and he believed it now, at the bars.

"The twelfth contract," she said. "Release."

"Is a lovely word." His smile was sad. "Eleven you did. The twelfth you failed. Release has always been a word for what comes after."

He rose, tucking the book under his arm, and lingered looking down at her. She thought for a moment he would reach through the bars. He did not.

"You are thinking you were owned. You were. You are a clever girl, you have always known it." His head tilted. "But it comes to me you think this book is the whole of it."

She said nothing.

"The ledger isn't the only book, child," said Chathu softly. "It never has been."

He took up the lamp and went away down the aisle with his uneven step. The tin stayed on the bar, the steam still lifting from the lid.

*

They came for her an hour later and bound her better.

Three hunters, and Pachan not among them. They took off the soft cord and put on hard, wet leather that would shrink in the heat. They pinned her arms behind her at the elbows, tied her wrists together, and hauled the knot to a staple in the floor. They did not speak. One ran his thumb down the inside of her wrist, over the pale ridged scar, as though it were a mark on a cheese.

Then they left her alone with the light climbing the grille.

Dusk, she thought. *Maybe ten hours.*

Second dusk is tonight. Muthu will have started at first light, as I told him. If he doesn't meet me, he keeps coming, and he reaches the gate at tonight's dusk.

That was the arithmetic. A sick man in a cart, at the gate of a yard full of hunters, and Vellan waiting. She worked at the knot until the leather bit. It held.

Chathu had seen her turn at sixteen and written her into a book, and called it mercy. Devan had seen her ten times and more. On the nights since the rampart he had held a river pebble in his cheek, so that in sleep or fever the word could not slip, and he had never asked her to thank him for it.

Both of them held the same word. One kept it in a ledger. One kept it behind his teeth.

If the resin took her at dusk, she would not go into the straw with her mouth shut. She would say it herself, aloud, to someone who was looking. She did not know why that mattered. Only that the word should be hers, once.

Boots came across the yard outside, and a voice she knew, quick and low and out of breath. Not words. Only a tune.

Pull and pull, the tide is coming in.

The door at the end of the aisle opened. Light fell down the straw, and Ammu stood in it.

She was mud to the knees, in the plain blue cotton of Valli the pepper trader's girl, her braid half down. A hunter held her elbow, though she

was not struggling, and Chathu's voice somewhere behind her said, *Let her see.* She had ridden all night, and her face was grey with it.

She looked down the aisle at the cages. At the fox. At the deer. At the small grey shape in its straw with the silver on its leg.

Then she looked at Neela.

Twenty years. Neela had seen that face laugh and lie, tease and steal and cry itself sick over a dead sparrow. She had never seen it like this: still, and white, with its mouth shut hard over something it was not going to say. Her lips began to shape a line of the tappers' verse, *the name given back,* and stopped before the sound.

Across all the bars, Ammu's eyes held hers, and did not look away.

Chapter 27

Leopard

They forced the resin on her before sunset, so she would have time to bleed.

Four hunters held her in the cage, and Pachan was one of them. He kept his eyes on the straw. A fifth man took her chin in his fist and tilted her head back until the bars bit her skull. Ammu stood at his elbow with the resin pot in both hands, as Chathu had ordered. Her face gave away nothing.

"Hold still, Seventeen," Ammu said, in a voice that was not hers.

The paddle came down cold across the pale scar at Neela's throat.

She had smeared that resin herself a hundred times and chosen every one. The scars knew her hand. They did not know this. The old ridges split like seams. Blood ran warm down her neck and into her collar, and the cold went to fire. They did her wrists next. She heard a sound and knew it was hers.

It would take her at dusk. She could scream or sing or lie dead still, and it would make no difference. Already a low hum had started behind her teeth.

"The cart is at the gate road," said a hunter at the door. "Master wants everyone."

"Ammu stays," Pachan said, thumbing his belt. "Master says a lesson's better with the eyes. Watch her."

Ammu nodded. The boots went away across the yard, and the latch dropped on the aisle.

Neela counted. At ten, Ammu set the pot down on the straw, and her hands stopped shaking.

"Pachan's belt ring," she said, holding up a key. "He still leans like a man among friends."

She took a flat blade from her braid and cut the wet leather. The strips fell. Neela's hands came free, red to the elbow, and would not close.

"Here." Ammu pressed something small into her palm: a finger of clay, with a thumb-pinch in the wax. "Out of Chathu's sleeve. I've been picking that sleeve since I was seven."

The antidote. Neela stared at it. "Ammu. Your hair. You'll be—"

"Dead, probably. Listen, chechi, I haven't long." The old teasing was gone from her voice, and the speed stayed. "There's a way out. I told you once there was, and you didn't ask, because you never do. Once in a life, to one person who is looking at you, during the dusk turning, you say it yourself. Aloud, in your own voice."

"Say what?"

"What you are." Ammu's mouth shook. "The name given back. That's the verse. That's all the verse ever was."

The song. Neela had sung it a thousand times, tapping bark, and never heard it.

"It voids everyone else," Ammu said. "Chathu. Me. The witness page goes dead in his hands. After that it takes two voices to cage you, and one of them is yours. Nobody can do it without you."

"What does it cost?"

"Everything." Ammu laughed once, breathless. "You share wounds with that person for life. A cut on him opens on you. If he's dying, you go with him. Your entry in the ledger burns, so the guild knows, and you're rogue. The crown hunts you. And you can do it once, ever, to one person, so you'd better mean him."

Neela said nothing for a breath. "You've known for years."

"Since I was fourteen. An old master whispered it drunk, and I swore I'd never tell. I didn't tell you because it costs, chechi." She wiped her face with the back of her wrist. "And because hiding kept us alive. It did. Twenty years. I'm not sorry."

"I'm not asking you to be."

"Good." Her chin came up. "You know who."

"I've known since the stable."

"I know you have. I stopped believing your tom cat a week ago." Ammu pulled her up by both arms. "I'm a bad liar when it's you."

At the cage door she stopped. She dug two fingers into the resin pot and drew them down her own throat, then across each wrist, quick as a woman straightening a collar. She hissed once through her teeth. The black smear shone wet above her cloth.

"I'm not waiting for anyone to hold my chin," she said. "Come on."

They went out past the cages. Neela stopped at the small one. The civet lay curled around the silver on its leg and did not look up.

"I wrote her and wrote her," Ammu said, very low. "She's past the door, chechi. Come."

Neela put two bloody fingers through the bars and touched the grey fur. It was warm. She took her hand back.

*

Last light lay red along the yard wall.

The shouting came from the gatehouse before they reached the corner of the cook-house. Steel on steel, and a big voice roaring words she could not make out. A horse burst out of the arch with its rider slumped forward on its neck, iron-shod hooves skidding in the wet. Muthu had not brought a cart. A cart was a day Devan did not have. A very large man with a sword slapped the horse's rump and turned his back on the yard.

He did not look round. Hunters came at him in the arch, and he took them there, one at a time, with the stone at his back.

The horse stopped in the middle of the yard, blowing. The rider slid sideways and hit the mud.

She ran. She went down on her knees in the wet beside him, and her hands found his face.

He was grey. His lips had gone the colour of ash, and the black thread had crept past his belt and up under his ribs. His eyes opened when she said his name.

"Neela." It was barely a sound. He spat something into his palm and closed his fingers over it, a small wet river pebble. "You didn't come back."

"I'm here. Swallow."

She dug the wax stopper out with her teeth. She tilted his head and put the vial to his mouth, and he took it as a child takes medicine, trusting and slow. Some ran down his chin. She held his jaw shut with her hand.

"Swallow."

He did. His throat moved.

"Now listen," she said. "The sun is almost down. I'll change. The resin's on me. Don't look away. Whatever happens in the next minute, keep your eyes on me."

"I've watched every turning you let me see." His mouth shaped the ghost of something dry. "I never once looked away."

"This is different."

"Then I'll look harder."

The shed latch scraped.

Chathu stepped out of the long shed with his lamp in one hand and a black cloth packet in the other. His step was uneven on the left foot. He saw her kneeling, and the open kennel door beyond the cook-house corner, and he stopped. For one moment she saw the old man's face come apart. He looked like someone who had found a hole in a floor he had walked for twenty years.

"Seventeen," he said. "Ammu. Oh, child."

Ammu was already gone. She was a shadow at the cook-house corner, and then she was not.

The sun touched the wall's edge. The hum behind Neela's teeth became a drum.

She stood. She put herself between Devan and the last of the light, so that he would see her and nothing else. Her wrists were running. Her throat was running. The first bone moved.

"Look at me," she said.

He was propped on one elbow in the mud. He looked. Not at her throat or her hands, but at her face, as if it were a thing he meant to keep.

Behind Chathu, a big shape came out of the shed shadow at a walk. Vellan pulled a flask from his collar and smeared his throat as he went. She saw it at the edge of her eye and did not turn her head.

The burn came up her spine like a fist opening. Her knees bent the wrong way. Her mouth filled with the taste of bark and copper, and the yard tilted and swam with a thousand new smells, and every one of them was prey. She had a minute, perhaps less, before the voice went.

She had never said it. Not in eleven years, not to a mirror, not alone on a hill. The other one, she had called it, afraid of its name as she had been afraid of her own.

To him, then. Her voice cracked and held.

"Leopard."

It went out of her like a thrown stone. Something in her chest unlatched and latched again, and settled with a click she felt in her ribs. Devan's face did not change, except that his eyes shut for the length of a heartbeat and opened.

Then her jaw lengthened, and her voice was gone.

*

Chathu began to read.

He had the page out of its cloth, a single ivory leaf, brown at the edges, black lines crowding its face. A narrow slip was stitched to its corner with coarse thread. His voice was steady and kind, the voice that

had read her to sleep once. "Seventeen. First turning witnessed in this house, Chathu, master. Night-shape—"

He stopped. He took a breath, because the word had to be said.

"Leopard."

Nothing happened.

She stood on four feet in the red mud, the whole yard a bell of smells, and waited for the cage to close. It did not come. There was only the click she had already felt, lodged in her ribs.

"Leopard," he said again, louder. "Seventeen. Leopard."

The ink moved on the page.

The witness lines blackened one by one, the way a leaf blackens in a fire, from the middle outward. A thread of smoke rose from the fine hand she had once copied her letters from. The entry curled and glowed in his fingers, and he cried out. The slip tore free at its stitches and dropped face up in the mud, whole and unscorched. *Intake, sold at six years,* it said in a different hand, with two more lines beneath that she could not read.

The rest of the leaf burned in the mud and was gone.

Chathu stood with his hand held out in front of him. Then he stooped, quick and careful, and took the slip out of the wet. His thumb covered what was written on it. His eyes were wet.

"What have you done?" he whispered. "What have you done to my book?"

Then, over his shoulder, flat and cold: "Vellan."

The turning was done in him. She heard the wet crack of it and smelled scorch and sap, and the bear came on at a run.

Devan was still propped in the mud on one elbow. The antidote had gone into him a minute ago, no more. It had not reached his legs. He could not stand.

It was not a fast beast, but it was a heavy one. Its mass shook the ground. It came straight at the downed man and the cat beside him, forepaws raised.

Neela threw herself at its flank.

It was all she had. Her shoulder hit the black ribs, and the bear's rush turned half aside. Its weight flung her off. She hit the mud and rolled, winded, and the ache in her new limbs said she would not do that twice.

The bear swung back for the man on the ground.

Devan got a knee under him and no more. His arm shook. He had no sword. The great black shoulder came down at him, near enough that the stink of it filled his face, and his right hand lifted from the mud with the fingers crooked.

It stopped in the air.

She saw him find the place. She saw him think of the ford, and the eight years. His fingers crooked tighter and hesitated, the way they had when he told her about the raider captain. His face went very still. He did not close his eyes.

The hand went in, hard and exact, to the hollow of the shoulder.

The bear's foreleg folded. The whole huge body pitched and skidded in the mud with a grunt like a tree coming down, and ploughed to a stop an arm's length from his knees. It lay there bellowing.

Devan pitched forward on his hands and stayed there, his head hanging.

A hot tearing line opened along her own ribs.

A cut on him opens on you. Ammu had said it not an hour ago. His old wound had split under the strike, and now it was hers as well. She saw him sway and clap a hand to his side.

He lifted his head. He looked at what he had done, and at her.

He did not look sorry. That was the thing. She had been braced for sorry.

Chathu's voice rose behind them. "Leave the cat! She'll keep till the bear's done. The jackal has Pachan's key. Take the jackal!"

Then she heard it from the cook-house roof. Three short yips, a pause, and one long rising note.

Tomorrow, I will find you.

She had practised that at eleven and nine, behind the sheds, until Chathu said the House had no use for dogs.

A fawn shape dropped from the thatch onto the bear's back, raked its ear with a flash of teeth and sprang off. Ammu landed in the mud with her hackles up and her tongue out, grinning. It was a ridiculous look on a jackal. It was exactly her face.

She turned and ran for the trees.

The bear heaved up on three legs. It roared, and the sound shook the yard. Then it went after her, limping, furious. The hunters followed with their poles and nets, spilling past the cook-house. Chathu's voice rang, thin and high, behind them.

No, Neela thought. The cat in her bunched to follow.

Devan's hand found her shoulder. It did not grip. It rested.

"Don't," he said. "They want you to follow."

She stood trembling under it. The cat's whole body said run. She weighed it the way she weighed a wall. Ammu was thirty strides ahead, and the nets were thrown for a leopard as much as a jackal. His tunic was black and wet down the left side where the old line had split, and the same fire lay along her own ribs. If she ran and a spear found her, he would bleed for it, with no blood to spare. If she ran, she ran alone, and left him in the mud of a yard that still had hunters in it. If she stayed, Ammu ran alone.

Nobody ordered her. His hand stayed light, and he did not say it twice.

She stayed. She hated it.

Every sound reached the cat's ears, a hundred times sharper than hers. The crashing in the brush and the bear's wounded breath. Then a stretch of nothing but running feet, and a yip that cracked, and then another, too far.

A man shouted, a single word. A spear thudded.

Then the cry. It was not the call. It was short and high and surprised. It rose, as if she meant to say something at the end of it.

It stopped.

The wind turned and came back across the wood. It carried the smell with it: jackal blood, hot and sharp, and nothing living under it.

At the gate, the steel noise had gone quiet too, and somewhere in the arch, a big voice was swearing hoarsely and alive.

Chathu's lamp passed along the yard wall and went into the dark. Neela did not look at it.

*

She could not turn back before dawn.

Nothing in the world could change her till the sky did. She was a cat, and there were hours of night to get through, and a body that did not know how to weep.

Devan had not got up again. He lay on the wet earth, his breath shallow and fast, and the antidote had begun to work in him, or he would be dead. The stain on his tunic had spread, low on the left, and she felt the answering sting along her own side.

She stepped over him. She lowered herself, heavy and warm, across his chest and belly, and put her chin on his shoulder. She could feel his heart under her. She counted it.

His hand came up and found her ruff and stayed there, loose. He said nothing. The night came down, and the rain began again.

She did not leave.

Chapter 28

Wound-Share

The sky went grey, and the cat let go of her.

It began in the spine, a pull like a wet rope drawn through her bones. Fur sank into skin. The great warm weight across Devan's chest thinned to a woman's, lying in red mud with the rain gone cold on her back. She had no cloth and no voice yet. Her teeth were chattering too hard for either.

Then the cold stopped mattering, because her side was on fire.

She pushed up on one hand and looked down. A welt ran along her left ribs from under the breast to the hip, raw and red, beaded with blood along its length. She had not taken this wound. Nothing had cut her side. Her own blood was at her throat and wrists, where they had held her.

It lay exactly where the black stain showed on his tunic.

"Neela." His voice was a scrape. He was looking at her face, only her face. "Is that my wound?"

"It's yours." She pressed two fingers to it, and he hissed through his teeth at the same instant, and his hand flew to his ribs. They stared at each other.

"On me," she said. "It came up when I turned." She could hear her own voice climbing. "Ammu told me. A cut on you opens on me. She didn't say it would feel like this. Every time. Every cut you take. For the rest of my life, Devan."

"Yes." He did not soften it. "And you'll cost me the same."

He touched his own throat. His collar was stiff and dark. Beneath it, when he pulled the cloth aside, ran a thin red line where an odiyan's scar would be, though he had none, and another showed at each wrist where his sleeves had ridden up.

"The resin," she said. "They tore me open. It's on you."

"I thought it was the fever." He looked at the lines, then at her wrists. Her fingers had swollen overnight and still shook. "They were bleeding through the turning?"

"Still open when I said it. That's when it took." She held them out before he asked. "Here."

He did not say he was sorry, or that he had done it to her. He tore a strip from the hem of his tunic with his teeth and one hand, and bound her left wrist, and then her right, quick and tight, not touching the open parts.

"You can't wrap yours," she said.

"Then I'll bleed in pairs." The corner of his mouth moved. "Seems fair."

It nearly made her laugh. The laugh came up through her chest and caught, and she found she was crying instead, without any sound. He said nothing. He moved his arm and let her put her face against his shoulder where the mud was thinnest, and he held her head.

Muthu found them like that. He stood a way off with a horse blanket, his face grey under the stubble and one sleeve black to the elbow, and made no noise at all. He set the blanket down on the mud and walked back to the gate.

*

The yard was empty. That was the first wrong thing.

No hunters, no lamps. The long shed stood open, and a net lay trampled by the cook-house door. Chathu had taken his people and gone into the Blackbark Wood in the night, and he had taken the book.

A burned leaf was one leaf. Every other page he held was still a leash, and he knew it.

Vellan had gone with him. A bear's track ran from the yard into the mud at the tree line, three clear prints and a fourth that only dragged, a long furrow where the ruined foreleg trailed. It led straight into the trees.

She found Ammu where the trees began.

Ammu lay on her side under a black-barked giant with her knees drawn up, small, a woman again after a night as a jackal. The spear had gone in under the ribs. Her face was turned to the earth, and her braid had come all the way down. Muthu had put a coat over her, and it was too big. The sleeve covered her hand.

Neela knelt. She had thought there might be something to say.

"Ammu," she said.

That was all there was. Twenty years, and it was a name. She turned the shoulder gently, and the face was not afraid. It looked cross, a little, as if Ammu had been interrupted halfway through a joke. Her mouth was open on the next word.

Neela closed the eyes with two fingers. She did not cry again. There was none left to do it with.

At the foot of the tree, in the roots, lay a small blue bundle: the cloth Ammu wore as Valli, the pepper trader's girl. Muthu had found it at the cook-house corner, where she had shed it, and laid it at the tree. It was folded in thirds, as Ammu always folded things. Beside it was a cord pouch with a thumb of black resin in it, the last she had held back for herself. Neela took it and tied it at her waist. She had no master now, and no ration, and she would not see the House's groves again except over a blade. The pouch was no gift. It was a debt, and she meant to spend it well.

Muthu had found a spade in the tapping sheds. He dug without being asked, a long way into the soft red ground, and she did not tell him to stop. Once she looked at his back. She remembered a stable, and an order, and Chathu's *a house pays its debts in news*. He had come on

horseback, held an arch with a sword against twelve men, and slapped a horse's rump to send a sick man past him. A man could do both things.

She did not ask. She thought, *Later.* She was not sure she was brave enough for later.

When the grave was deep enough, Devan was there, upright by some stubbornness, a hand on a tree. He had washed his face at the cook-house well. He looked down at the small shape in the coat, and his lips moved once.

"Ammu," he said.

She turned to him. He said it again, carefully, like a man learning a name he had come to too late. "I'd have liked to know her."

"She'd have cheated you at seven wells," Neela said. "In the first game."

"Good."

"She hummed when she was afraid. A fishing song. *Pull and pull, the tide is coming in.*" Her mouth would not go on. He did not ask her to. He took hold of one end of the coat, and Muthu took the other, and they laid her down.

*

She would not leave without the kennels.

Devan did not stop her. He lowered himself onto the cook-house step and said, "I'll be here," as though that were an ordinary thing to say, and it was the kindest she had ever heard.

The aisle was as it had been. The deer. The hare. The mongoose, the fox that did not lift its head. Someone had left the end door open, and the light lay along the straw. A hunter's lamp had burned out in its bracket. The troughs were dry, and the racks were bare. No one had come to feed them.

She stood a moment. Then she put her bound hands to the shuttered well behind the cook-house and tore the boards off it, and it hurt, and she did it anyway. She hauled the bucket up and down the aisle until every trough held water. She forked fodder from the loft into every oc-

cupied cage, forty-one of them, and carried the cook-house scraps to the fox and the mongoose.

Then she went down to the small cage and stopped.

Kirri slept. The civet was curled nose to tail, and a thread of grey light lay on the silver round its leg.

Open it, said the part of her that had been the best at locks. *Open every one. Run them out into the wood.*

And then what? These were not captives with a bolt to draw back. Their minds were going out like lamps. A cage could be unlocked. A caging could not. The deer would stand in the open and not know what the open was. Kirri would walk into the trees and forget why.

And one trough would not last them. Water and a forkful of hay were a day, three at most. Forty-one animals shut in an empty compound would starve long before she was a week down the road.

No caging is ever undone. She had known it all her life, as she knew the number of the stairs. She had never before known it with her hand on the bars.

She put her fingers through and touched the silver anklet. It was worn so thin she could have bent it.

"I can't take you out," she said. "I'd like to tell you I can. I'd like to say it was the cage." Her voice cracked. "I can't give you your name, Kirri. But I'll keep it. I've got yours and Ammu's now."

The civet did not stir.

"You wanted a boat." She swallowed. "I'll find the sea. I'll send the anklet in a fish basket, like you said. Do you hear? I'm coming back. For you, and for the deer, and the fox, and all forty-one." She counted them with her eyes down the aisle, and her voice dropped. "Every one. If it takes years. If I have to take the House down plank by plank."

Nothing answered her. She stood until the light climbed the grille.

Then she propped the end door wide with a stone, wiped her face on the back of her wrapped wrist, and walked out into the morning.

Devan was on the step. Muthu stood a little way off, leaning on the spade.

"They'll be dry again in three days," she said. "I can't open them. It wouldn't free them, it would only put them out to die."

"No." Devan did not look at the kennels. He looked at Muthu. "The first cart goes as soon as the wood road will take a wheel. Four of Bhaskaran's men and fodder. If the rain holds them, they'll lose a day, not more. Then every week the roads allow, until we know what else can be done."

Muthu looked at the spade. "I'll go myself," he said, hoarsely.

"After the sealing." Devan's voice was mild. "I want you at the gate."

Muthu's hands went still on the spade. "Aye," he said.

It was not enough. It was all that was on offer. Neela nodded once, and Devan nodded back.

*

They rode all day.

Muthu had Devan before him on the big bay, one arm round his waist. She followed on the grey mare, who had stood in the thicket since the first dusk and now rolled a reproachful eye at her. Neither man spoke much. Devan slept in snatches, and she watched his back go slack, wake, and slacken again.

The road ran up out of the wood and the trees lost their black. Behind her lay the only home she had had, and it was closed. Her page was ash. The House would call her rogue. The crown hunted rogues, and no one could now vouch for her at any gate in Varanad except the one she was riding toward.

She had not a guild-sister left to lie to. She had not a master. The only people on her side of any wall who knew what she was were a captain with a locked mouth and a sick man who had followed her through a gatehouse.

Late in the day Devan roused and looked back over Muthu's shoulder. He said, in the flat voice he used for facts:

"The warden's house has room in it. Nobody will ask for your page at my gate."

"They'll ask the next day."

"Then they'll ask me." He thought about it. "I have no one at Kettamala who's mine except Janu, and she's the fort's. I'd like it to have someone who is."

She did not answer. She rode. But she moved the mare up until her knee touched the bay's flank, and she kept it there. Devan turned his face forward again. After a while his hand, on the bay's neck, uncurled.

*

Two days after they rode in, the Keeper of the Passes came up to Kettamala with five carts.

He was late. The carts had been due days before, and a rider had come in ahead of them with word that they were held at the lower waystation. A matter of an axle, the rider said. The charter sealing waited on the Keeper's own seal, so every day he lingered below was a day the pass stayed open. Devan read the delay another way. It was how a man waits when he is listening for news from the fort, of a warden dead and a widow holding the seal. The news had not come, so the carts had.

Devan stood under the padippura roof, because he had said he would. Eravi had wanted him in bed, and Janu had wanted him in a chair. He had told them both he would stand in the shade. He had eaten two bowls of rice, drunk a quart of water, and put on a fresh tunic over the binding. The ribs gave a slow, clear ache that was his own, and at his wrists a thin sting that was not. Neela was somewhere up on the west rampart above the chamber window, where the sentry used to stand. The wall bent there toward the gate, and she would see every cart come in. He could not see her.

The sky lay low on the pass. The rain had held off all day, the way an animal holds its breath.

Ittan came on foot beside the lead cart, which he need not have done. He was a round man in good grey cotton, soft-voiced, with rings on three fingers and a clerk at his shoulder carrying a case of tallies. He had a

pleasant face. He had written Devan a kind letter every season for six years, and Devan had kept them all.

He raised both arms from forty paces off.

"My friend!"

He did not slow. He did not check or glance at the gate sergeant. Devan had been braced for the small stumble, the half-breath of a man who had been told that the warden was dying and then finds him standing. It did not come. The step went on over the stones, whole and easy, and the arms came wide, as though Ittan had walked up to a wedding feast and found the groom exactly where a groom should be.

"They said you were poorly," Ittan said, close now, and took Devan's hand in both of his. They were warm and damp. "The whole road said it. I said, no, not our Devan, he is made of laterite. And look at you!"

"A fever," Devan said. "It passed."

"Thanks be." He did not ask which fever. "And the bride? She does not bore you? I have thought of you both, I assure you. A man's first marriage in office, and nobody to tell him what it costs." He laughed. "Pepper never grew in a quiet house."

He smelled of clove, strong, sweet and oily, and it clung to the rings.

"Forgive the scent." Ittan lifted a hand, and the sleeve slid back from a thumb with a stain on it, dull brick red under the nail. "My wife's cough. I've rubbed her chest every night for three winters, and I carry it on me like a sin. The physicians say clove will do her no harm and no good. What shall a man do?"

Clove oil. Brick red, under a thumbnail. Devan knew that colour as he knew his own signet: council wax, poured with clove oil so it would not crack in damp. He set it beside the rest and did not let it reach his face. A man could rub a wife's chest and still handle wax. A man could also be a Keeper whose office held a seal box. It proved nothing. It sat in him like a stone in a boot.

He looked past Ittan at the carts.

Five of them, and the first rode low. Not by much. A carter would not have remarked it. But the axle bowed, and the ox's head hung, and

the wheel cut a groove in the track that the next cart did not. A big chest sat roped under the tarpaulin. A carter walked beside it with one palm laid flat on the lid, the way you rest a hand on an animal you do not want to startle.

On sealing day every cart is opened, in or out. No exception is written for the Keeper.

Not yet. Tomorrow. He needed Ittan under his roof tonight, comfortable and fed and unwatched, and a clerk's tallies still unsorted.

"You've never climbed to Kettamala," Devan said. "You send a clerk."

"Never, yes. Shameful." Ittan beamed and patted the hand he still held. "This year I wished to see how the match had prospered. I proposed it, you know. A matchmaker's vanity."

"The council usually sends a clerk to seal the pass."

"It does."

"Who sends the Keeper, when a clerk would do?"

The smile did not falter. It did something Devan had not seen a smile do. It simply stayed, perfectly kind, and nothing behind it moved at all.

"I am only a hand, my friend," said Ittan, Keeper of the Passes. "Hands go where they're sent."

He pressed Devan's fingers once, warmly, and let them go. He turned to call a servant about the oxen, and the clove drifted off in his wake.

Devan stood and watched the first cart roll in under the padippura roof, low on its axle. A thin line of pain pulled at his right wrist, where her torn one lay bound on the wall above. She had closed her hand.

A hand went where it was sent. He stood very still and wondered whose palm was open.

Chapter 29

The Sealing

"Open them," Devan said. "All five."

The courtyard under the padippura roof went quiet. Rain had started before dawn, a thin grey hiss on the tiles. Sixty soldiers of the garrison stood in the wet with their spears grounded, and nobody moved. The Keeper of the Passes stood by his lead cart in good grey cotton, hands folded over his stomach, smile in place.

"My friend," Ittan said, gently, "surely a courtesy. No warden has opened a Keeper's cart in living memory."

There it was. Ittan was not counting on the law. He was counting on eight years of a man who never struck first, and five of a warden who never once turned his power on anyone. He had walked up the mountain trusting that habit.

"It's the charter." Devan kept his voice level. "On sealing day every cart through the padippura, in or out, is opened and searched. No exception is written for the Keeper. And the same charter says that if the Keeper's seal is found false, the warden closes the pass with his own alone. Gopan has the line ready upstairs. Bhaskaran, start with the second cart."

He had read that line so often the vellum had gone soft at its fold. Now it had to bear weight.

Bhaskaran grunted and went. Two men took the ropes off the second tarpaulin. Salt-fish baskets, a cask of oil, a bundle of folded cloth. They worked down the row.

Devan watched Muthu.

The captain stood at the head of the first cart, where Devan had put him last night with a hand on his shoulder and the word *honour*. His big shoulders were square. Then his eyes went to the lead cart, to the roped chest, and to the Keeper's folded hands. His own hand came up to the rope and stopped there.

He was quiet. Not the flat quiet Devan knew from the pit, the one that came just before a lie. This one had weight in it. It was the quiet of a man holding his breath between two loyalties.

"Captain," Devan said.

"Warden." Muthu's voice came out low. "That's the queen's council. If we put a blade to the Keeper's own boxes without a writ—"

"We have a writ. It's four hundred years old and it hangs in the guardroom." Devan crossed the wet stones and put his hand on the rope beside Muthu's, close enough to feel the man's knuckles. "Open it, Muthu."

Muthu's thumb worked twice at the frayed end of the rope. He glanced at the Keeper, then at Bhaskaran's men already unlacing the second cart, then at Devan's hand. Then the captain's knife went under the rope and cut it.

Devan marked the hand that cut. It was too early to trust it.

*

She came down the west stair while the third cart was being emptied.

Devan saw her first at the stair head, in the ivory kasavu she had worn on their wedding day. Her bound hand closed on the pala rail, and at his right wrist came a thin, warm pull, her torn skin tightening under the cloth. Then she crossed the court with the plain gold bangle riding over the binding. She walked past the soldiers and the Keeper's servants and the grooms crowded at the stable door, and every head turned with her.

The wall was where she had been all morning. It was where she was safe, with an eye on every corner and nobody's gaze on her. He had thought she would stay.

She stopped at his right side, close enough that her sleeve touched his.

"Unni," she said to the thin young guard at the gate, who had gone red to the ears. "Your mother's salt fish. Tell her the warden's wife will take two baskets this week."

"Yes, lady." Unni's voice cracked.

"You could have stayed up there," Devan said, very low.

"I could." She kept her eyes on the Keeper, who had stopped smiling by about a finger's width. "I've watched this fort from the walls for five weeks. I'd like it to see me standing somewhere." A pause. "Beside you, if the warden has no objection."

"None."

"Then that's settled."

Janu stood at the kitchen door with her arms folded. She took one long look at the two of them side by side and went back inside. A minute later a kitchen boy came out with an oiled umbrella and held it over them without a word. Devan found he had nothing to say for a while after that.

*

The chest was in the first cart, as he had known it would be.

It had not left the cart all night. Devan had stood the five carts under the roof, with Bhaskaran's men set round them as a courtesy, to keep the oxen dry and the Keeper's goods from the damp. At the middle watch the clerk had come down with a lantern and a pry-bar and got as far as the chest's ropes before two of Bhaskaran's men took him by the elbows. He talked about a lame ox. He was walked back with many apologies and a cup of hot milk.

Four men lifted the chest down, its iron corners sagging between them. It was teak, as long as a man's arm. The clerk made a thin noise.

The Keeper stepped forward with his hand outstretched, as if to steady it.

"My private papers," he said. "My wife's physicians' accounts. Truly, there are things a man keeps..."

"Then they'll be kept," Devan said, "once they're read."

Bhaskaran broke the lock with the butt of a spear. The lid came up. Folded papers lay on top, bills in a physician's tidy hand, a bundle of letters tied in ribbon. A silver comb. The smell of clove rose out of the chest.

Bhaskaran put his big hand flat on the inner floor and pressed. He rapped it with a knuckle. Then he rapped the outside, low on the wall, and looked up. The sound was different.

"Two hands deeper outside than in, Warden."

"Take it out."

It took a chisel. The false floor came up in one board, and the soldiers who had been leaning on their spears straightened together.

Under it lay split-ash tally sticks in rows, each wrapped in oilcloth. Bhaskaran drew one out and unwrapped it. The stick was blank. No clerk's number, no gate mark. On its end sat a thumb of dull brick wax, pressed with a pepper sprig.

Bhaskaran counted them aloud, because the garrison would want a number. Thirty-six. Beside them, in a cloth bag, lay a flat oilcloth book no bigger than a hand.

Devan took the first stick.

A scrap of beeswax rode in his sleeve, soft from the warmth of his arm, carried five weeks. With it came the second thing, wrapped in a faded red thread: a tally stick with wax on its end, found in a camphorwood chest at the end of the south passage. His sister's *first one*. *Not yet.*

He held them side by side in his palm and let the rain fall on the wax. At the stem of the pepper sprig on each lay the same small private mark, a dot with a split beneath it.

"Dot and split," Bhaskaran said. Then, hoarsely: "That's the mark on the one I passed. But mine had a clerk's number cut in it, and the num-

ber matched a cart on the roll. That's why I stamped it. These have no number at all. I'd never stamp one of these."

"No gate would," Devan said. He turned the blank stick so the soldiers could see its bare end. "A stick with no number is no pass. Unless someone holding Kettamala's seal numbers it and stamps it herself. A widow, in trust, with the Keeper beside her as her kindly adviser, could do all thirty-six in an afternoon. No roll to check them against."

Bhaskaran frowned. "Then what use are they?"

"In a widow's hand, thirty-six open gates."

Somewhere behind him, Unni swallowed.

Devan opened the oilcloth book. The first leaf was dated in the spring. Down the page ran sums in a neat, comfortable hand, with a place-name set beside each, and a word that was a pass and a word that was a fee. It went on for forty leaves. Some of the places were villages on the coast side of the pass. Devan knew the names. He knew which of them had burned.

He looked at the Keeper.

Ittan had not moved. He laid his ringed hand on the rim of the lead cart. "Those are forged, of course," he said. "A man in my office makes enemies. Someone has put them there."

"In the false floor of your own chest."

"I will answer to the queen's council for it."

"You'll answer here first."

*

"There's one more thing."

Neela's voice came quiet at his shoulder, and every soldier in the court heard it. She had a scrap of paper in her fingers, creased and torn along one edge, with a single line of cramped writing on it in black, tacky ink. It was the slip he had given back to her keeping last night, so that her hand would be the one to bring it forward. She held it out to him, not to Ittan.

Devan took it. Muthu stood ten paces off, and whatever was said in this court would go to the palace in a grey-sealed letter as soon as the road opened. So Devan would name only a wife who had brought him a paper, and keep the rest as a debt.

He read it aloud, so that Bhaskaran and Muthu and Unni and the rain would hear.

"*Balance due from the Keeper on the widow's seal.*"

Ittan turned one ring slowly with his thumb.

"My wife brought me this before the new moon," Devan said. "It came off a courier's papers. I'll say no more of whose hands it passed through." He looked at the clerk, who had gone the colour of tallow. "A balance owed by the Keeper. On a widow's seal. What widow, I wondered. I am not dead, and I have no widow."

He drew a folded paper from his sleeve. The marriage writ had come back from Kodiyur in registry blue, handed to a boy at the gate by a man who would not climb to the keep. He had read it three times. He read it once more, aloud.

"*...and the said wife, being lawfully wed, shall hold the pass-seal of Kettamala in trust from the hour of the warden's death, until the council shall name another in his place.*" The paper shook a little in the damp. He steadied it. "That is the clause. A wife holds the seal. No one else."

He folded the writ.

"A man who needed that seal," he said, "would need the warden dead, and a bride to hold it, and an hour alone with the bride. And a man who proposed the match would know the clause was there."

For the first time, Ittan said nothing.

*

It broke slowly, a fine line first.

The kindness stayed on his face, but it stopped meaning anything. His eyes moved from the chest to the soldiers to the clerk and then to Neela. They rested on her for a long time.

"My friend," he said. His voice had no breath in it. "You've thought this through very carefully."

"Since the day my sister found the first one," Devan said. "Bhaskaran. Take his hands."

Bhaskaran stepped forward with a length of cord, and Ittan lifted his hands in a pleasant, tired gesture, as if conceding a point at supper. The clerk bolted two steps and was caught by Unni, who grabbed him by the collar and looked astonished at himself.

Devan said it aloud, in the old words no warden had needed in his time. "By the border charter and by the seal of the warden of Kettamala, I hold Ittan, Keeper of the Passes, for the sale of false tokens to the enemies of Varanad. He will be lodged in the guardroom under guard. Let any who object say so now."

Nobody spoke. Then Bhaskaran's spear butt came down once on the wet stones, and the garrison's followed, sixty of them, a ragged knock like a slow drum. Across the court, Janu had her hand over her mouth.

Ittan walked quietly as the cord went on. He turned his round, pleasant face toward Devan as they led him past, and his voice came clear and soft, the voice of a man giving directions to a stranger.

"You've no idea whose hand I am."

Devan had been told nearly the same thing last night, under this same roof, in warmer light. *I am only a hand, my friend.* Last night it had sounded like modesty. Now it sounded like the answer to a question he had not yet learned to ask.

"Then I'll learn," he said.

"You'll learn what you're permitted." Ittan's eyes slid, once, toward the road beyond the wall, the long road down to the coast. Then he was gone into the guardroom, and Bhaskaran dropped the bar across the door.

Devan stood a moment with his sister's tally in his hand. He had done it in the open, before sixty witnesses, with his name on it. The council would hear of it when the rains broke. There would be a writ, and a rider, and a cost he could not yet count.

His wrist ached. He glanced down. She had put two fingers lightly over the binding on her own.

"You're shaking," she said.

"Some of it's the ribs."

"Not this part." She kept her hand where it was. "I know where the ribs are."

*

The downpour came in full as they climbed to the gate-chamber.

It had been a drizzle all morning. It turned while they were on the stair, with a sound like a hundred horses on a bridge. The gate-chamber sat directly over the padippura, under the same roof, and the rain drummed on it so hard the cistern chain clanked the hour and could scarcely be heard. By the time Devan reached the window, the Monkey Pass had vanished. The road, the cliff and the langurs' tree were gone, and water came off the eaves in a solid sheet.

Gopan had the closing writ ready in its box. The old man's hands were steady, which Devan's were not. Devan had never done this part without the Keeper's own seal beside his own, because it was the Keeper's task to bring the second impression, and the warden's to close. There was no second impression now.

"The single closing stands," Gopan said, before he could ask. "But the line asks for a witness of the warden's house, marked beside the seal, so the council cannot say the warden closed alone."

"Then mark it."

"It must be one who stands in the house." Gopan looked at the writ. He had no need to look at Neela.

Devan took the warden's seal from its cord about his neck. It was an iron disc the size of his palm, cut with a hill and a gate, worn smooth by eleven wardens. His father had worn it. Asha had held it for a week once, as a joke, and their father had taken it back crossly.

"Neela."

She stood at his side. He had not told her to. She looked at the seal in his hand, and he saw that she understood what he was asking before he had asked it. A name beside his, on a crown writ, would go to Kodiyur with the rider. The crown hunted odiyans that no master vouched for, and she was one. Once her name sat on its record, the crown could set it beside the word *rogue* whenever it chose.

"It's yours to press," she said. "I'm only the one who stands here."

"I'd like you to stand here. And write beside it."

She was silent for the length of three clanks. Devan did not look at her face. He watched her hands. The bound one lay flat on the writ to hold it against the damp. The other opened and closed once at her side, then went still.

She took the pen from Gopan, in the grey light, and wrote on the line below his in a small, upright hand. Not a number. Her name, as the fort knew it, and *of Kettamala* after. The pen did not shake.

"Then I will," she said.

He pressed the seal into the wax. It held, dull and black. Gopan took the writ and drew the iron bar across the inner gate, and the bar fell into its sockets with a sound that went down through the stone of the tower and into his boots.

The pass was closed.

Thunder rolled up the gorge. Somewhere below, a road that had been dry that morning began to run as a river. For four months nothing would climb to Kettamala and nothing would go down. No rider, no cart, no writ from Kodiyur. He had a prisoner in the guardroom who knew something he did not, and nobody could reach the man to silence him, or the fort to recall its warden. Someone had sent Ittan up this mountain. Whoever it was, they were still out there beyond the wall, and the weather had just made the distance longer.

He turned to speak to her. She had already put her hand in his, wet and cold, the bangle pressing into his palm. The bound wrist tugged once at his own.

He closed his fingers over hers and held on, and the rain went on falling over the place where the road had been.

Chapter 30

The Tooth

The cistern chain struck for dusk, and Neela lifted the bar off the west shutters herself.

It was heavy teak, black with years of hands. She leaned it against the wall where she had leaned it every dusk since the second night, and she swung both leaves wide. The third slat creaked. Rain blew in at once, a cold fine spray across the floor and her bare feet. The sky beyond was the colour of wet slate. The monsoon had no use for evenings, so it simply went dark.

She did not close them. She did not look at the door or count the steps to it. Six. She knew it was six.

Behind her the bed ropes creaked.

"The bar's off," Devan said.

"It is."

"It's raining in."

"It has been all day." She hooked the cotton curtain back on its peg.

He sat against the wall with a blanket over his knees, which Eravi allowed and Janu did not. His ribs were bound under a clean tunic. Yesterday he had stood in a courtyard and arrested a councillor of Varanad. Tonight he looked like a man wrung out and hung up to dry. A river pebble sat in his palm, and he closed his fingers over it when she turned.

"I'm not turning tonight," she said. "Ammu's resin is in its pouch and it can stay there. I wanted the window open with nothing behind it. Just me, and you, and the rain."

"Your nails."

"Are bad. I'll pay for it." She crossed to the bed and sat on its edge with the open window at her back. For forty days she had never sat with her back to a window at dusk. Her shoulders waited for something to happen to them. Nothing did.

"I owe you a thing," she said. "Two things. The first is smaller."

She opened her fist.

The tooth lay on her palm, yellow as old ivory, as long as her thumb joint. She had unpicked it from her waistband that afternoon with a needle, and the stitches still clung to its root like a stem.

"It came from the House store," she said. "A real one, off a real beast. It was meant to go in your wound. A physician finds a tooth, the fort says a cat, and no one asks why the warden's bride slept through it." She kept her voice level. "I sewed it into my waistband the day I left Kodiyur. I wore it to our wedding."

He looked at it for a long moment.

"Tell me the rest," he said. "All of it. I won't stop you."

So she did.

She told it in order, the way she would have written a report. The contract, and the twelfth place on a list, and what twelve bought: her page burned, her name returned. The pass closing in forty days. A chamber with shutters facing west and a ledge broad enough for a crouching body. How she had counted his guards through the wedding feast while the drums played. How the House sent a tin of sweets before every kill and called it luck. Chathu's last message: if the pass closed with the account open, he would force the resin and read her page aloud at dusk.

"I didn't know who bought it," she said. "The House never tells. I learned it was Ittan from a slip of paper. That's why it's his name I gave you."

"I know."

"That's this one," she said. "There were eleven before it. You can have those too, one at a time, if you ask."

"I'll ask."

"I never did it. I want you to hear that I never did it, and also that I meant to. Both are true." Her thumb moved on the tooth. "The first week I stood over you with a knife in reach, and I wasn't thinking of you. I was thinking of a number. I'd been a number for twenty-one years."

"And now?"

"Now I'm in a window with the shutters open." Her mouth twisted. "You'll have to take that as an answer."

"I'll take it." He held out his hand. "May I?"

She tipped it into his palm. He turned it to the lamp and closed his fingers around it, and the point went into the pad of his thumb.

A bead of red came up on his skin. At the same instant a sharp sting opened on her own thumb, and a thin welt rose, bright as a thread.

They looked at each other.

"You did that on purpose," she said.

"I did not."

She held her thumb up beside his. Same thumb. Same joint. The same red bead, a hand's width apart. "Put it somewhere safe, Devan. Somewhere that isn't your hand."

He wrapped it in a corner of the blanket. Then he went still.

"Ask your question," he said. "You've been carrying one since the second day."

*

She had not known he knew.

"You never answered," she said. "When I asked why you bar the shutters, you said 'rain.' And the next dusk you said it again. It was clear sky from here to the sea."

"It wasn't an answer. I knew it wasn't. It was the closest I had to quiet." He turned the wrapped tooth over once. "I still have my one refusal in the question game. I'll not use it tonight."

"Then why?"

"I'd decided before I picked up the bar on the second dusk." His voice was even. "Whatever I'd seen, I would not use it. Not on you, not for the council, not to bargain. Barring the shutters was how I kept that true. I wanted to be the only one who carried it, so no one else could set it down on you."

"You didn't tell me."

"I didn't know how to say it so you'd believe it." His voice was dry. "You'd just spent the evening counting my doors."

She laughed, and it hurt, and she let it. Rain ran in at the sill and found the back of her neck. She did not shift away from it.

"Ask me another," she said. "Your turn."

"Do you want to know when I stopped being wary of you?"

"Were you wary?"

"Yes. For about eleven days. Do you want to know when it stopped?"

"I do."

"You came down the north steps while I drilled." He held her gaze. "Dawn, the pit lamps still lit. I had my back to you, and I knew the step. You put your fingers at the base of my skull, there." He touched his own nape, just under the bone. "A thumb's width below it. The old masters call it the door."

Her mouth went dry.

"Your fingertips were cold," he said. "The first one settled in the notch and my pulse jumped against it. I couldn't have told you what else was in the pit. Then you counted."

"One," she said. She had not known she would say it aloud.

"One. I counted with you. At one I kept my shoulders loose, and that took everything I had. At two your thumb shifted a hair, to the true place, and I thought: she knows exactly where it is. At three I stopped counting. I was standing on both feet with my eyes open, and I did not

want to turn." He rubbed the nape as if it still held the print. "Then your hand lifted, and the air came onto the skin where it had been. You told me my guard dropped on the left."

"It did."

"It does. I've been working on it."

"I pulled it," she said slowly. "Three breaths is how long it takes to be sure. I used them up on you and on nothing else. I counted so there'd be an end to it."

"I know. I felt where the end was." His eyes didn't leave hers. "I was tired of being the wall. I stood there and thought, let her. I had a great deal of reasoning about you by then. Reasoning is not knowing. That was the morning I knew you wouldn't do it in the dark."

"And still you offered me a bargain in the storm."

"Yes. Knowing you wouldn't kill me isn't the same as trusting you with the name. I was wrong to make you pay for it."

She had nothing ready to say. No one had ever told her what he had seen when she thought no one was watching, and then told her where he had been wrong, with neither one a bill.

*

"I thought it would be a leash," she said.

Her voice came out strange. She went on anyway.

"Chathu watched me turn the first time, and every night after that I was a thing someone could say a word over. Ammu saw it too. Ammu never said it. But I never stopped knowing she could." She pressed her thumb to the welt.

"I've had forty days to say it," Devan said. "I never will."

"I know. That's what I'm telling you." She looked at him: the bound ribs, the bruised hands, the pebble he had forgotten in his fist. Behind her the window stood open on the dark. "There's rain on my neck and a man who's seen all of me, and I'm not counting the door."

"Six," Devan said.

"Six," she agreed. "You've known it was six all along."

"Since the first night."

"You put a stone in your cheek every resin night since the rampart. So a sleeper's mouth wouldn't slip."

"It was a small thing."

"It wasn't." She took his hand off the blanket. "Yesterday you took the warden's power and used it, in front of sixty soldiers, on a councillor of the realm. I watched your face. I expected you to come back colder."

"I thought if I ever used it, I'd become what used it on Asha." His thumb moved across her knuckles. "Nothing since has made me less myself. I think that's you, not me. Your name stands beside my seal on the writ. I wasn't alone with it."

"No," she said. "You weren't."

His hand stayed over hers. That was the comfort. He had never pretended to offer another kind.

*

She had meant to say it carefully. She had practised on the ride and on the stair and while she unpicked the tooth. In the end it came out the way things came out of her now, which was plainly.

"I love you."

His fingers tightened on hers once.

"I don't know when it started. I could name a night. I could name a morning, but I'd be guessing." The rain was loud on the sill. "You asked once what I wanted, and I said to be left alone, and that was a lie. I wanted somebody to leave the shutters open and not look. I'd have said it was the worst thing a person could want."

"It's not."

"I know. You taught me. I love you, Devan."

He took his time. She watched him choose the words.

"I love you," he said. "I said it to my sister, badly, in the kitchen, the week before she died. I haven't said it to anyone since. I don't say a thing I haven't measured. I've measured this one for a long time."

"Say it again," she said unsteadily. "So I can check."

"I love you."

"It holds."

"It does." The corner of his mouth moved. "Neela is the only name you've given me. It's the one I'll use until you give me another."

"Then use it," she said. "I'll tell you when there's a second."

Then she kissed him, in the open window at dusk, with the shutters wide and the rain on her back and the dark coming up the gorge. He kissed her back and winced once against her mouth. A thread of heat pulled along her left ribs, which was his, and she drew back and laughed against his cheek.

"Sit still. You're bleeding on both of us."

"Unavoidable." He leaned his forehead on hers. "I think I'll learn it."

*

It was a long time before she said the last of it. She had to say it to the lamp first, and then to the floor. Her hand went to the pouch at her waist, to the small hard thumb of Ammu's resin, and rested there.

"I want to ask you for something."

"Ask."

"You've never had to say yes to me. Nobody has. You made your vow at sunset with a council behind you, and I made mine under a name that wasn't mine, with a knife in my cloth." She made herself lift her eyes. "I want to be married to you. Not because I was sold. I want a morning one."

He was quiet.

"Tomorrow, at noon," she said. "In the courtyard. In front of Janu, and Muthu, and Kannan and the goat. Rain or none. With my own words, and every person in this house standing there who's ever carried my water." Her fingers closed on the pouch. "Ammu should have been at my first one. She'll hear this one."

"Neela." He did not say it gently. He said it exactly. "Muthu will stand in that courtyard. Whatever you say goes into a grey-sealed letter. It waits for the road, and then it goes to the palace, to whoever reads

them. Your own words, in your own voice. Ittan said I'd no idea whose hand he is. Someone will want to know whose hand you are."

"I know."

"You've spent your whole life keeping your name off paper."

"And you watched me put it on the sealing writ, beside yours." Her voice caught, and she let it. "Ten days ago I wouldn't have. They'll write it either way. I'd rather they copy something I said. I've never asked anyone for a thing I couldn't take. I'm asking."

"You are." He looked at her as he looked at weather, closely and with respect. "I'd have said yes from the second word, you know. I was waiting to see the third."

"You were not."

"I was. I've been waiting to see the third word of everything you say for six weeks." His hand turned under hers and held it, palm to palm, the bangle between them. "Yes. Noon. I'll stand where you tell me."

"You'll stand next to me."

"Then tell me what you'll say."

"You'll hear it at noon," she said, "with everyone else."

He studied her a moment. Then he nodded slowly. "With the cook, then. And the goat."

"With the goat."

The lamp burned low. Beyond the shutters the last grey went out of the sky, and she sat with her back to the dark and the dark did nothing, because nothing in it could be said against her now without her own voice.

Far below, across the wet court, one window still showed light. The guardroom lamp. Ittan was awake down there, with four months of rain between him and any rider, and nothing to do but wait for whatever he knew to be asked of him.

Her fingers found the pouch again. Tomorrow at noon she would say her name in front of Muthu. Tomorrow at dusk she would open this and turn in front of Devan on purpose, and at dawn she would have to turn back where he could see.

She watched the small yellow light until the rain blurred it. She did not count the door.

Chapter 31

Daylight Vows

At noon the sky hung low and dark as a wet plum, and Neela walked out into the courtyard with nothing in her hands.

No knife in her cloth. No flask in a fold. She wore the ivory kasavu again, its gold border dulled by two days of damp, and the plain bangle on her wrist. She counted the first ten steps from the west stair and then stopped counting.

They had all come. The garrison stood in lines with spears grounded, sixty men and the rain not yet falling. Janu waited at the kitchen door, arms folded. Chinna leaned beside her on her bad hip. Kannan held Pepper on a rope, and the goat chewed something it should not have. Muthu stood at the front of the soldiers, big and quiet, with his hands behind him.

Devan waited under the padippura edge, where the rain could reach them if it chose. He wore a plain grey tunic, and his hands were clasped hard in front of him. As she crossed the stones he said nothing. When she reached the tenth step his hands came apart and hung open at his sides.

She stopped beside him and turned to face the fort.

"I am Neela," she said.

Her voice carried too well in the wet air. She let it.

"I came to this house sold, and I didn't mean to stay. I say that first because I've stood in your kitchens and your yard and not told you the

truth, and I'd like to start clean." She found Muthu's face. He did not look away. "I'm going to say my own vow. Nobody wrote it for me."

Nobody coughed. Far off, thunder walked along the ridge.

"Two people should be here and aren't. Raiu, who was nineteen, with a cowlick that wouldn't lie down. He held the torch outside my door and never once asked what I was doing awake." Unni breathed in sharply. "And Ammu, who was my sister. She hummed when she was frightened and she was frightened most of her life. She is dead, and I'll say her name in the open as long as I have a mouth. Raiu. Ammu."

The yard took the names and kept them. Somewhere in the silence the first drops began, fat and slow on the stones. Nobody moved.

"Now the living. Janu, who scolds me and feeds me anyway. Chinna, who has a wager she won't show anyone. Kannan. Pepper, who bites. Gopan, who has kept every hour for nineteen years bar one. Bhaskaran. Unni, whose mother sells salt fish, and I'll buy it. Eravi. Muthu, who rides when he's asked." She went on. She had learned them all, the way she learned every house, and she said every one. Grooms. The woman who turned the wash. The two brothers on the south wall who argued about dice. It took a long time. Nobody shifted their feet, and the rain thickened over them.

"That's my house," she said. "I was given a number for twenty-one of my twenty-seven years. Here I have names, and I mean to keep every one."

She turned to Devan.

"I take you as my husband, in daylight, with my own mouth. I won't leave you in the dark, and I won't be left there."

He drew a breath.

"I'll stand where there's room for two," he said. "I won't lie to you. What you give me, I won't hold over you." His eyes didn't leave her. "Ever."

That was all. She had been promised things before, by people who wanted something. Nobody had ever promised her less than he meant.

*

Janu wept first. She wept loudly, with her apron up, and complained in the same breath.

"Rain on a wedding. *Rain!* I said it would turn, I said it to Chinna at the well, and who listens? Nobody. And you in silk in this damp, you'll take a chill, and he'll take it after, and I'll be nursing the pair."

"Janu," Neela said.

"Don't *Janu* me." She seized Neela's face in both wet hands and kissed her hard on the forehead. Then she was gone, and the kitchen door banged.

Food arrived within the quarter hour. Rice cakes, a fish curry with the pepper turned up, plantain fried in ghee, a jar of sweet payasam that two boys carried between them. Devan was handed a third helping before he had finished the second.

"I'm full," he said.

"A man of thirty-two should know when to eat," Janu said, reappearing at his elbow. "And you don't. You're a wall. Walls eat."

Neela caught his sleeve while the court roared at that. "I had a line about teeth," she said low. "For the end. I cut it on the stair."

"I heard you cut it." He did not turn his head. "It would have been accurate."

"It would have been too much."

"That too."

Chinna cornered her at the trestle with her hip jutting. "I'll tell you now, nobody won the wager. Damp-madness, privacy, Janu's old tale, every one was wrong. I'm keeping the stakes." She looked at Neela sidelong. "I'll not ask what was right."

"Good."

"I'm not stupid, lady."

"I know," Neela said. "I learned your name first."

Unni was crying quietly into a rice cake. Bhaskaran put a heavy hand on the boy's neck and left it there. Someone started a coastal song, badly, and halfway through the second line it cracked in the middle, because it was Ammu's, or near enough, and Neela had hummed it in the yard that

morning without noticing. She stood with her throat shut. Then Kannan fed Pepper a whole plantain, the goat took his sleeve with it, and the court roared again. She laughed until it hurt. The grief didn't leave. It sat on the same bench as the laughing, and neither moved over.

Muthu found her last, with a bowl he wasn't eating from.

"Lady." His big voice was low. "I'll have to write this down."

"I know."

"I'll write the weather."

She studied him. He had gone very quiet, and she knew now what that meant on him. He was lying. He would write every word she had said, the names, all of it, and he could not look at her while he promised otherwise.

Letting him keep the lie would have been kinder, and it would have cost her nothing today.

"Then write my name spelled right," she said.

His eyes came up. For a moment the big face had nothing on it at all.

"Lady—"

"Two e's. Clerks always drop one. Then an l, then an a." She took the bowl out of his hands and put a rice cake in it. "Eat. You'll want your strength for the pen."

He ate. He did not say the weather again.

*

By dusk the rain had settled to a steady fall, and the chamber smelled of wet laterite and lamp oil.

Devan had opened the shutters before she came up. He had set a covered dish and a cup at the foot of the bed, and a folded cloth beside them. She looked at those a moment. She had never told him what the morning after cost her. He had watched her come back shaking from the ledge, every dawn, and noticed.

She stood at the window with her back to the room.

"Ready?" he said.

"No." She smiled at the dark. "Yes."

The thumb of Ammu's resin lay in her palm, hard and black, smelling of scorched tamarind. She pared a little with her nail and warmed it between her fingers. Then she turned around and looked straight at him, because the rule wanted a face and she wanted him to have hers.

"I'm going to do it where you can see," she said. "I'm not hiding it. I don't want you looking through your lashes."

"You knew about the lashes."

"I count your breathing. I'm not blind."

His mouth moved. "Then look at me."

She smeared it on her throat, over the pale ridged scars, and on the inner wrist of each arm. The burn came up bright and clean. She kept her eyes on his. Ammu had put this in her hands. It tasted of her.

The pull started at the base of her spine. She went down on the broad sill on her palms. Bone slid. The room swung sideways into smell: rain, wet stone, lamp oil, the wound-salt of his ribs, and his steady heart, which didn't speed. The last thing she saw as a woman was his face, wide open, with no fear in it.

Then she was low and spotted on the sill, and he was breathing slowly across the room.

He crossed to her. He took the river pebble from his cheek and set it on the sill beside her paw, and the small wet click of it was loud.

"I won't need it," he said. "It takes both our voices now, and one of them's yours. But I'll keep it." His fingers closed over it again, and he put it in his sleeve. "It got us through a hard month."

She looked at him, and he looked back.

"Not the cat," he said. "Neela."

She pushed her head into his hand. He let it be as heavy as it wanted.

*

The bed took her with a groan. She lay along his right side, away from the bound ribs, with her chin on his thigh and her tail over his feet. He lay back in the lamplight with the curtain tied wide and the rain coming

in on the sill, and he talked a while to the ceiling, low and without hurry, about nothing. Pepper. The fourteen hounds. A cousin's boat.

Then his breath slowed. A third of the way through each long count it hitched, small and true. She listened to it all night and let it be the only thing she counted.

Near the middle watch, a low voice came at the door, and a boot shifted on the boards. Unni, she thought, by the step. Devan rose without a sound, spoke three words through the gap, and the latch fell again. She filed it with the watch changing and turned her ear back to the rain.

Later he went to the brazier. She heard the coals stir. When he came back he sat awhile on the bed's edge with the folded cloth in his hands, turning it to the heat, and he did not lie down again. He was awake when the window greyed.

*

First light came grey and wet.

The pull in her spine woke her before she saw it. His arm was already round her, and he drew her up against his chest as the fur went out of her and the bones came apart. It hurt as it always hurt. She did not climb the ledge and she did not go to the cleft under the spur. She turned back in his arms, with her face in his throat, and let him see every part of it.

He had seen it before, from across the room. It was the first time she had let anyone watch it.

Then she was a woman again, shaking, hollow to the root, and cold as a stone in a stream. The cloth was round her before she knew he had moved, and it was warm to the core. The dish was in his hands. She ate two mouthfuls of rice and curd with her teeth chattering on the spoon, and he held the cup and said nothing at all. Rain pattered on the sill.

"That's it?" she said, when she could. Her voice was scraped. "That's the thing I've hidden since I was sixteen?"

"That's it."

"It's ugly."

"It's you," he said, and he did not say it as a compliment. He said it as a count.

Then he drew a slow breath, and she knew the sound of him choosing words.

"There's something I held back from the room. I didn't want it in here at dawn."

She waited.

"At the middle watch it was Unni at the door. Ittan woke in the guardroom and asked for the warden. Only me. He says he'll tell me whose hand he is." His voice stayed level. "I sent Unni to Bhaskaran with an order: nobody goes into that room until I come. Bhaskaran will hold it against anyone but Muthu. He's Bhaskaran's captain, and I can't order a sergeant to bar him without telling the fort why."

"And Muthu knows about the grille and the lamp."

"Muthu knows the guardroom has a prisoner. I'd have gone down myself. I wanted you to turn back first." He held her gaze. "You're giving up something if you keep me here. Ittan talked at night, and he is the sort who thinks better of it by morning. If I'd gone then, I'd have had the first word with him. Now Muthu could be at that door before me. It's your hour. Say go, and I go."

She looked at the grey square of the window. Ittan had a wife, and a cart with a false bottom, and six years of other people's deaths on his books. Now he wanted to talk, and the want might not last the morning.

The confession was hers to spend, and she was spending it on this hour. She knew the price, and she paid it.

"Asha waited six years," she said. "Ittan can wait an hour. Muthu may reach him first. I know that, and I'm saying stay."

The spoon clicked against the dish as she set it down. Neither of them had ever done this in daylight with the shutters open and nothing owed. Her hand found the knot of the cloth at her shoulder and undid it.

"Lie back," she said.

His brows went up. "Neela, the ribs—"

"I know exactly where the ribs are." She pushed him gently down by the breastbone and swung a knee over him, careful of the left side. The cloth slid off her. The cold air touched her and she barely noticed. "I'm leading. Tell me if it pulls."

"It'll pull."

"Then say so."

"I'll say so." His hands came up and rested on her hips and stayed there, waiting. She had never been waited for. She bent and kissed him, slowly, and his hands tightened.

He kissed her throat next. He found the ridged scar there with his mouth, the pale rope of it, and went along it as if reading. Then he took her wrist and turned it and kissed the inside, where the resin had burned her for eleven years. The torn red line was still healing, and a matching one on his own wrist pulled in answer. A tremor went through him. "Does it hurt?"

"No." His mouth moved against the skin. "It's yours. I'm only holding it."

She had to close her eyes.

Her fingers found his ribs after that, the puckered white seam from the ford and the newer cut over it, healing. Beneath her own left breast lay its twin, a thin pink welt like a drawn thread. She laid her palm over his and her thumb across hers, and they matched. "Look at that," she said unevenly.

"I see it."

She moved on him then, slow, with her hands flat on his chest, and he gasped her name against her collarbone. She learned the pace. When she went too fast he said, "Left," once, low, and she shifted, and the pull in his side eased. Under her palms she counted his breath, as she had every night for six weeks. In for four, out for four. Midway through each long count it hitched, small and true, and she waited for it and it came. She lost the next number. She didn't go looking for it. For the first time since she was six years old, she stopped counting.

The rain was loud on the roof and the shutters stood wide, and he watched her face the whole time. When she came it was long and shaking, and she said his name into the damp air and had no number for it. He followed with his forehead against her breastbone and her fingers in his hair.

Afterward she lay on him, listening to his heart come down.

"I'm not hurting you."

"You are." His chest moved under her cheek. "I wouldn't change it."

*

The rain was still coming down when they spoke again. Neither had pulled the blanket up. It had stopped mattering.

"The hounds can run the yard again," Devan said. "Loose, the way it was."

"They'll bark at the cat."

"They'll learn her."

She laughed into his shoulder. His fingers moved idly on her back.

"The pass stays shut till the rains break. The wood road is lower. Bhaskaran's men got water through it before the rain closed it for a few days, and it opens again between downpours. Muthu takes the second run to the Resin House in three days, with fodder." He paused. "I thought you might want to send something."

Her breath caught. "Water for the end cages. A clean cloth for Kirri's cage. She wears a silver anklet. Nobody takes it off her. Don't open any of them."

"I won't."

"I don't know what I'm asking."

"A cloth." He said it like a plain fact. "I can do a cloth."

She lay quiet. Muthu would drive that cart. Muthu, who had stood in the yard at noon and promised the weather, and would write her name spelled right. She was handing Kirri's last scrap of dignity to the man who reported her. She knew it, and she let it be a choice anyway. There was nobody else with a cart.

"What do we do with four months?" she asked.

"Eat what Janu gives us. Teach Kannan to spar." He turned his head on the pillow to look at her. "Open the shutters at dusk."

"And at the end?"

"Ask me then." He touched the bangle at her wrist.

She sat up, holding the cloth to her, to find the hour by the light. Through the open shutter the wet court lay grey and shining. Across it, under an oilcloth held over his head, Muthu was walking toward the guardroom door. In his other hand he carried a packet sealed in plain grey wax, and it was thicker than any month's letter had ever been.

"Devan," she said.

He was already beside her at the sill. Muthu's voice came across the stones, big and easy, made to carry. "Post for the spring rider, Bhaskaran. Pass is shut. It waits with the warden's box till the rains break, same as every year."

Bhaskaran stood at the door with his spear grounded and his orders. The spear shifted. He said something short, and shook his head once.

Muthu said something back, low. He was the warden's second, and no one else in the fort was.

Bhaskaran looked across the court at the open shutter, at the warden standing in it, and at the packet. Then he stepped aside.

The door opened, and took Muthu in.

Chapter 32

The Queen's Seal

The records room at Kettamala had no window, and the rain made it darker anyway. Devan lit a second lamp and shut the door on the clerk.

Ittan's effects lay on the long table in the order Bhaskaran's men had unpacked them. Two saddlebags. A writing case of tooled leather. Seven good shirts, which Janu had counted with disgust. A silver comb. A small brass box of clove oil, half used.

An hour ago Ittan had sat behind the guardroom grille with his tea going cold in his lap. He had been shaved. He had looked like a man at a wedding feast who had heard bad news. Devan had asked what he meant to tell.

You've no idea whose hand I am, my friend, Ittan had said.

That was all. Devan had stood there while the cistern chain clanked twice, and Ittan had looked at the wall. The man who had begged for the warden at the middle watch had thought better of it by morning, as Neela had said he might. The hour was gone, and Muthu had walked through it. At the last Ittan had asked only whether his wife's cough medicine could be sent on.

Neela had spent that hour on purpose, knowing what it cost. Devan did not mean to make her sorry for it.

The grey packet sat in the hall strongbox with the rest of the post for the spring rider. Muthu had come out of the guardroom still carrying it,

and Devan had held out a hand in front of Bhaskaran and half the yard. "That goes in with the others." Muthu had shrugged, big and easy, and said that was where it went every year. Devan had locked it in and put the key back on his cord. The wax was whole. Muthu believed his letters were as safe as ever.

Devan took the tally book first. He had read it once already and read it again. Forty leaves of dated sums, pass place-names, tokens sold by the dozen to men with no names. Beside the sums, in the same tidy hand, were the prices of fire. A village on the coast side. A ford. The sums were small, and they were everywhere.

He set it down and opened the writing case.

The letter lay on top, unsealed, half finished. *To the physicians attending my wife in Kodiyur.* He read it standing.

Boil the willow bark, do not steep it. She does not say when the cough is bad, so judge by the cup in the morning. If she asks for me, tell her the road is long and I am well. I send forty measures more with this rider. If it is not enough, write and say so, and do not tell her it was ever a question.

Below that, in a shakier hand, a line scratched out and written again: *She likes the window open when it rains.*

He had spent six years wanting the throat of whoever bought Asha, and a few weeks knowing it was this one. This was a husband's letter, specific and tender. It changed nothing Ittan had done. Asha lay under the same stones regardless. But Devan noted it, as Neela would have noted a goat-boy's name, and set it aside with care. A man could do both. That was the worst of it.

Under the letters lay a flat bundle wrapped in oilcloth and tied with red thread.

He knew the thread. Asha's notes had been tied in it.

Red thread was cheap. He told himself so as he worked the knot. Inside were two papers.

The first was a strip of pale hide, two fingers wide, stamped with a mark he had seen once on a seized courier's letter in a classroom twelve years back. A resin-ink bar and a circle. Under it, a brief line in a fine,

careful hand: *Contract: the warden of Kettamala. In his chamber. By beast. Before the closing of the pass.* The signing mark needed no explaining. It was Chathu's.

The guild's chit. His own death, written down like a delivery of salt.

He laid it flat. His hand was steady. He had known for forty days that someone had bought this. Knowing it and holding the receipt were different things.

The second paper was a writ.

It was good cream paper, heavy as cloth, folded in thirds. *To the Resin House of the Blackbark Wood, in payment of the account of the warden of Kettamala, the sum of* and then a number in pepper weights that made him sit on the edge of the table. It was dated seven weeks before the wedding. Underneath, a closed hand had signed with a flourish he did not recognise.

Below the signature was the seal.

Green wax. A small bird pressed into it, wings spread, the long curved beak of a sunbird. He raised the writ to his face and breathed. Crushed leaf, with no clove in it anywhere.

He did not need to compare. He did it anyway, because he was a man who measured. From his sleeve, wrapped in a scrap of linen, he drew the cut seal off the palace wedding gift. It had been there since the sandalwood box came up the road with its silver betel set and its courteous note, and Janu had wanted the thing hung in the hall for the honour.

He laid the two side by side under the lamp.

Same wings. Same chip at the left tip, where the matrix had flawed. Same smell of leaf. The one on the writ was fuller and brighter, because nobody had prised that one off a knot of cord to open a gift.

Rain ran in the gutters above. Somewhere a door shut.

The queen had sent the box herself, with her blessing on the match. He had locked it in the granary because he did not trust gifts from the palace, and kept the seal because he kept everything. He had never once thought to read that seal as evidence.

I proposed the bride, Ittan had said, *out of vanity.* Genial, over wine. A hand. Only a hand.

Devan folded the chit and the writ into the oilcloth and tied the red thread round them. He did not take them to Bhaskaran, or the clerk, or the strongbox. He left the records room with the bundle in his bare hand and went up the wet stair, and the rain ran in under the arch and soaked his shoulders.

*

Neela was in the warden's chamber with a bowl of rice and the window open. Her hair was still damp from the wash-house. When the door opened she looked up.

He was wet to the skin. Rain darkened his tunic from collar to belt and dripped from his cuffs onto the boards. The oilcloth bundle in his hand was tied with a soldier's knot, pulled tight. It was a knot for something he meant to keep from the weather.

She put the bowl down.

"You came straight here," she said.

"I didn't stop for a coat."

That was all. She looked at the wet prints behind him on the boards, and did not ask where else he might have taken it first.

"Read it with me," he said, and set the bundle on the bed between them. "Everything. I'll say what I think after."

She untied the red thread and spread the oilcloth. Her fingers went still on the hide strip.

"That's Chathu's mark."

"It names the chamber."

"Yes." Her voice had gone flat. She counted something, one, two, three, four, and stopped. "This is how it comes down to the shed. A strip like this, a mark. They give it to me at the stone, and I burn it. The House keeps the other half."

"This is the half the buyer holds."

She lifted the writ. She read the number and the date, and then the smell reached her and her head came up. "That's leaf. That isn't clove."

"Look at the seal."

She turned it to the lamp. He unwrapped the linen from the second piece and laid it beside it, and she bent so close her breath stirred the wax.

"The gift," she said.

"The gift."

"You kept it."

"I thought it was too fine to throw away." His mouth went crooked at his own answer. "She sealed the box with her own hand and the writ with her own hand. It's the same hand, Neela."

She laid both papers flat on the quilt. The blow did not land as a flinch. It came slowly, like a count run to its end.

"So it wasn't Ittan's money. He carried the purse."

"He carried it. She paid." He slowed, the way he did on a bad step. "Eight weeks before the wedding I wrote to the council that the raiders' tallies carried true wax, and asked to see every seal register. I know now where those registers lead. To Ittan's box. He didn't need to act on his own. She acted within days, because I was closing on him."

"Then the queen of Varanad bought one of us to kill her own border warden." Neela's mouth twisted. "And sent you a betel set for the wedding."

"With her blessing."

"A tin of sweets before every contract. I learned what a gift is, Devan. It's the start of a bill." She laughed once, short and horrible. "She sent the gift, the bill and the knife in the same season."

He reached across and took her hand. Hers was cold. For a while they sat with the papers between them, and neither tried to make the thing smaller than it was.

She sat back and reached for a question, because questions were what she did with a blow.

"If the crown paid the guild, what else does the queen own?"

"The passes," he said. "Ittan sold tokens on her council's wax. The raider scouts carried new Varanad silver, straight from the mint. I thought a councillor had stolen the coin. I may have been wrong about what was stolen."

"And the House." She stared at the sunbird. "Chathu told me in the kennels the ledger wasn't the only book. I took it for a boast. I think he was telling me what he'd already sold." Her thumb found the welt on the other thumb. "If she pays the guild, she can read the guild. She knows my number. She knows what Ammu was. She might know Kirri."

"She'll have your name. You signed the closing writ, 'of Kettamala'. It goes to her desk with the first rider."

Neela went still. Then she almost smiled. "I was a line in a bill. Now I'm a line in hers."

"You were never a line. You were the one thing in any of this I didn't have to guess at."

She looked at him a long moment. "Say it again."

"You were never a line. You were the one thing in any of this I didn't have to guess at."

"Same words," she said. "Same order. Nothing added the second time, and nothing left out." She breathed out. "All right. I can think now."

"Then think. You're the only person I know who could plan a fight against her."

That caught. Her eyes came up, dark and bright together, and she had stopped looking at the walls. She had found a door.

"Who else has seen this?"

"No one. He wouldn't say. Bhaskaran's men never untied it."

"Then he kept it to bargain with. A man doesn't keep the crown's receipt unless he's afraid of it." She nodded slowly. "He's afraid for his wife. If he talks at all, she'll know."

She bent over the papers. "We keep these where nobody finds them. Not Muthu. Not the strongbox, with his packet in it. He's stood beside that lid for years."

"Not the granary."

"Not the granary." She went to the shutters and ran her thumb along the frame behind the third slat. There was a hollow where the housing had shrunk from the wood. "Here. It creaks, and a creak is a good watchman."

They fitted the strip, the writ and the seal back inside the oilcloth. He tied the red thread. She tied it a second time, harder, as if the knot could close a door.

*

Nine days into the rains, the cart came back from the Resin House mud to the axle, and Muthu with it.

Neela was in the hall mending a bow string for no reason except to keep her hands busy. The brazier hissed. Devan stood at the long table with a map of the wood road under his palm. In nine days neither of them had said what they were thinking.

Muthu stood dripping. He did not take the stool Janu pushed at him.

"The cattle are fed," he said. "Water in the end cages. Clean straw." He looked at Neela and did not smile. "I laid the cloth in the civet's cage myself. She didn't move. Then she put her nose against it and lay down on it."

Her throat shut. "The anklet?"

"Still on. I didn't touch it."

"Thank you."

"Lady." He seemed about to say a great deal and said, "There was a man in the yard. The old master. He came out of the cook-house when the cart rolled in and stood on the step in the rain. He had a book under his arm, held to his chest like a baby. Black cover. He never put it down. When I looked at him he nodded, polite as a priest, and went back in. Pachan stood behind him with a pole."

"The ledger," Neela said.

"I don't know what it was. I know he didn't let go of it." He shifted. "I'll be at the stable."

He went. The door banged in the wind. He had gone off to the wood on a plain order, fodder and water, three days after the vow, and he came back as easy with the warden as ever. Whatever he had been told to watch for, he had seen nothing in the hall to suit it.

At the far end of the table stood the iron-bound strongbox, its lid shut. Neela looked at it. Inside lay a packet in grey wax, thicker than any month's letter, the seal whole, in with the rest of the spring post where Muthu had watched it go. She thought: *Leave the wax whole. Let him think he's unread, and let the rider carry it south when the roads open.* She did not say it aloud. Devan's eyes went to the lid and back, and that was the same answer.

Then she looked at the strip of black beyond the open door, where the wood road ran down into the rain.

"Chathu's keeping every page where he can touch it," she said. "He knows we know where it is. He'll know the queen's paid his bill." She laid the bow down. "I'm going to take it, Devan."

He did not ask what. He did not tell her it was madness, or that the roads were shut, or that they would be two against a House of hunters. He studied the map as he studied a weather sign, with respect.

"If you take a book that makes you a master," he said. "Every page in it. Whoever holds it."

"I know what it makes me." Her voice was quiet. "I don't know yet how to hold it and not be it. But I'm going to take it."

"Then I'll come."

He said it as he had said *noon* and *yes*, with no weight at all. She felt the room settle. Rain went on falling.

"Say what it costs," she said. "Out loud. I want it said."

He didn't pretend. "A warden who rides off to rob a guild in the middle of the rains."

"The fort," she said. "Sixty men who'll wonder where you are. The office, when the queen hears who took the book. She'll have my name with the first rider, Devan. Soon she'll have yours beside it."

"I know the price."

"Then you're a fool."

"Yes." His hand turned under hers, palm up, and held on.

She took his hand off the map and kept it. Four months, she thought, and began to count.

Also by Anya Kalloor

The Odiyan Contracts

1. *Vow of Teeth* (this book)
2. *Oath of Claws*
3. *Crown of Night*

Coming next

The pass is sealed. For four months Kettamala is cut off from the world, and nobody can ride in or out.

Neela has no guild, no page and no way home. She has a husband who shares every wound she takes, and a silver anklet in her memory that she promised to send home in a fish basket. Somewhere in the Blackbark Wood, a soft-voiced old man holds a black book with her whole life written in it. Forty-two animals in cages still have minds behind their eyes, and every day the minds fade a little more.

Devan has the queen's seal on a payment writ, the fort's loyalty for as long as the snow lasts, and a promise he made in daylight: he will go where she goes.

The ledger is the only thing that can free them. It is also the thing that makes a master of whoever holds it. One page read aloud at dusk, and a woman is a leash in someone's hand. Neela has spent her life on the wrong end of that.

She knows exactly how the guild is guarded. He knows exactly how a fort falls. Neither of them knows what the pages will do to the one who carries them out.

The rains will not last forever. When the pass opens, the palace will read what has been written in this fort.

Can they steal the guild's ledger without becoming its new masters?